**Bright Moon Coffee Co.**

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# Bright Moon Coffee Co.

by IorekoftheHorde

Summary

Catra is, begrudgingly, a barista. But recently, a certain blonde has been unintentionally shining a light on her uneventful life.

Notes

This was some brain rot I had a while ago.
Catra was monologuing in my head and wouldn't shut up so I started writing it down and it turned into this.
It's technically a one-shot but I'm not opposed to continuing it in the future, it could literally go in any direction...

See the end of the work for more notes

# Chapter 1

Goddamn it.

Despite the god-awful weather, the thundering rain battering on the windows, the rush of people forcing their way in through the poor automatic doors as the storm hit, Catra found herself frozen to the spot once again staring at the most radiant smile she's ever seen. *That blonde* was standing across the counter, once again ordering the same black coffee she's been ordering for the past month, and once again making Catra weak at the knees by doing nothing but smiling at her. It's a normal thing to do. Innocent, even. It's not her fault that every time she smiles Catra's heart does a summersault and tries to run off, taking all common sense with it.

It's completely normal that Catra knows she comes in every Monday, Wednesday and Thursday. It's also normal to know that she always comes in just after 1pm, avoiding the initial 12pm rush to get out of work, grab lunch, and get back as soon as possible. The whole mad rush around lunch perplexes Catra, all these people desperate to get a coffee and a little sandwich or cake seemingly before their bosses realise they've gone.

But for the past month, almost as a reward for putting up with it three times a week, Catra breathes a sigh of relief whenever she sees the familiar swaying of a blond ponytail passing by the floor-to-ceiling windows in front of the café. Sometimes the blonde hugs the wall a bit too close, managing not to pass under the sensor for the door to open, and has to step back and wave up at it for the doors to let her in. Sometimes she manages to catch the doors just as they're about to close and almost walks into them. Every time, Catra suppresses a laugh, covering her mouth with a closed fist as she coughs into it. Every time, she watches with keen interest while pretending to focus on the drink some other customer had ordered.

'Excuse me?'

*Crap!* Catra quickly ran her hand down the length of her tail, flattening it down after the shock of being broken from her trance.

'S- Sorry!' *Shitshitshit.* She'd been staring too long. What was the order again? Probably the same as usual. Black coffee. Gross. Every time she ordered that, Catra would slip in something else, something to make it decidedly *less* gross. Almost as if presenting a fine artist with a blank canvas as declaring to *have at it* and paint whatever they like on it. Although in this case, it was more like she was ordering a canvas painted completely black, but Catra still painted something else on it anyway. Something subtle. Maybe a colour underneath the black, so it's not quite pure black. Or maybe a little doodle in the corner. Recently, she's been getting more brave, painting swirling patterns across the black canvas in steadily brighter colours just to see if she could get a reaction out of her unwilling test-dummy.

Losing her job had never occurred to her. Catra really shouldn't be messing with customer's drinks, but when the manager is your best friend you can get away with a lot more. Even though sometimes customers would just order *"whatever"* and it would be up to her to decide by judging them on the spot and making a complete guess as to what they might like. That was part of the Bright Moon Coffee Co. menu, it wasn't made up. Luck of the draw kind of thing. Almost like gambling, in a way. The main rule is that the customer isn't allowed to complain afterwards, because they knew full-well what they were signing up for.

This isn't like that though. The blonde purposefully orders her coffee black every time and Catra messes with it anyway. Doing anything to it to make it seem even a degree more interesting, more deserving of being drunk by the absolute radiance of the girl that orders it.

Radiance is something the rain doesn't help, Catra decided as she picked a cup off the stack and prepared to fill it with a black coffee base while considering what else to put into it. Her usually bright blond hair had been dulled by the rain and plastered to her forehead. While Catra turned away to see to the order, she started ringing out her ponytail like a soaked towel, dripping water all over the floor. Whatever - the floor was ruined by now anyway. Tons of people had forced their way in once the impromptu storm started, dragging in mud and water and making Catra's mopping skills from the night before completely redundant. The storm, it would later turn out, was not random. The Met Office had been saying for weeks that storm Kyle would be hitting shores soon, but no one really ever pays attention to the Met Office and proceeds to complain about the weather anyway.

Catra had only looked the blonde in the eyes once, the first time she came in and ordered a black coffee. It had taken far too long for Catra to tear her eyes away that time, so Catra resigned herself to not looking, only glancing around her face (not that that seemed to work considering she had been staring just now). The deep, sparkling blue had pinned Catra to the spot, holding her hostage and threatening cold-blooded murder should she turn away. No, that's too harsh. Those eyes were far too kind for that. It was Catra who would murder if she should be forced to look away from those eyes a second time.

Having a "customer-face" was something most workers had, be it in retail or service. A blank smile with no meaning behind it waiting to accept anything that came from a customer's mouth as the gospel truth. The only person who was allowed to refute that gospel truth was the manager, but Scorpia would never hurt a fly, not really, despite her pincers and literally person-paralysing venom in her tail.

Speaking of remaining blank and having unique features, Catra's tail and ears often betrayed her, the *traitors*. Her tail was especially guilty, thrashing excitedly far more than would be deemed appropriate in a work setting every time that ponytail came within eyeline. Catra could feel those dreamy eyes watching her back as she prepared the coffee, now no longer just black like she had ordered. Picking up a pen, Catra wrote "ponytail" on the side of the cup, and placed it on the counter in front of the waiting blonde.

'I have a name, you know.' She beamed that infectious smile once again. Catra froze. This was the first time she had said something other than her order and a thank you as she smiled and left. It took a moment, but there was no one else waiting to order right now anyway, so Catra steeled herself and prepared to ask, her heart hammering in her chest.

'Oh yeah, what is it?' For a whole month Catra had been meaning to ask. Usually you would once the customer had ordered, standard practice. But ever since that first time she came in, when Catra had been too distracted to speak, she had just been writing "blonde" or "ponytail" on the cup. Catra assumed she didn't mind, as she never opposed it, just seeming amused by the observations Catra was making on her cup.

'Adora.'

Of course it fucking is. It just *has* to be a beautiful name doesn't it.  A name that sounds amazing to hear and must taste like goddamn honey to actually say out loud. Christ, she's got it bad. If just hearing the blonde's name is enough to make her face feel warm, god knows what Catra is going to do if she actually goes forward with any of the fantasies that have plagued her mind since week two of watching this blonde order shitty coffee.

It wasn't as if *Adora* was her gay awakening. Catra had crushes growing up, as most folk do, but they had never amounted to anything and had never been as *intense* as this.

Ah, crap. Catra's gaze was lost in those oceans of blue again. She couldn't help it, not after hearing her name and finding out that name was just the most amazing word she's ever heard. The second time Catra's ever made eye-contact, and over her goddamn name. *Adora* seemed to realise too, bursting into an infectious smile when she met Catra's eyes and looked into them like she was trying to see something hiding behind them.

'I've got to run, thanks for the coffee.' Catra watched as *Adora* paid for the coffee before practically bouncing on the spot. Then the blonde turned, ponytail swaying, and gently squeezed her way past the crowd hiding from the rain that was gathered just inside the door, apologising as she went.

That's when Catra realised it was Thursday and she wouldn't see Adora again until Monday. She groaned inwardly before plastering her fake smile back to her face and serving one of the rain-crowd that had been dislodged by Adora's exit.

Not long after that, Catra took her lunch break.

She never had to bring her own food. Scorpia usually managed to crush something while stacking shelves that they could no longer sell, so Catra just ate the victims of those accidents. She groaned, much more audibly this time, flopping back on the sofa in the break room and sprawling across it. Scorpia was in there too, sorting through some files - or trying to - that she had been meaning to sort through for a while. Catra would usually help, but Scorpia knew she was usually grumpy on a Thursday afternoon so she usually wouldn't ask but these files *really* needed to be sorted and her claws would just not cut her some slack.

'Oh. Uhm - Hey there, Wildcat. Rough morning?' Scorpia always sounded chipper. Sometimes it was welcome and actually helped to improve Catra's mood, but not today. Wildcat was a long-standing nickname from college. Scorpia had been in one of the upper classes on Catra's course but they ended up being friends anyway. She had often gushed to Catra about her long-term plans of opening her own coffee shop somewhere in the city, but apparently a good stepping stone to that was becoming the manager of a chain-café that already existed. If you were to ask, she would say she's happy to be learning so much about running a café at all, despite some of the work being handled by the powers that be. Scorpia always tried to put her own twists on any promotional material that came through, but she couldn't get away with a lot. Everything had to be by the book, and any obvious deviations wouldn't make it past the inspection. That's just how these companies are. Catra blew out a long breath into the room, closing her eyes and just trying to focus on not listing to the hammering rain that was filling her senses.

'Yeah, whatever. I don't like how loud the rain is.' Catra lied. Well, it wasn't a *complete* lie. The rain was loud, but that's not why she was sulking.

'You want to talk about it later? I can give you a call again, if you want to - obviously you don't have to talk if you don't want -'

'Okay, fine. I'll tell you about it tonight.' Catra turned to face the back of the sofa, hiding her no doubt furiously flushed face from Scorpia. Scorpia was a long-time friend, despite also being her manager. She was the reason Catra even had a job here at all. Catra hadn't quite made it through college, getting expelled after only her second year for almost clawing out some bully's eye. They definitely deserved it, but the police had gotten involved and Catra had to be punished for seriously injuring someone. Her caregiver, Ms. Weaver, soon had her out on the street too. Apparently, getting kicked out of college was the last straw for her and finally gave the drow the excuse she needed to kick Catra out for good. It's not as if Catra wasn't planning on running away as soon as she turned 18 anyway.

Catra had then ended up on Scorpia's doorstep with her one bag of belongings, having nowhere else to go, and Scorpia greeted her with open arms. She also recommended Catra for the spare part-time position as barista at the little BMCC chain café, until a year later Scorpia was made manager and swiftly promoted Catra to have a permanent contract with slightly better pay. Once Catra had enough pay-checks saved up, she moved out of Scorpia's place and got herself an apartment of her own somewhere nearby, content with just existing and living out each day. That was until a month ago when a certain *stupid-hot-ponytail-wearing-blonde* had to start taking up all the free space in her thoughts.

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'I think I'm in love.' Catra admitted down the phone later that night to a worried Scorpia, who promptly stopped being worried and squealed excitedly down the phone as Catra quickly jerked it away from her ear. Catra had been dreading this call because she knew Scorpia would react like this.

*'Wow! That's amazing, Wildcat. I'm super happy for you that's just - wow. Awesome.'*

'It's not like we're together, Scorpia. It's just a crush. I can't stop thinking about her.' Catra always found it easier to talk about this kind of thing over the phone, feelings were not something she could talk about with someone else in the room. Having heightened senses means that she can get a good read on people, often being able to pick up on the slight changes that a normal person wouldn't even dream of noticing.

*'Tell me about it! I want to hear everything - this is a big deal, Catra, you've never told me about a crush before.'*

This was true only because no one had stood out to her since meeting Scorpia in college. Catra - it turned out - was incredibly picky. She seemed to have a thing for blondes, specifically ones that played sports. Catra had oddly specific memories of blonde girls running relays or kicking footballs around the school fields. She drew in a long breath and tried to gather her thoughts into some semblance of order.

'Okay. If I'm going to do this, you need to shut it and just - let me talk. Alright? I've not exactly done this before.' Catra waited for a moment longer for Scorpia's assurance. 'Scorpia?'

*'Oh! Sorry I - I thought you meant immediately. Yeah, no problem, Wildcat. I won't say a peep.'*

Catra felt a smile tugging at the corner of her mouth. Scorpia had always been quite straightforward, but she was nice. Kind. A good friend. Catra rolled onto her back, staring up at the ceiling and weaving her tail between the fingers on her free hand.

'Okay. So - for the last month she's been coming into the café and just ordering black coffee. But... don't give me an ear full for this - she's gorgeous, okay? I can't let her drink that shit. So I've been adding little extras to it so it's not just straight black coffee. But when I first served her I couldn't... I forgot to ask her name. So I've just been writing whatever on her cup but today - today she told me her name.' There was a moment of silence. 'Go ahead, Scorpia.'

*'Wildcat! How have you kept this quiet! This is amazing. I can tell you like her. So she's a customer? What does she look like? What's her name?'*

Catra let herself smile wide at her friend's excitement. Scorpia was a lot on the best of days, but Catra would often let herself be influenced by her near-constant positive and peppy outlook on life. 'One question at a time, Scorpia.'

*'Sorry, go ahead.'*

'Yes, she's a customer. She's blonde, built well - I guess. Her name... Her name is Adora.'

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It turns out, according to Scorpia, there was someone called Adora who had been something of a local legend when it came to playing sports at their college. She had been in the same year as Catra, but only really started making the front page of the college News Club's zines sometime after Catra was expelled. After completing her course, she started attending the nearest University and continued to study something or other sports related.

On Monday, when Catra handed over the cup of not-black coffee, Adora had looked down and smiled at her own name scrawled on the side.

'That was her, then?' Scorpia asked during the lunchbreak, leaning back against the counter and waiting for the sink to fill up so she could attempt to wash up the plates and mugs that had been left out on the side for almost a week. Normally, she would use the dishwasher, but the plumber still hadn't been round to take a look at it and Catra was silently seething about it.

'Yeah, that was her.' Catra had felt extremely nervous about writing something other than "ponytail" on the side of her cup. Somehow, it felt like some huge step towards getting closer to her, but Catra knew that was just her hopeless lesbian brain feeding her fantasies that Adora actually gives a shit.

'It was definitely the same Adora, oh yeah. I recognise her from the college newsletter things they used to hand out. I never really wanted them but I just couldn't refuse them when they handed them out to me, you know?' Scorpia laughed, trying to hide her apparent secret shame of being *too nice* to say no to accepting a flyer from some over-eager wannabe journalist. 'Did she say anything? Anything new? You did write her name on the cup this time, didn't you?'

'Yes, Scorpia, I wrote her name on the dumb cup. And no, she didn't say anything else, just looked hot and smiled as usual. I just...' Catra stuttered over her next words. The truth was, she had been so nervous about just writing Adora's name on the stupid cup that she hadn't thought about next steps. At all.

'Maybe you should write your number on the next cup.'

Catra flushed an unhealthy red, and looked wide-eyed over at Scorpia where she grinned innocently at Catra where she was sprawled on the sofa. A splashing suddenly caught Catra's attention as her ears twitched towards the sound. 'Scorpia! The sink!'

'Oh - shoot!'

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No numbers were written on any cups during Adora's next three visits. Scorpia insisted she should but that felt an overstep, for a barista to just write their phone number on someone's cup. Plus, what if some weirdo found the cup if Adora just threw it away and called instead? What if Adora saw the number and felt disgusted by Catra coming on to her and never visited ever again? What if-

Catra sneezed, interrupting her own spiralling thoughts. She had caught the flu going round from a particularly gross customer who full-on sneezed on Catra the day before. Now her muscled ached, she had an awesome headache and her nose hadn't stopped running once. Getting ill was not something that happened often with Catra, but when she did it hit her hard. Something to with magicats having different reactions to this kind of thing. Not only that, but Catra was doubly grumpy because she's missing her Wednesday shift. It's the first shift she's missed since Adora started coming into the café.

Scorpia had also been calling Catra all day, checking up on her continuously to ask if she's okay or if she needs anything, also asking even more questions about her crush on Adora for some reason. Apparently she turns into some kind of overprotective mum when one of her friends is ill, and it took Catra actually getting ill to feel the full brunt of it. Scorpia had even come over to bring her lunch from the café. It was now approaching closing time, 5:30pm, so Catra was expecting a call from Scorpia any minute. She may have decided to indulge in her friend's kindness and asked her to bring over something for dinner and to hang out, even if she had started to feel slightly better.

There it was, the familiar buzz of Catra's phone, steadily vibrating itself toward the edge of the chest of drawers next to the bed where it's been on charge all day. Catra picked it up and answered immediately, she had made the mistake of not turning off the ring tone earlier in the day and her heightened hearing while ill was, decidedly, not fun.

'Hey Scorpia. Before you say anything, yes I'm still home, yes I'm started to feel better, and no, I won't tell you anything else about my crush on Adora.'

Silence.

'Uh, Scorpia? Have you butt-dialed me again?'

*'... Hey.'*

Catra froze. That wasn't Scorpia's phone voice, or even close to her normal voice.

'Who is this? How'd you get my number?'

*'It was... written on my cup. Is this Catra? Your manager gave me something to bring you, she said you're ill but she's too busy to come over.'*

Catra would have responded, but her brain had crashed after the word "cup."

'I'm going to kill her.'

*'Um... please don't?'*

# Chapter 2

Chapter Summary

Adora's been crushing on a certain magicat ever since she first locked eyes with her in a chain-café. The only problem is, she hadn't told her friends anything about it.

That's about to change.

Chapter Notes

There is a culprit for this chapter materialising out of nowhere in just a few hours. You know who you are.

Enjoy part 2 of what was supposed to be a oneshot, but the brainrot returned with a vengeance.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

*'What do you mean you spent the night!?'* Glimmer's shrill voice screamed down the phone so loud Adora had to pull the device away from her ear to save her hearing. After a moment, she tentatively replaced it when she heard Glimmer continue, *'me and Bow were so worried when you didn't come back! You could have said something!'*

'I'm really sorry, Glimmer,' Adora began, because she *was*, 'one thing just kind of led to another. She was *really* ill. Like, really bad. When I saw how awful she looked at the door I offered to prepare the food for her a bit. She went into her room, I took it to her, and then I just sort of... stayed?'

Glimmer mumbled something about *useless fucking lesbians* but it was completely lost on Adora. In all honesty, she was practically *buzzing*. She'd spent the night! At Catra's place! Yeah, she'd slept on the sofa, checking on her host throughout the night whenever she woke up from the couch being too uncomfortable, changing out Catra's glass of water every time so it was fresh and triple checking that the medication she'd placed nearby was the right kind for magicats. But that was fine. Adora managed it. She was great, and Catra had even said *thanks* at the end of it and *smiled* at her.

*God her eyes are pretty.*

Adora was, to use some of Glimmer's language, completely fucked.

She'd had crushes on girls before, but it wasn't until a year or so ago that she realised that that's what that feeling *was*. It was so bad that it took Glimmer leading Adora by the arm to a corner of the party at Sea Hawk's place and asked, *"you're gay right?"*, for Adora's whole world to pause while her brain went:

*Oh shit! I'm totally gay!*

And with that revelation out of the way, Adora's whole perspective on love shifted. She'd always wondered why certain girls made her feel funny, and guys made her feel... nothing? All her friends in school had always talked about boys, and Adora did the usual *"haha yeah"* to feel included, but it wasn't until years later when faced with a question from her new best friend in the corner of a frankly crappy party that she could say *"haha yeah"* unironically.

*"What's your poison?"* Was Glimmer's follow-up question.

*"Girls,"* had been Adora's confident answer. She'd even nodded. *Look at her go.*

So when Adora happened to stumble into what *was* just a random café after a particularly long night of hiding Wii remotes with Bow and Glimmer around their shared flat, feeling groggy and in need of something strong to wake her up, she was woefully unprepared to come face-to-face with an altogether unfairly effective pick-me-up alternative in the form of a, quite frankly, *beautiful* magicat woman standing opposite her on the other side of the counter. They stared into each other's eyes for a few moments too long, but there was no-one to pull them out of it, what with it being so early. It was actually Adora's phone alarm that shook them out of their stupor, ringing loud and proud as if to say *"wake up dumbass you've slept in"*, but actually said *"wake up dumbass you're lost in her eyes"*. After a quick apology on Adora's end and a dismissive flick of an ear on the

barista's, Adora left the chain-café with something a little sweeter than what she'd ordered in her hand, and something a little sweeter than a crush settling into her heart.

*'You're coming back to the flat right now and telling us what the the hell you've been doing in that coffee shop,'* came Glimmer's voice once again, wrenching Adora back to reality from deep within her own thoughts, just in time for Adora to realise she was about to walk into a lamppost and completely avoid it like a boss. Hell yeah, *nailed it*. Adora 1, lamppost 0. If her hands weren't full of her phone and leftovers that Catra didn't want, she'd have done finger guns at it.

*Pew pew.*

*Ha, that's a kind of bench.*

'Do I have to?' Adora whined, only just holding in a chuckle as *pew pew* looped round in her head again, not really completely sold on the idea of laying her thoughts out bare for her protective best friend and her overzealously kind and understanding best friend to observe and comment on.

*'Yes, yes you do.'*

And, as it always is, that was that.

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'So who is she?'

The interrogation began with a direct question from Glimmer, quickly followed by an apologetical wince from Bow who had probably tried to convince his girlfriend into using less direct language but, well, it's *Glimmer* so that was a pipe-dream.

'She's the barista. *A* barista. Not the only one, obviously,' Adora struggled to get the words out. She hadn't really done this before, not like *this*, not when it was someone *Adora* was crushing on instead of people Glimmer thought she could be interested in if she would *"just go on a date with them and talk to see if you like them"*.

Glimmer huffed and puffed for a moment like a struggling steam engine before pouting and crossing her arms over her chest. 'What was wrong with that other barista girl I tried introducing you to?'

Adora rolled her eyes, 'Glimmer, that was a *barmaid*, in a *pub*. Not a barista.'

'Same difference,' the sparkly pink-haired girl defended, reaching up to run her fingers through her undercut. 'What makes this one any different?'

'What's that supposed to mean?' The blonde returned, eyebrows furrowing in annoyance, 'am I not allowed to crush on someone *I* like instead of someone you're trying to match me with?'

Glimmer, Adora had come to realise since she said *"haha yeah"* followed by *"girls"* at a crappy party about a year ago, was asking whether Adora was gay because she apparently had a whole list full of equally single gays that she was keeping an eye on for *"research purposes"* until she found herself joined at the hip with Bow and no longer had any real reason for the list. Thus, she found a use for it: trying to set Adora up.

Adora, to give her some credit, had actually gone on dates with a few of them. You can't say she didn't try. But there was never any kind of spark, nothing that jumped out at her to entice her into a second date. Sure, some *(a lot)* of them were easy on the eyes, Adora had to give Glimmer credit for her type in women, but unfortunately that credit didn't extend to the people under the looks. Which, Adora reasoned, is *far* more crucial.

But what is a gay supposed to do when the first impression *are* looks and that alone sends the spark shooting through her body?

In the month before Adora gave Catra her name, Catra barely said a word. Yet, it was almost as if the magicat didn't need to. Adora took her silence the wrong way at first, thinking she was being ignored completely. That is, until she noticed the signs. The swishing of her tail. The flicking of her ears. The bristling of her fur. A few hours of googling later, and Adora was practically an expert in *"how to recognise what a magicat is feeling through body language alone"*. And, for the rest of that month, Catra didn't *need* to speak for Adora to know exactly, or kind of vaguely make somewhat educated guesses, what she was thinking. Or feeling.

'Of course you are,' Bow supplied, grabbing at Glimmer's wrist to bring her back down to sit next to him on the larger of the two sofa's in their living room that was just a little too small for two sofas and a coffee table and a television stand and a little shelf that was stacked high with board games. 'You're allowed to like whoever you want. Isn't she, Glimmer?' Bow raised an expectant eyebrow at his *grumpy-wumpy girlfwend*, a phrase that always seemed to make her giggle, and Glimmer relented.

'Fine! Yes. Of course, that's okay. I'm just...' *frustrated that you couldn't get any success out of your list*, Adora finished for her as Glimmer sighed. 'I'm happy for you Adora. Really, I am. Do you *want* to talk about her?'

*Yes* is Adora's instant reaction to that question, but she doesn't voice it quite as quickly because... well... what does she actually have to talk about? She's barely spoken to Catra at all over the time she's been seeing her. *Seeing* as in from a distance of a few feet over a counter while purchasing goods from the magicat's place of work. Maybe it would be easier to just... show them?

Before Adora could question what she was doing, she found herself looking down at her phone, at a new contact. Her fingers *brrr'd* over the keys and before she could second-guess anything she'd sent a text.

Then she caught up with herself and her expression quickly morphed into one of pure horror.

'What is it? What's happening? Adora, you okay?' Bow's voice filtered through the haze and Adora lifted her phone to show her friends the evidence of what she'd done.

***Adora (15:46)*** *Hey, how are you feeling? Any better? Will I find you in the café any time soon?*

Bow and Glimmer's eyes widened as they read the evidence of Adora's weakness. But neither settled on an expression Adora was expecting. Bow's eyes turned soft as he cooed about how cute the message was, and Glimmer's eyes shone with a spark of opportunity. Adora knew which eyes to fear more, and she was right.

'Whenever she says she'll be in next, we're going with you!' Glimmer declared, as if that wasn't Adora's original intention with the message in the first place before she made it sound way too personal with three whole questions. Surely she'd overstepped, right? Catra wouldn't reply to that, it was too invasive too soon. There's no way Catra would even reply within the first five minutes of Adora having sent the—

***Catra (15: 48)*** *getting there*
***Catra (15: 48)*** *monday probably*

***Catra (15: 49)*** *thanks for asking i guess*

Adora dropped her phone and Glimmer scrambled to pick it up while its owner stared into space, a goofy smile slowly spreading across her face.

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The following Monday, Adora found herself zoning out while the Best Friend Squad made their way towards the Bright Moon Coffee Co. branch where Catra works. Glimmer and Bow were chatting away about what they were going to order, having looked up the menu online. It was a nice day, all sun and mostly clear skies, with just the right amount of wind to keep it from being too hot or too cold, and Adora loved that. She loved the way the wispy white clouds stretched across the sky, slowly crawling in the direction of the wind. She loved the way the birds flitted from one building to the next, seemingly chirping away to themselves about anything and everything. And finally, she loved the way that she felt inside. All warm and content, like nothing could go wrong ever again.

She may have texted with Catra some more the night before. Just a little. Only for a few hours, until she literally fell asleep next to her phone.

By this point, Adora has practically told Catra her whole life story, including the tale of her gay realisation, which the magicat found "fucking hilarious", because apparently she's always known she was into girls. After some light prodding from Adora, she'd even let slip about the girls she'd had crushes on in school that sounded like carbon copies of Adora; blondes with muscles and ponytails.

It was that last detail that Adora hoped Catra maybe wasn't so hung up on, because she may have... well... had all her hair chopped off. She did it a couple days ago, because the EUCS (Etherian University & Colleges Sport) tennis league would be starting soon and, to put it mildly, she was sick of it whipping her in the face all the time.

She ran her hand through her hair, feeling its new length between her fingers and wondered again what Catra would think of it. Hopefully she wouldn't mind it. Maybe she'd even like it? She'd considered getting an undercut, like Glimmer, but decided that for her first major haircut she just wanted to play it safe for now and go short on sides with a little bit more left on top.

Adora took a deep breath, trying to purge any self-destructive thoughts about her decision from her mind. She likes her haircut. It's lighter, she doesn't have to stretch her scalp back to keep it out of her face. Vaguely, she's aware of the hair bobble around her wrist, but she's not sure why she's got it. Habit, maybe?

Above all else, when Adora first saw herself in the mirror after the hair dresser declared that, finally, she was finished and Adora finally let herself *look* at herself, she knew that it felt *right*. She wasn't really sure what that meant, because she'd never really had any opinion on her hair before, but something about it being shorter made her chest feel lighter, somehow. If she'd cried a little in the bathroom afterwards, that's her business, even if she doesn't know why.

The sound of the doors sliding open outside the chain-café, that became one of Adora's permanent favourite places for a very specific reason, shook her from her tumbling thoughts, bringing her back to what they were doing and why they were here, of all places.

*Catra.*

Glimmer and Bow had come along, not with the pure intention of having brunch with their friend, but more to openly intrude on her crush to see what all the fuss was about. Somehow, even though it was originally Adora's idea to do this, Glimmer declaring that they would come along before she'd had a chance to suggest it herself somehow made it feel like an intrusion. But *whatever*, they're here now, walking through the doors and looking around as if to spot Catra anywhere other than behind the counter, where she always is.

*Where she isn't, right now.*

'So where is she?' Glimmer asked, spinning round on the spot in the middle of the floor, directly between the queue for the counter and the seating area. Adora shook her head, because honestly: she doesn't know. Catra had only said she would be here that one time, and that was the only time throughout all their texting that they had talked about the café at all. Adora can't even remember if she mentioned that Catra's a magicat, which sort of feels like a piece of vital information.

Magicats aren't especially rare, but they're not common either. If you were to walk down your local high-street, you'd maybe spot one or two going about their business. The fact Adora was crushing *hard* for one should have maybe worked itself into an earlier conversation. But, *eh*, they'll find out soon enough if Catra really *is* here.

Adora shrugged, glancing around the café to look in all the places she knew Catra wouldn't be, just in case, 'I don't know? She could just be on a break. Sometimes that happens when I come in on my own too.' Adora held her tongue before she let slip that Catra always seems to be on the till by the time she gets to it anyway, but her friends don't really need that snippet of information.

'Well,' Bow started, eyeing the menu above the tills despite animatedly talking about what he was going to order the whole way here, 'why don't you find a seat, Adora, and we'll order for us. What do you want to drink?'

'Just a black coffee,' Adora lied. What she *wanted* was for Catra to *not* make her a black coffee, like she usually does, but Catra isn't here right now to do that for her.

'You got it,' Bow said, taking Glimmer's hand and leading them away to join the slightly shorter queue.

Adora sighed and looked out across the seating area. There were a good number of tables, a few of them occupied. A man in a suit with a laptop open in front of him, a small group of satyr girls all sat staring at their phones with their drinks going cold, and even a couple of sea elves with big, bulging backpacks and an actual, physical map spread out over their table. Adora took a seat in a four-person booth, keeping to the outside as she normally does, and tapped her fingers on the table in a random rhythm that's stuck in her head while she waited for her friends. She couldn't help but keep glancing up to watch their progress, and also to check if Catra's there yet. Would she be okay that Adora's here, actually seated in the café with her friends? She's never done it before, sit in that is, nor has she ever brought other people with her. What if Catra just ignores her the whole time she's here? What if she hates the new haircut? What if, after turning up unannounced like this, Catra never texts back again?

The cup being placed in front of her paused her thoughts, and Adora glanced up to watch as her best friends filtered into the booth opposite her. Glimmer immediately pulled out her phone, sipping on what looked like a weirdly sparkly drink that Adora had never seen before, whereas Bow just sat looking softly at Adora, probably piecing together a question in his head.

'So,' he began, speaking slowly as if his voice was walking on glass, 'what does she look like?'

Adora swallowed and took a sip of her black coffee, immediately cringing at the taste and putting it back down on the table with a definite finality. What the hell, she used to like black coffee. Or, she was able to tolerate it at least. Catra's conditioned her taste-buds.

'She's just,' Adora sighed, spinning the cup around in her hands to give them something to do, 'she's really pretty. Like, super pretty. She has the most amazing eyes, different colours, and I never want to look away from them. She's a little shorter than me, has short, brown hair that looks really soft and... well... she's a—

'Adora?'

Adora's head whipped round to see the owner of the voice she recognised so fast she felt her neck crick at the sudden motion.

Catra, standing right there, looking down at her with wide eyes and wide, dark pupils. She was clutching her tail in one hand, her ears up and alert, and seemed stunned to silence to see Adora here.

'Um. Hi, Catra,' Adora smiled, because she was happy to see the most beautiful girl in the world again, but also she was smiling through thoughts like: oh god she she's looking at me so intently what do I do? Just sit here? Why is she so close? She's never come out from behind the counter before? What's she doing with her hand? Why is it—

Adora's eyes closed as soon as Catra's hand landed on her head. The magicat's fingers spread wide, threading through Adora's short hair with reverence, gently stroking through the top part, and slowly making her way down to the sides. There was a light brush of claw as Catra moved her hand away, and Adora was only vaguely aware that that was the first time she'd felt Catra touch her.

She wanted it again. More. Do it again.

'Shit! Sorry,' Catra cursed and apologised under her breath, her pupils even wider than before. She reached behind her to where she'd placed another cup on another table, and swapped it out with the one in front of Adora. 'I won't let drink this black shit. This one's on me,' she muttered, before turning and sauntering back towards the counter.

Adora swallowed as she watched Catra's retreat, then reluctantly turned back to her friends who were staring at her with wide eyes.

'That,' Bow cooed, 'was the cutest interaction I've ever seen!'

Glimmer looked less enthused, 'you didn't tell us you were crushing on a magicat!' The girl squawked at her across the table, following that statement up with, 'don't they have like, claws, and...' Glimmer waved her hand in the air while searching for a word, '*rough* tongues?'

Adora had to close her eyes to force *those* images out of her head.

'They do,' Bow nodded, '*and* they're *super* flexible.'

Adora groaned and almost headbutted the table a little too hard with how fast she dropped it to hide her flushed cheeks. She did not need those kinds of images in her head right now. 'You guys are the worst. I don't care that she's a magicat, that's not why I like her.'

'So why do you like her?' Bow asked, perfectly innocently.

'I know why I'd like her,' Glimmer commented, less innocently.

'GLim!' Bow chastised, looking at his girlfriend in shock. Playful shock, but still shock.

'What?' Glimmer smirked, 'she's hot.'

'Yeah,' Adora nodded into the table, 'she is. She's also really sweet, and has been making me a different drink every time I've come in so I wouldn't drink straight black coffee. I always just want to stare into her eyes all the time. I want to scratch behind her ears. I want to know if her tail is as soft as it looks. I want to kiss her, so bad, and it's all I've been able to think about since I first saw her working here.'

'You've got it bad,' Bow observed.

'Yeah, I do. I really want to take her out somewhere, but I don't know how to ask or where to go.' Adora turned her head to look at her cup, and promptly sat up straight, picking up the cup to read what Catra wrote on it more clearly:

***handsome blonde***

Adora grinned and looked across to the counter again in search of Catra. What she saw, was Catra furiously wiping up coffee from where she'd overfilled a cup. She poured it out, getting ready to start again, when their eyes met. Catra's smile was a little more devious than Adora's, and she flicked her ears in a way that was just obvious enough for Adora to notice them.

*Oh,* Adora thought, her grin dropping as realisation set in, *she could hear us the whole time.*

And Adora promptly fell just a little bit more in love.

Chapter End Notes

Hope you liked it!

Idk if there will be a part three. If there is, it might not be soon, and for that reason the chapter count is staying at 2/2 for now.

Edit: I was bribed. There is now going to be a part 3.

# Chapter 3

Chapter Summary

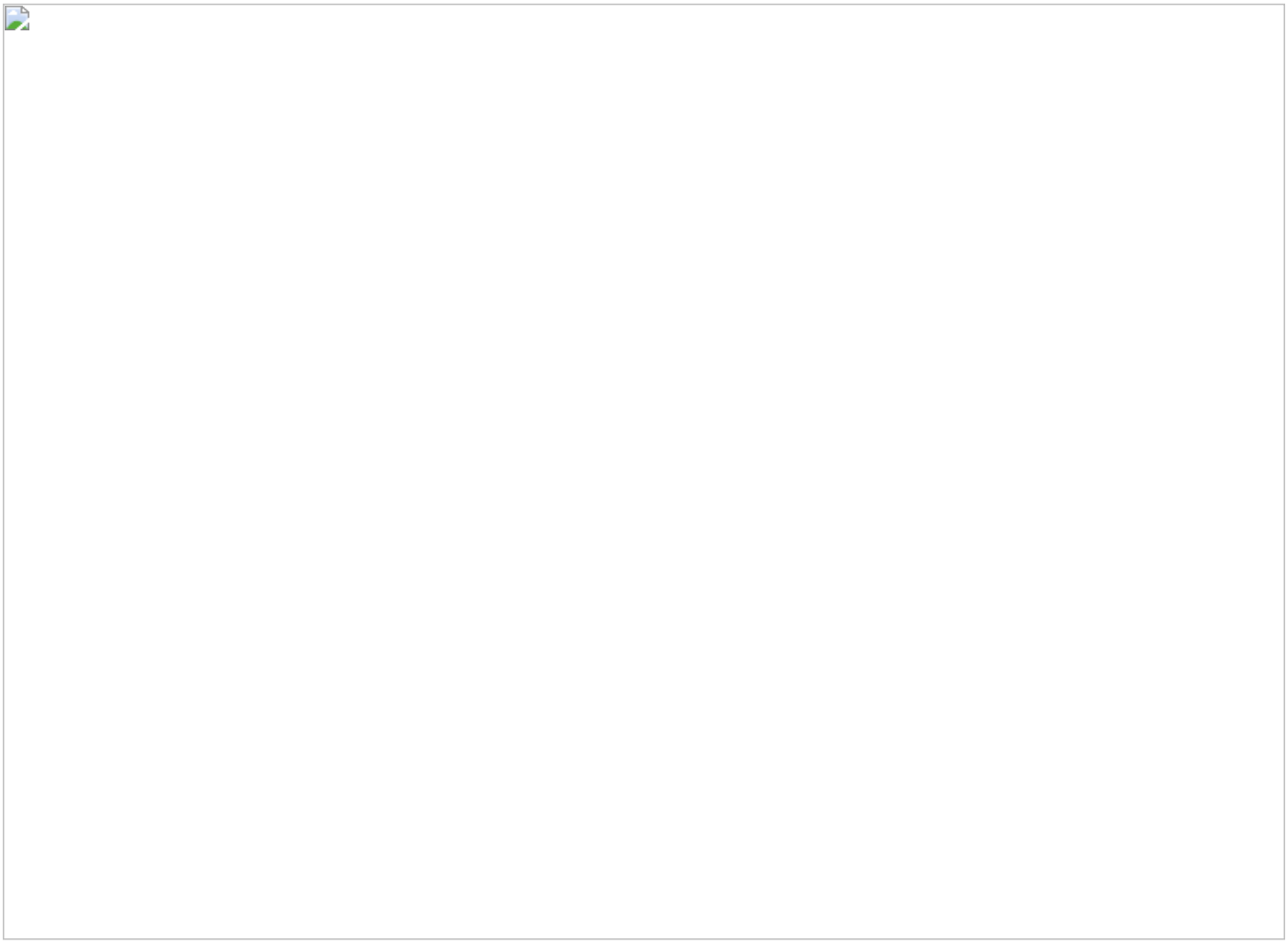
Catra freaks out for 6.5k words.

Chapter Notes

So I couldn't hold this in anymore, I had to post it.

It features my best attempt at writing in my partner's chilli recipe, because I'm a terrible cook and their chilli is the only thing I remember how to make.

This chapter was initially bribed out of me by this illustration of handsome short haired Adora by theraccount.



Do you see why Catra couldn't hold herself back now? Yeah, same.

Anyway, enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

'Fucking hell!' Catra groaned into her sofa as soon as she face-planted into it after just walking through her front door, having locked up the café and gone shopping with Scorpia, and immediately vaulting herself onto the furniture to hide.

Scorpia paid no mind to the athleticism of her feline best friend, instead busying herself with scouring Catra's kitchens for any sign of the pots she needed to make enough chilli for them to eat tonight and to last Catra another few days, at least. Catra would need to help when it got to the more fiddly parts of the cooking process, but Scorpia was a master at cutting up the peppers and onion.

'Scorpia!' Catra yelled for her anyway, almost stunned by her best friend's silence. 'Did you *see* her today!?'

Scorpia giggled to herself like a woman with too many secrets for her own good, 'I did, wildcat, I was the one who came to get you from the break room, remember?' She started unloading the shopping bag of ingredients, lining everything up in the order she would need it.

'Thank *fuck* you did. I don't know what I'd have done if *Lonnie* was the one to come through and tell me Adora had been in and was sporting a fucking *haircut*!' Catra yelled the last part into one of the cheap cushions on her sofa, kneading into the softness of the furniture if only to try and work out the urge she'd had to quell for the entirety of her shift to go back and run her hands through Adora's hair. *Again*. 'It was so fucking soft! And she smelt amazing! She must have only just showered and I want... *fuck*.' Catra poked her head up to gaze at the scorpion woman currently peeling a red onion, 'and then she was talking about me, and I could hear every word and—fuck, Scorp, I think *she likes me back*.'

Catra had frozen on the spot when she'd heard Adora start talking about her. Some of what the blonde had said was still swirling around her mind, taunting her, daring her to take the next step into whatever-the-fuck it was that was happening between them.

*She's really sweet...*

*I just want to stare into her eyes all the time...*

*I want to scratch behind her ears...*

*I want to know if her tail is as soft as it looks...*

*I want to kiss her, so bad...*

Catra had stood still just listening for so long that the drink she'd been making had overflowed onto the floor, which was exactly when Adora had chosen to look over at her. And, Catra, because she's a little shit, had waggled her ears at her. The face Adora made told Catra that she *knew*. She knew that Catra knew. If anything, Catra saw it as fair game. She'd accidentally told Adora she had a crush on her, and now Catra had overheard a long list of Adora's wants. It was simply the universe righting itself, and Catra didn't know what the fuck to do in the fallout of it.

*Adora hadn't texted yet.*

Truth be told, Catra hadn't planned to start regularly texting Adora. It had been a nice distraction from her icky illness, but then once she was better she just... kept replying. Catra had tried telling herself that Adora was only doing it because she felt bad about having to take care of her that first day, and was doing everything else to make up for it. But after seeing Adora, carding a hand through her hair, seeing the face of absolute *bliss* on Adora's face when she did, and then hearing all of *that.* Catra now knew that at least some of what she was feeling was being reciprocated. At least, she thinks it is, but Adora still *hasn't texted yet* and it's making Catra doubt herself.

She watched as Scorpia made a show of placing the cans of chopped tomatoes and mixed beans on the worktop in Catra's direction and, pretending like she doesn't always do it, Catra groaned and rolled off of the sofa to go and help her friend.

'Gosh, Catra, I don't know what you want me to say,' Scorpia said as Catra moped over to stand next to her, picking up one of the cans and making quick work of the lid with the claw on her index finger. 'You just need to talk to her, right? That seems like the easiest next step.'

Catra scoffed, 'easiest? I'd rather fucking eat my own tail. There's no way I'm texting her first.'

Scorpia winced at Catra's language, 'don't you think you've exhausted the F-word for tonight wildcat? And why won't you text her first?'

'Sorry, Scorp,' Catra relented, sighing as she picked up the next can, 'and I won't text her first because... I don't know what to say, and I don't want to sound pushy, or overeager or something.'

'You're afraid of losing her,' Scorpia said carefully, turning round to wash her pincers in the sink, 'aren't you?'

'She's not mine to lose,' Catra grumbled. She placed the can down and eyed the next one.

'She is though, Cat,' Scorpia whispered softly, fully aware that Catra could hear her. 'You just haven't seen the way she looks at you.'

'And how, exactly, does she look at me?' Catra asked carefully. She kind of felt like she knew the answer, she'd just never really considered it before.

Scorpia smiled, 'like you're the only thing in the room worth looking at.' Catra whirled round to see Scorpia pulling a weirdly wistful expression. She met Catra's eyes and broke out into a wide smile, 'gosh, I bet that sounded weird, hah. I only say that cause, well, there's someone who I think looks at me in the same way.'

'Who?' Catra asked, eyes narrowed as she crossed her arms over her chest. Scorpia flushed the same colour as her pincers, and proceeded back to the worktop where she'd placed a chopping board, and easily cleaved an onion in two with one swift snip of her claw. Catra leant forwards, 'who, Scorpia?'

'Uh, well, I kind of, may have, well, I mean... my girlfriend?' Scorpia squeaked.

Catra's jaw dropped. '*What*?'

'Uh...my...yeah...' Scorpia kept cutting the onion, smaller and smaller, not meeting Catra's gaze.

'Since when do you have a girlfriend!?' Catra yelled, before waving her hands in front of her, 'no, wait, this is a conversation for another time. Bring her over soon, I want to interrogate her.'

'Catra, that's really not–'

'This isn't a frucking debate, Scorpia. I want to meet her. You deserve the best.'

'Aww, thanks, Wildcat.' Scorpia cooed, before sliding the chopped onion into the pot and dribbling some oil on top, as well as a pinch of salt. Catra watched as she placed it on the hob to simmer, and promptly picked up the next can and got to work again.

'Whatever. How does this relate to Adora?' Catra asked, a little too preoccupied in her own mind to be able to deal with the fact that Scorpia has a girlfriend of her own.

'Well, you said she slept over, right?' Scorpia asked, getting to work on chopping up the peppers.

'Yeah, on the couch,' Catra confirmed, picking up the final can.

'And she looked after you the whole time, then even made sure you were okay in the morning?' Scorpia was leading up to something, but Catra could only guess as to the point of this line of statements pulled from a previous conversation between the two of them.

'Where is this going? It's not like she came back again.' Catra set the last can down, eyeing her friend wearily while she continued chopping the peppers with her pincers.

'Did you want her to come back?'

Catra sat with that question for a moment, idly watching as Scorpia added the chopped up peppers, mixed beans, and chopped tomatoes to the pot. She then stirred it with a spoon before leaning against the worktop and setting a timer for 15 minutes. Wanting to busy herself with her hands, Catra started on the next step early, getting out the rice and making an educated guess as to how much they needed, pouring it into the smaller pot.

'Of course I want her to come back. I don't know why I'm being so weird about this. She literally fricking said she wanted to kiss me. Well, not *to me*, to her friends. But she still said it.'

'Do *you* want to kiss *her*?'

'Fmuck yes!' Catra popped the small pot of rice on the hob next to the larger pot full of simmering ingredients and then started to boil the kettle. 'That's all I've wanted to do since she first walked in the shop, Scorp. She just radiates this feeling of comfort and she smells so... god, it's like she smells of *safety*. I just feel safe when she's around. Happy. I don't know how to describe it.'

'I think you described it pretty well the first time you told me about her,' Scorpia said, eyeing the timer.

Catra frowned, pouring the newly boiled water over the rice and turning on the second hob as Scorpia added a tablespoon of cumin and a teaspoon of chilli powder to the simmering pot of chilli. She continued to stir as Catra asked, 'What did I say?'

'You said you thought you were in love.'

Catra buried her face into the palm of her hands before dragging them up and over her head, flattening down her hair in a way that used to work when it was long, but only served to ruffle it now as the shorter curls sprung back with a vengeance. 'Oh god... I am. Scorp... I'm in love with her, aren't I?'

'You're in love with her,' Scorpia agreed, smiling to herself.

Catra started pacing, 'but *how* can I be in love with her? We've texted a little—well, a *lot*—but we've hardly spoken face to face! This doesn't happen to me, Scorpia! Why have I fallen for a girl I barely know?'

Scorpia hummed to herself in thought, standing back from the chilli for a moment to look at her friend. 'Maybe it's like you said, you feel safe around her. Maybe it's her scent attracting you, or maybe it's just like a really strong hunch. Whatever it is, she definitely likes you back, buddy, so I don't see why you shouldn't just go for it. The worst that could happen is she says no, which she won't.'

'Right, because she looks at me weird.'

'No, Cat, she looks at you like you look at her.'

'And how do I look at her?'

'Like you're in love with her.'

Catra groaned, 'why are you being so helpful? Since when have you been such an *Oogway* about love?'

Scorpia grinned to herself, happy that she's been able to help Catra sort through her feelings while also appreciative of the reference to one of their favourite movies, 'girlfriend, remember?'

'Yeah, of how long?' Catra scoffed, 'just having a girlfriend is hardly enough for you to suddenly become wise and enlightened about all relationships.'

'I don't know, Wildcat,' Scorpia said, a far-off look in her eye, 'I get this feeling, it's like, oh gosh... I want her to be in my life as long as possible. She makes me feel safe, just like Adora does for you.'

'I guess I just...' Catra sighed, watching again as Scorpia stirred the chilli, 'I just don't get why she likes me. I can't see how I would be, I don't know, attractive or whatever to her. I was literally kicked out of college for clawing some asshole's eye out!'

'Does she know that you did that?' Scorpia asked, seemingly surprised that Catra would have told Adora about it so easily, considering it's the event that basically uprooted her whole life. The cause behind her being kicked off her course, and the cause behind Ms. Weaver finally giving up on her.

'No...oh god she's going to hate me!' Catra groaned into her hands and slid down the cabinets until she was sat on the floor, legs spread in a wide V in front of her, the claws on her feet stretching as she flexed her toes.

'No! No, what I mean is:' Scorpia backtracked, aware that the subject was a touchy one, 'that's something for you to tell her when you start getting to know each other. I'm sure she has her own tales to tell.'

Catra leant her head against the cupboard behind her, looking up at her friend. 'Yeah, but she's not going to have done something *that* bad.'

'How do you know?' Scorpia countered.

'I—*shit*.'

'Exactly.'

'But this just proves my point more!' Catra exclaimed as Scorpia started rifling through cupboards in search of bowls. 'How do I love her already if I don't know anything... I just... I don't know what to do.'

'You don't have to tell her you love her right away,' Scorpia said, laying out the two bowls next to each other on the worktop, 'just get to know her, and if you still love her when you feel like you know her more, then tell her.'

'And then what?' Catra asked, standing to grab a spoon for herself as well as Scorpia's spoon pincer attachment from the cutlery drawer.

'Then see what she says. Either she'll say it back, or she won't. Either way, once you've said it, you need to *listen* to her. Talk to her, decide on next steps together.'

'I think you're getting a little carried away there, Scorp. We haven't even been on one date yet.'

'No, but you will, and if the looks you give each other are anything to go by, I think you'll be alright.'

'God, Scorp,' Catra chuckled, 'where has this girl been all your life?'

'That's what I want to know!'

The two of them laughed together for moment, but were rudely interrupted by Scorpia's final timer signalling that both the chilli and rice were ready to be served.

When the pair finally sat down on the sofa, Scorpia wordlessly rented Kung Fu Panda and hit play (so what if Catra mooches off of Scorpia's streaming shit, butt out) no doubt subconsciously drawn to it from Catra's earlier, extremely fleeting mention of the old turtle.

Catra, however much she'd like to pay attention to the film and spend time with her friend, is instead drawn to her phone when it shoots off a number of *dings* rapid-fire. Very specific *dings*, ones that Catra didn't expect to hear. She finds herself almost dropping her bowl of chilli when she leans over to snatch up her phone off of the coffee table in front of them. She should really stop perching food in her lap, she's kind of tempting fate with that one.

It's Adora. *Messaging*. Messages from Adora. The chilli is forgotten, Catra was almost finished anyway, and the film is suddenly background noise. Catra brings up her legs, practically scrunching herself into a ball on one end of the sofa and cradling her phone in her hands as she opens her texts, secretly afraid of what she'll read. Scorpia is enthralled by the film, as she always is, and pays Catra no mind.

**Adora (19:56)** Hey
**Adora (19:57)** I'm so sorry about today, I kind of forgot you'd be able to hear us 😅
**Adora (19:57)** I hope what I said wasn't too weird
**Adora (19:58)** But I meant it. All of it. I just needed you to know that.

Catra reads them. Once. Twice. Again for good measure.

*She meant it.*

She isn't shying away. She really does...

Catra felt a foreign pang in her chest, that soon turned into a squeeze, and she practically hugged the phone to herself and failed to fight a smile, but succeeded in hiding it behind her knees. She wrapped her tail around her ankles to keep it from thrashing around while she brought her phone back out again, and with shaking fingers, she typed her reply.

**Catra (20:01)** hey Adora, its no problem, usually id kick people out for whispering about a member of staff but since your hair was soft ill let you off with a warning

She has to close her eyes before she could press send. And then she did, and the message was delivered. It was only after she sent it that she realised she'd accidentally capitalised Adora's name. She doesn't usually do that, it's a waste of time. Huh.

*Read*.

Catra immediately snaps to worst-case-scenario mode when that one little word pops up.

*Oh god oh god oh god that was too forward she's gonna stop she's not going to reply stupid Catra that was too much she's just being nice she–*

**Adora (20:02)** What's the warning? 🤔

Catra stares at the message for a moment. Is this flirting? Is Adora flirting with her? Only one way to find out for sure...

**Catra (20:04)** if you say shit like that again i may not be able to stop at just your hair

*It was so soft!* Catra thinks to herself, thinking back to the moment when she first clocked Adora sitting with her friends. She hadn't meant to walk over to them, but seeing Adora with different hair, with *shorter* hair, had made her relinquish control of her body to her desires for a moment. Before she knew what was happening, her *hand* was in Adora's *hair*, and it was *so flucking soft!*

It shouldn't have felt so good to have her claws against Adora's head, but it *did*, it felt *amazing*. Catra wants to do it again. Another string of messages vibrates her phone a number of times before she reads them.

**Adora (20:09)** Sorry, just had to escape from the roommates 😅
**Adora (20:09)** I'm in my room now
**Adora (20:09)** They can be pretty nosey 🙄
**Adora (20:10)** But they mean well!

*Yeah*, Catra thinks to herself while glancing up at Scorpia, now finished with her chilli yet still enraptured by the movie, *yeah they do*.

**Adora (20:12)** Can I call you?

*Oh*. That's new. Adora's never asked to call before, they've only texted. The only times Catra's been able to speak to her was at the café when she'd order a drink...

'Hey, Scorp?' Catra asked, peering at her friend from over the top of the phone while apparently trying to hide behind it. 'I'm going to go to my room to take a call, if that's okay? You can keep watching the film, I'll tidy up our bowls and do the washing up so don't worry about–'

'Hey,' Scorpia interrupted, a soft, knowing smile warming up her face, 'it's alright, Wildcat. Go talk to your girl.'

'What! S-she's not my–' Catra sputtered in a weak attempt to defend herself, but Scorpia just gave her The Look, the one she gives Catra when she knows she's being stupid. 'Whatever. Don't clean up.'

'I won't!' She will.

**Catra (20:14)** one sec

***

*'Hey.'*

'Hi.'

The silence that seemed to stretch on beyond that initial *"hello"* didn't feel all that silent at all. It was almost as if the air had grown thicker in Catra's room after just hearing Adora's voice. Well, her phone voice, but it's still *her*. It's still *Adora*.

Catra's mind was also racing. Asking herself *why* would Adora call her? She also feels like she has so much she wants to say, so much she wants to talk about, but no idea how to start. Whatever kind of relationship they have right now felt like it started ages ago, but the reality was that they've only been *really* speaking for a week or so. But, despite that, Catra *trusts* Adora. Really *trusts* her. And she hasn't felt that toward anyone other then Scorpia in a long, long time.

Plus, also, she's completely in love with this girl and is frozen as if a school crush just brushed hands with her in the hallway.

She doesn't want to mess this up, whatever *this* is, and can't find the right words to say.

Thankfully, she doesn't have to.

*'So,'* Adora starts, tentatively choosing her words as if she's afraid Catra will hang up, *'how are you?'*

Catra smiles, glad to not have to start their conversation, and the tension just ebbs away from her as if it were never there to begin with. 'I'm good, Adora. Are you okay? Why did you want to call?'

There was a pause on the other end of the line, but Catra could still hear Adora breathing. She was taking deep breaths, maybe calming herself down? Why would she need too calm herself?

*'Yeah, yeah I'm okay. I just, um... I've been thinking about, well, a lot of things for a while and I just—I really—I just suddenly needed t-to hear your voice.'*

'My voice?' Catra asked, half stunned. Why would–*oh my god she really does like me. Okay.*

*'Yeah, is that—is that okay?'*

'Yes!' Catra said, a little too fast for her own comfort, 'I mean, yeah, of course. I don't mind. Your—I mean—it's nice to hear from you too.'

There was a long, pregnant pause on the other end, and then, *'could I ask you something?'*

'Sure?' Catra responded, unsure as to how else the blonde imagined she could have answered that request.

*'This might be a really personal question but I've been wondering... when did you know you were, um, gay? And, uh, are you... like specifically...'*

The magicat couldn't help but smile at the boldness of Adora's train of thought. 'Am I a lesbian?'

*'...yeah.'*

Catra's smile spread to become a wide grin. She was suddenly feeling very confident with herself and loved being asked that question so she could reply with something along the lines of: 'yes, Adora, I'm a fucking *massive* lesbian.'

Adora laughed, a sweet melodic sound that made Catra's chest ache. In a good way, a warm way. *'Okay, ha, good. Me too.'*

'Awesome.' It was. Catra had half expected this call to be something mundane, but the actual content was not bad. Not bad at all.

*'When did you know?'*

'When did I know I like girls?' Catra asked with a small frown.

*'Yeah.'*

*Okay, just diving right in. Why the hell not?*

'Oh, well, it's kind of always been girls, for me. I think it started when I was really young. I was still getting used to how intense all my senses were, like, it wasn't sudden. I think I mentioned something like that you before?'

*'Uhm, yeah, you said you didn't realise how sharp your claws were until you were told off for scratching stuff up at school.'*

Catra smiled at the fact that Adora remembered something so mundane from an earlier text conversation. She's so thoughtful and considerate that Catra doesn't really know how to act around her.

'Yeah that's right. But up until I was maybe four or five, I was pretty much the same as a human except for, well, the fur, ears and tail. But one day I could hear just, *everything* around me, seeing in the dark developed slower, my claws slowly got longer and sharper, and the *smells*...'

*'Are you telling me you like girls because boys stink?'* Adora's voice sounded nice with a little teasing thrown in. Catra couldn't help but wonder if they would have been friends had she not been expelled from college.

'Yes, Adora, that is absolutely the *only* reason,' she replied, hoping the roll of her eyes made it through the phone.

*'Wow, okay.'*

'What about you?' Catra asked the question carefully, *as if* pressing for more information from Adora would scare her off. Adora's already shared far too much in their texting, but Catra kind of finds how open she is endearing, so, *yeah*.

*'What about me?'*

'Well, I told you my lesbian origin story, what's yours?'

Another pause. Catra closed her eyes, focusing solely on the sound of Adora's breathing. Briefly, Catra wondered what it would feel like to actually lay her head on Adora's chest, hear her heartbeat, actually *feel* the rise and fall as she breathed in and out. Briefly, Catra allowed herself to yearn.

*"Mine's not quite as simple as yours,' Adora began, pausing for a moment to see if Catra would say anything. When she didn't, Adora continued, 'I already told you this, but I didn't know for sure until last year, and since then I've not really had much luck, like, romantically or anything. I've had some experience, y'know, in bed, but not… not a lot. That might be because it took a little longer for me to accept that I was, like, completely a lesbian, but that's what I am. That's who I am.'*

Catra made an affirming noise, turning to lay on her side and putting the phone on the pillow beside her face. It wasn't on speaker, but she could still hear it.

*'But I don't feel like I'm completely... I don't know. And, with my hair–'*

Catra's eyes suddenly snapped open and she sat up straight, bringing the phone back up to her ear. 'Adora, I'm sorry for doing what I did, back in the shop today.'

Adora's reply was small, hesitant, *'what do you mean?'*

'I just– I wanted to say that I was sorry for, you know, just putting my hand in your hair like that. It was too far, I just really wanted to– whatever. It looks—you look—really... really good, Adora.' A small part of Catra had felt bad about just putting her hand in Adora's hair. She kind of hoped Adora wouldn't ask *why* she did it, because she doesn't really *know*. She had just gotten a feeling, an *urge*, and then her hand was carding through short blonde hair with the girl in question leaning into her touch.

*'Yeah?'* Came the reply after a moment. It was small, almost unsure.

'Yeah,' Catra replied, making sure she sounded like she meant it.

*'Cool. It's... I mean, I feel good. Can I—can I tell you something weird? You might laugh at me, or think it's stupid...'*

Where is this going? 'Uh, sure? I promise I won't laugh.'

*'Okay. I haven't told this to anyone else yet, so bare with me...'* Catra heard the girl on the other end of the line take a deep breath, focusing for a moment on keeping her breathing steady. When she spoke again, her voice was heavy with a weight that Catra couldn't quite place. *'Um... After I had it done, I went to the bathroom and when I looked at myself in the mirror I just, kind of... starting crying? How weird is that?'*

'You cried?'

*'Mhm. Yeah...'*

'Was it... like a good cry or a bad cry?'

*'I don't know.'*

'Do you... Do you want me to... How does it make you feel?' Catra felt like she was getting an idea of what Adora was experiencing, especially since her gay realisation was only about a year ago. Adora may have been thinking about herself on a much deeper level during this past year than she ever has, and having such a drastic haircut has obviously opened up some kind of new direction that Adora hasn't thought about before.

*'Oh, uhm, I don't know. Happy? I like the way I look now. I really liked when I saw what you wrote on my cup. That felt nice.'*

'You like when I call you handsome?'

There was a soft hum of confirmation. Catra couldn't help but smile at the sound.

'Okay.'

*'Okay?'*

'Yeah, okay. You—I think you're really handsome, Adora.'

Adora's reaction was to produce the most cutest giggle-snort Catra's ever heard, and followed it up with a *thwump* (Catra guessed that was her dropping her phone) and saying something muffled that sounded like, 'says you!'

Catra smiled, lying down again and placing the phone next to her head on the pillow. 'You think *I'm* handsome?'

'Well, yeah!' Adora said, quite incredulously, as if any other statement would be factually incorrect. 'Handsome, beautiful, just– you're all the words, Catra. You always look amazing and I can't–'

'Can't what?' Catra asked in that tone of voice which she *knew* contained just the right amount of a teasing lilt.

'I can't stop looking at you,' Adora admitted, rushing the words out, 'and I don't want to.'

Catra smiled, closing her eyes and denying to herself that she was, in fact, purring. 'I don't want you too either,' she whispered, wholeheartedly meaning every word of it.

***

Catra awoke the next morning still fully dressed, having not changed before starting her call with Adora, nor during. Her phone was on the floor, thankfully plugged in, where it must have fallen from the bed during the night. She reached for it, stretching a little to where it bounced just a little out too far away to easily grab, and flipped it over. Catra sat up with it now in-hand, and squinted down at the four messages on the screen.

The first text made her roll her eyes, because *of course*. Scorpia is too good for this world.

**Scorp (21:28)** Finished the movie and tidied up and washed all our plates. Your extra portions of chilli are tubbed up in the freezer. Don't stay up too late talking to your girl, I still expect you in bright and early to open up tomorrow ;) goodnight Wildcat

After feeling a pang of guilt for accidentally leaving her friend alone to clean up by herself, for which she'll apologise for profusely when they meet up at work, she turned her attention to the next few messages. Her heart leaped into her throat when she saw who sent them, and Catra made sure to take her time reading each one, before re-reading them again a couple more times for good measure. *Just in case*.

**Adora (01:12)** Goodnight, Catra
**Adora (01:13)** I had to hang up because you fell asleep, but I really enjoyed talking with you about everything

**Adora (01:15)** Do you always purr when you sleep?

*No,* Catra thought to herself while failing to resist her cheeks flushing bright red, *I don't.*

*Not always.*

***

Come Wednesday morning, despite Adora calling again the night before and starting another until-the-early-hours-of-the-morning call, Catra's mood was completely soured by a particularly aggravating customer who seemed to think he'd managed to unlock some kind of secret code to access a non-existent "secret menu" that Bright Moon Coffee Co. apparently hid from regular customers.

'But I'm not just *any* customer,' The Prick said, puffing out his chest as if he'd just bought the place, 'I'm *important*.'

'Oh yeah?' Catra asked, utterly disinterested. *Please just get on with it*. 'Even so, I'm going to have to ask that you order something *on* the menu, sir.'

The Prick sputtered for a moment, apparently surprised that Catra wasn't backing down. 'I demand you serve me the,' he tried to hide looking down at his phone, 'the Spritzy Sugar Special, else I will be in contact with Angella Moon herself.'

'The mayor?' Catra raised an eyebrow, if he thinks *that* name has any sway over actual businesses in Krytis he's dead wrong.

'The very same.' Oh he does. *Bless*.

Catra rolled her eyes, deciding to just make him a flat white with a little extra sugar, and maybe some marshmallows for good measure.

'Ohh, is this it?' He asked, non the wiser as Catra placed the drink in front of him.

She just shrugged, charged The Prick for *two* flat whites to really sell the guise that he'd ordered something "secret", and said 'next!'

When the absolute *prick* of a customer finally stepped aside with his coffee, huffing and puffing about "sub-par service" this and "wouldn't get this anywhere else" that, the next customer in line stepped forwards, and Catra froze. Her brain slowly shutting down as she realised who it was and what they were wearing.

It was Adora. Tennis-racket bag slung over one shoulder, white shorts, purple polo-shirt with big pink capital letters spelling "KUT" across the front, with "Krytis University Tennis" underneath in smaller copy. Her short, amazingly soft-looking hair was slightly obscured by her white sun visor cap. It was no wonder Catra hadn't initially recognised Adora when she first came in, but now that she did Catra found that she couldn't look away. Adora looked *amazing*, stupidly hot, and images of her moving around on a court, racket in hand, fleetingly sped through Catra's mind in the few seconds between Adora stepping forwards and arriving at the counter.

Adora smiled, and Catra had to grab her tail to stop it from giving away how flustered she was.

'Catra! Hey! I um—I wanted to ask you something, if that's okay?' Her smile faltered a little, and Catra could tell by the subtle change in the blonde's expression that, for some reason, she was nervous and trying to hide it.

'What is it?' Catra asked, trying to keeping her tone flat. Adora never mentioned that she played tennis, and now she just shows up at Catra's place of work looking like *that*? The absolute nerve–

'Will you go on a date with me!?'

Catra spluttered over nothing, choking on her own air, coughing into her hand while turning away to hide her face from the doe-eyed blonde. She dropped her tail in the process, and it swayed while reaching for ceiling behind her, betraying her growing excitement. 'What!?'

'Well, I just—I've been thinking about it since Monday, and my friends have been trying to convince me that it would be okay to ask... I know it's sudden, and we've barely spoken but... I would really love it if you would go on a date with me.'

Catra didn't know what to say. She stood up straight, fighting back tears that wanted to betray her to her friend/manager stood just a few feet away behind the line, the other customers and responsibilities of her job forgotten in favour of this far more important question that was *begging* for an answer.

'Catra?' Adora seemed to have shrunk in on herself when Catra didn't reply, and Catra kicked herself for letting that happen.

'Yes!' Catra answered before she could think about it any more, before she would inevitably do something stupid like letting her insecurities catch up with her and forcing her to say "no", despite that being the last thing she wanted to say, 'yes, Adora. I —I would... I would really like to go on a date with you.'

'YES!' Adora cheered, turning around to shout, 'she said yes!' to her friends standing just inside the café door. Catra hadn't even noticed they were there. Somehow, Catra didn't even mind that the blonde had needed moral support to ask this of Catra. Adora's declaration was followed by a round of whooping and clapping from the giddy pairing loitering in the entryway, and Catra couldn't help the smile that spread across her face. 'So, um, when—when are you free?'

'Oh, uh–'

'I only ask, cause, well—I was wondering—would you come to my match this afternoon? I know I'm all dressed up already but I like to warm up before a game. This isn't the actual date! I just thought it would be really cool if you would come,' Adora rubbed the back of her neck, chuckling a little to herself, 'maybe as a way to start getting to know me more?'

Catra's stomach dropped. She wanted to go. *Of course she wanted to go!* But she was supposed to be working a full day today. 'Adora... I'm really sor—'

'Well!' Came a shout from beside Catra, almost making her leap into the air in surprise but was stopped by a huge red pincer draping over her shoulder, 'it's really lucky you're only doing a half-day today, huh, Wildcat?'

*Scorpia, you're my fucking hero.*

'Great!' Adora beamed, and Catra was blinded by the sincerity behind the smile. So what if she smiled back just as brightly? She's in love. 'I'll see you later, then?' Adora asked, eyes wide and sucking Catra in the longer she stared into them.

'Yeah, of course you will, dummy,' Catra said with a fond roll of her eyes. It was an excuse to look away, and the return of The Nickname seemed to make the blonde smile even wider.

(Adora forgot where her phone was last night while on call with Catra and, because she's a little shit, Catra just went along with it trying to suggest places she could have left it instead of just pointing out, what should have been, the obvious. It was a while

before she relented, drawling "you're talking into it, dummy" and revelling in Adora's reaction. Her flatmates seemed equally amused, and Catra wished she could have high-fived them in the moment.)

'Adora! We gotta go!' The pink one shouted from the entrance, breaking the little bubble Catra and Adora had found themselves in. Adora smiled again, Catra's heart squeezed, then the blonde waved goodbye and bounced over to her waiting friends who promptly pulled her into a group hug. Catra could only watch as the scene unfolded, marvelling at just how happy Adora looked in that moment and realising that she, too, could not stop smiling.

But she was going on a *date*. A date with *Adora*. *Where to?* Who knows? It doesn't matter, Catra couldn't care less. She just wants to spend time with Adora outside of work. She just *wants*.

It's a few minutes later when she realises that Scorpia must have manually driven her to the break room, because she didn't remember walking there herself. Scorpia couldn't be blamed for her suddenly ending up on top of the cupboards though, that's on her subconscious wanting to get somewhere *high up* because of her nerves spiking.

'What are you doing to me?' Catra muttered to herself, unable to stop thinking about *Adora* and *short hair* and, of all things, *tennis*.

Speaking of tennis, Catra's pretty sure that Adora was wearing the men's KUT gear, because she's seen tennis girls in the shop before and they have sleeveless things and skirts on.

Catra's never questioned her identity on the level she's pretty sure Adora is right now, and she spends the rest of her break on top of the cupboards thinking about it.

She wants to ask, to check in with Adora, see how she's feeling about things. But asking on the phone feels too impersonal, and she's fully prepared to give hugs if she needs to. Hell, Catra would kill (metaphorically) to cuddle Adora, and she's pretty sure Adora will probably die (metaphorically) when she does.

*When*.

Catra stayed on top of the cupboards in the break room for a lot longer than she meant to, but when Scorpia comes to find her she doesn't seem to mind. She isn't even surprised at where she finds Catra hanging out. Again.

Before she really registers what's going on, Catra is out the door and texting Adora where she should go.

Adora **(13:28)** I'm so happy you're coming! I'll ping you my location!
Adora **(13:29)***Adora shared her location! Tap now to see where she is!*
Adora **(13:29)** I might be on the court but you can hang out with Bow and Glimmer
Adora **(13:29)** They might question you but they're nice I promise

Catra **(13:30)** can't wait Adora
Catra **(13:30)** see you soon

Catra **(13:31)** ❤️

Chapter End Notes

There will be a part 4, I'm not evil.

(I am but that's by the by)

# Chapter 4

Chapter Summary

Adora preps for her tennis match and Catra meets the roommates.

Chapter Notes

The summary is, as usual, an oversimplification of events.

TW / CW for homophobia and transphobia in this chapter. It starts around “Oh, look, it’s Adora” and ends around “But one girl stayed behind”.

A bunch of new tags have also been added, and the chapter count still evades me.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora hasn't told anyone this yet, and by this point is pretty sure she will never tell a soul, but ever since she accidentally kinda maybe clued Catra in to how she feels about her, Adora's been doing some reading.

Well, more reading.

She's never crushed on a hybrid before, not like this—not this *intensely* —and the absolute last thing she wants to do is somehow be unprepared to deal with any specific needs that Catra has that she might overlook. Adora's been an absolute mess on dates with regular old humans before, which means now that she's asked out a hybrid (well, not just any hybrid, a magicat, *Catra* . Adora's still kind of in disbelief that she said yes) she wants to be prepared and ready and really, really doesn't want to mess it up.

However, none of the hybrid-specific articles actually have any dating advice, or useful ideas for where to take a magicat on a date. Instead, Adora finds herself reading through more mundane articles of generic date ideas in the Krytis area.

Glimmer would murder her if she found out, but Adora's so clueless about what to do she ends up reading through a rather obvious clickbait article titled *Top 10 Gay-stenations in Krytis* . Really, she should just ask her friends for advice, but Adora was kind of doubtful that she'd even get this far, so in spending all that time psyching herself up enough to actually ask Catra on a date—not to mention a few hours last night just kind of looking at herself in the mirror—Adora didn't actually consider the *where* of the date.

Adora sighs when she reaches the end of the stupid article, that was more than likely written by someone who hadn't even been to any of the places (and was more than likely not even gay), before turning off her phone and placing it in her locker. Catra hadn't texted anything more since the heart emoji, which Adora may have stared at for a bit too long and probably read a bit too much into, but she had a tennis match to limber up for and then needed to get out of the locker room to play it. She hoped that Catra would find and sit with her roommates, but Adora wasn't really sure if she would sit with them even if she did find them. Catra didn't know them, after all. And, even though the stands were nowhere near as full as they would be during the actual matches, they were still pretty big and the chances of Catra seeing and sitting with her friends were fairly low.

Sure, the match was only a pre-season one and would mainly decide who would play singles and who would be paired up in the real matches against other Universities, but it would still be taken seriously by her coach and teammates.

Not that she really wants to be paired with most of her teammates, they’re kind of—

'Oh, look it's Adora!' Comes the hushed whisper from behind her, followed by more whispering and giggling. Adora stiffens, taking a deep breath before they inevitably speak up and— 'Still wearing the boy's kit, Adora? Whatever, weirdo, suit yourself.'

—mean. They’re kind of mean. Inexplicably so. Adora remembers checking with their coach, she’s allowed to wear the kit she’s most comfortable in. Coach had even mentioned that the boys could wear the girls kit if they so pleased, it didn't matter to her as long as they wore the Krytis Uni colours and didn't make fools of themselves on or off the court.

That certain posse of giggling whisperers also fell silent whenever the coach was around, which Adora had noticed, but she didn't want to cause a fuss by saying anything. They weren't harming her, not physically at least, so she could put up with it as long as they just left her to—

'And what's with the *shit* hair? Are you trying to look like a *boy?'*

'Just leave me alone, please,' Adora mumbles toward her locker, just hoping that those girls will leave her alone and not continue to pester her before her game. She takes a deep breath, trying to just ignore their words and calm herself down.

Is she trying to look like a boy? No. No, that doesn't sound right. But she's definitely not trying to look overly... *girly,* either. What the hell *is* she doing?

'You what, Gayskull? Looking up our skirts not enough for you? What a fucking joke. You shouldn't be in here if you're trying so hard to look like a boy now. Maybe you should just put your stuff in the hallway, cause the boys won't want you either you homo sla—'

'FUCK OFF!'

Adora's eyes immediately go wide. She whirls around, fully prepared to apologise for her outburst, but the look on the face of– of... *Girl A* standing across the locker room, surrounded by her posse, gives her pause to reconsider.

'You want to say that again, A-*gay*-ra?'

Adora takes a breath, squares her shoulders, and fixes Girl A with a glare. Yeah, normally she'd back down. Normally, she'd never have said anything at all, just tried to ignore it and move on (it never worked). Today, though... today, the girl she liked said yes to go on a date with her. Today was special and, frankly, Adora was sick of the sight of Girl A. 'I said shut the fuck up, you homophobic piece of SHIT!'

It felt good.

That is, until Girl A's fist connected with her face.

Adora stumbles backwards, hitting her head on the lockers and sliding down them to land on the tiled floor in an uncomfortable heap.

Girl A and her followers quickly flee the scene, most of them whispering things like *"what the fuck was that"* and *"holy shit you're mental runrunrun"* .

But one girl stayed behind.

Adora looks up at her, vaguely aware of the pain from hitting her head as well as the ache under her eye where no doubt a tasty bruise is forming. *What will Catra think?* The leftover girl seems unsure of what to do, looking after her friends as if to follow but glancing back down at Adora just as much.

'Are you okay?' She whispers down toward the vaguely body shaped heap on the floor, almost as if she's afraid that she'll be caught staying behind and seemingly showing care for the– the... girl (?) who her leader just punched in the face. 'I'm sorry about... y'know...'

Adora swallows down the cry that she knows her body wants to sing, and holds back her tears while looking up at the girl. 'I'm fine,' she croaks, definitely not sounding fine.

'Blondie, my office, now.'

Adora turns to face the entrance of the locker room, where her coach now stands with an unreadable expression on her face. She isn't looking at Adora, though, instead her attention is focused on the girl that stayed behind—almost as if she's surprised to still see her there. 'I want to see you afterwards too, you're going to tell me everything that happened. Bring Adora an ice pack too, for her eye.'

The girl (Adora kind of wants to know her name now, maybe she'll speak to her after to thank her for her concern) stands up a little straighter and does her best to look Coach in the eye despite the intensity of the gaze she's being fixed with, 'yes, Coach.'

Coach just nods, looking back down at Adora with what seems to be halfway between an apologetic expression and a scowl. 'Come on, on your feet. You're not in trouble, but you do have a game soon. Chop chop.'

Adora pushes herself up from the floor, following Coach from the room while looking down at the ground. She offers the girl (Adora will definitely ask her name later, so she can thank her properly) a small smile and a nod, which the girl returns. That

helps to lighten Adora's mood a little, at least.

Coach's office isn't far, and Adora's soon seated in the chair in front of the desk while Coach herself just sort of paces around the room. The silence is deafening, and Adora can't help it when a few tears start rolling down her cheeks against her will. She tries to wipe them away as quickly as she can, but Coach chooses that precise moment to sit down on the other side of the desk and no doubt sees everything.

'Okay, Blondie. I know I'm your tennis coach, but this kind of shit is what I'm here for too. *Talk to me.* While you're in this building, on this team, you're under *my* care, whether you like it or not. But I can't help if you don't tell me what's wrong.'

And that's just it, isn't it? Something is wrong, but Adora doesn't really know where to start.

She tries anyway, because Huntara's always been nice to her.

'I don't know,' isn't really a great start, but it kind of summarises everything. Adora decides to expand anyway, 'I don't know what's wrong. You said it's okay to wear this kit, and I got a haircut, and both of those things felt good but... but I've just been punched for standing up for myself when someone called me out for it so now I– I feel like I'm doing something wrong and—' Adora has to cover her face to hide how it contorts under the sob that she can't hold back anymore. To her credit, Huntara is patient with her, just letting Adora get it out of her system.

The soft knock on the door silences Adora. She holds her breath while Huntara stands and rounds her desk, opening the door and whispering something to the person on the other side. Then, the door closes again, and an ice pack drops onto the desk in front of her. Adora picks it up wordlessly, holding it up to her eye and shivering a little at the sudden chill.

'Starla's waiting in the hall, and I'll ask her about what happened in more detail while you're playing your match. Afterwards, though, you come straight back here. If I'm not here, you come in and wait. I want to talk to you both about what happened so I can put a stop to it.'

*Starla.* Adora commits the name to memory before making a mental note to thank her properly after their joint interrogation.

'Now, if you're up to it, you still have your match with,' Huntara's eyes flick to the chart on her wall for a moment, 'Mermista to play. If you want, I can put a hold on it or—'

'No!' Adora blurts, before looking up at the chart herself, 'no, it's okay. I'm okay. I can do it.'

Coach smiles a toothy grin, her pointy white teeth contrasting against the purple of her skin. 'Well then, give her hell, Gray.'

Adora thanks her coach again and leaves soon after, offering Starla, who's sitting on a chair outside the office door, another smile. Starla looks like she's about to say something, but doesn't, instead heading into Huntara's office and closing the door behind her.

Adora only realises her hands are shaking after she gets back to the locker room and exchanges the ice pack for her racket. She tries to take a few deep breaths. It helps a little, but it doesn't calm her internal storm of confusion and emotions. Adora wishes that she could just know what's happening, what's wrong, what doesn't feel right and what does.

Then, a pair of heterochromatic eyes settle into her mind, along with a dangerous smile and the sound of a beautiful laugh and, suddenly, Adora's turmoil calms.

If there's one thing that feels right, it's Catra.

Catra is the most sure Adora's been about anything in a while. It's then, while Adora walks toward the exit onto the court, that she remembers that Catra should be here to watch. She wants to impress her *maybe* future girlfriend (fingers crossed that Adora can come up with a date location), to show off a little.

But then, as Adora steps out into the sun, she remembers she has a black eye and the events of the last 15 minutes or so come back with a vengeance. Reluctantly, she glances around the stands, looking for– *there!* Catra's there! Standing next to where her friends are sitting. But... she's frowning.

She knows. She's seen.

Adora ducks her head, walking toward the edge of the court where Catra is coming down to meet her, and fights away the guilty tears that want to fall.

***

'Hey!'

Catra's barely had chance to look around the tennis court when a somewhat familiar voice calls out to her. It's one of Adora's friends, the not-sparkly one, standing on his chair and waving over to her. She's vaguely aware that she's still in her work clothes, but she was too excited to remember to change and she's here now, so screw it.

Walking over to Adora's friends feels ominous, somehow, like she's walking into a spotlight and everything about her is about to be laid bare. Adora said her friends may ask her questions, and she may have been worrying herself about what kind of questions for the rest of her walk toward the campus.

Catra stops next to them, offering a small *hey* in greeting, before moving to sit down. Before she does though, she casts another glance around the court, familiarising herself with the layout of the place in case she needs to... *why would she need to run?*

'So,' the pink one starts, and Catra's flight instinct kicks in immediately. She fights it down just as, 'what are your intentions with our best fr—'

But Catra stops listening, because Adora walks out onto the court and looks *amazing* in the sun. Until she starts to look around the stands and Catra meets her eye. Adora freezes on the court, and ducks her head. But Catra's already seen.

'Something's wrong.'

'What? What's wrong?' Pinky asks, looking down to follow Catra's line of sight.

Her friend sitting next to her is oblivious, however, and just shouts excitedly, 'oh! There's Adora! ADORA!' He jumps up, waving his arms around, but Catra's already moving.

'Just... give me a sec. I'll be right back,' she rushes out, already out of their row and focusing on not tripping as she makes her way down toward Adora, who's ducked her head and is shuffling forwards to meet her. Catra's never seen Adora like this, looking so small and reserved like she's done something wrong. But then Catra's standing in front of her, and Adora turns to look her in the eye. Catra's stomach drops at the sight.

'Oh my god. Adora?' Catra holds her hands out, and Adora lets her face fall between them as if they've done it a million times before. They haven't. Catra doesn't know why she did it, but she can't argue with the results—but that doesn't matter right now, not really. What matters is the fact that Adora got a black eye sometime between leaving the coffee shop and now and, 'what the fuck? What happened to your face? Are you okay?'

'Yeah,' Adora practically chokes on the word before clearing her throat and starting again. Catra's heart almost breaks at the way Adora forces herself to smile, to meet Catra's eyes with her own, knowing that she must look like she's been crying. 'Yeah, Cat,' Adora tries again, 'I'm good. I– Can I– Can I tell you later? I have to...' Adora trails off, vaguely pointing with her racket toward the net, where the other girl—Adora's opponent—is idly picking at her nails, completely disinterested.

Catra wants to say yes, but, 'are you sure?'

Adora nods.

'Promise me,' Catra says, moving her hands to link her fingers around the back of Adora's neck as she looks up at her. Adora melts into her touch and Catra can't hold down her purr. 'Promise me you'll tell me what happened?'

Adora nods again, 'I promise. I'll– I'll tell you.'

'Okay,' Catra quickly drops her hands back down to her sides before her body makes her do something incredibly stupid, and clears her throat a little in an attempt to fight down the blush that's no doubt dusting her cheeks right now. 'Go, um, show me what you got, or something,' Catra mumbles, looking anywhere but at Adora lest her pupils double in size and her cheeks get any redder.

Adora laughs, and Catra's purr ramps up against her will as her ears twitch to soak in the sound. She also grips her tail for good measure to stop it from giving away how flustered she is any more than the rest of her is.

'Okay, Catra,' Adora says, and Catra almost trills at the way her name sounds when Adora says it. 'I have to talk to my coach after this but then I'll come find you and we can... I'll tell you about it then, okay?'

'Okay,' Catra agrees. Nodding and moving to step back. Before she can get out of arm's reach, Adora grabs her and pulls her back in, wrapping her arms around Catra's waist and—

*Oh.*

*Oh, this is nice.*

Catra can't hide her purr anymore. Not as she's being embraced so tightly. Her arms betray her, wrapping back around Adora's neck as her tail wraps around the blonde's waist as if to pull them closer together despite the wall between them.

She breathes in Adora's scent, basking in it as much as she can, and fights down the urge to rub her cheek against Adora's shoulder, neck, and jaw to mark her as Catra's. She's only just been asked out, on a date they've yet to go on, for crying out loud; one thing at a time.

'Thank you.'

Catra isn't really sure what she's being thanked for when Adora whispers it into her shoulder, but if all of Adora's hugs are like this, it's definitely something she could get used to. Catra just nods in response, letting one of her hands wander to card through Adora's short hair; she's purring too loud to whisper anything back.

***

'What was that about?' The pink haired one asks once Catra returns to sit one seat away from them. She looks inquisitive, but there's a gleam in her eye that Catra really doesn't trust. In contrast to the boy next to her, who's practically got hearts in his eyes.

Catra may have forgotten that Adora's friends would be watching when they were down there...

'Adora's got a black eye,' are the words that escape Catra's mouth before she thinks too hard about what to say. She winces a little as both of their expressions drop. ‘She seems okay!' Catra rushes to reassure them, 'she said she'd tell me about it after.'

The pink, sparkly, cloud of candy floss frowns, looking down at the court where they're about ready to start playing. 'Adora's been kind of spacey since her haircut. Me and Bow think she may be... well, questioning some things and... we know that she got some grief from some girls when she first came out. They were at the party when I asked if she’s gay and overhead her say she liked girls and then outed her in front of everyone, pretty much. It was rough.'

'Oh, shit,' was all Catra could really say to that. And her chest tightens a little that Adora hadn't told her, but why would she? It can't be a good memory. 'That fucking sucks.'

'Yeah,' Croptop pipes up, 'it took her so long to open up to us that anything was wrong, and we didn't know until it had all calmed down and she felt comfortable enough to tell us. So if that's happening again because she's...'

He trails off, but Catra understands. 'I get it,' she says, watching as Adora throws the ball over to the blue haired girl on the other side of the net. 'I don't know if I should tell you this, so don't tell her you know, but she told me that she cried in the bathroom after her haircut. That's when I started, y'know, wondering.'

Sparkles nods solemnly, 'yeah, we didn't know that.' Catra quickly gets the idea that these two are actually one entity and there's no secrets between them. 'If she opens up to you, please listen. She's put her trust in you. I know she'll tell us when she's ready.'

Catra flushes, figuring it's now or never to answer the question that Glitter was going to ask before she bolted down to see Adora. 'You don't have to worry about that,' she starts, choosing her words carefully, 'I really do... like Adora. She's just– she's– it's– Agh! *Fuck it!* She's amazing, okay? She's fucking perfect and everything I've ever wanted and so, so sweet all the time whenever we speak and I'm already so stupidly—'

The words *in love with her* die in Catra's throat as the game begins. Blue Hair serves the ball and Adora moves to intercept it. Catra watches as she lunges for the ball, swings, and—

—and Catra's transfixed.

She can't look away.

Well, she could, but she's not living in a world where she particularly wants to. Catra likes her current reality just fine, thanks.

Adora is a beast on the tennis court. Whoever it is she's up against, who has one hell of a fan showing his support standing behind her in the stands, she doesn't really hold a candle to how Adora just effortlessly glides around the court.

One time. One time Catra's been teased with a laser pointer. She was little, the kids were assholes, but *man* that little red dot just needed getting, y'know?

Anyway... This is kind of like that, except it's Catra's crush that's flitting around her vision, and not a concentrated laser of red light. Catra's pupils still double in size and stick to the blonde as if she is a little red dot anyway, though.

Beside her, Catra is vaguely aware of the sound of cooing and giggling. Her ear swivels toward the sound and it quickly cuts off. Before she can stop herself, she's faced with the sight of Sparkles and Croptop aiming their phones at her, either recording or taking pictures, and she knows she's caught. Her cheeks instantly blaze a fiery red as her ears pin back in embarrassment. She ducks her head, holding up a hand to hide her face. It doesn't have the desired effect, only seeming to encourage Adora's friends more, who start giggling again while being a thousand percent more obvious with their recording.

'Quit it!' Catra hisses, 'I'm trying to watch the—'

'Trying to watch your girlfriend?' Pinky quips, hiding behind her phone and no doubt catching the way Catra's pupils dilate as that thought rushes through her head.

'Fuck off, Sparkles! We're not... girlfriends,' anyone else with magicat hearing would've heard the *yet* that Catra mutters under her breath, 'and stop recording me!'

To his credit, Croptop actually looks apologetic, putting his phone away with a sheepish smile, but Sparkler just plows on, undeterred.

'Okay, first of all, my name is *Glimmer.* And second, if you're not already you will be soon, Adora's never crushed on someone like this before.'

'Well neither have I!' Catra clamps her hand over her mouth as her eyes go wide. Glimmer's face contorts into something *evil* . What the fuck, Catra! *Shut up!* 'Turn that off now! Stop it!' She leaps across the seat separating them, but Glimmer just hops over the seat in front, beaming up at Catra like she thinks she just did something.

'Really, Glitter?' Catra drawls, easily stepping over the seat to be level with the fiery sprite of a girl.

'It's *Glimmer.* Glim *mer!* '

'Yeah, don't care. Are you really going to make me chase you?'

'Maybe I'm just testing you,' and Catra doesn't miss the way Glimmer's eyes flick over her body.

Catra smirks, making a show of limbering up and cracking all the joints she can, just to be annoying. Croptop doesn't seem thrilled with the sounds, but Glimmer's focus never wavers as she watches the show. Once Catra's done, she decides to play with her prey a little, making a show of biting her lower lip and mirroring the way Glimmer's eyes feasted on her before. When Catra makes eye contact again, Glimmer is flushed red, her cocky bravado gone in an instant.

Catra cackles, and taunts, 'is that all you got?'

Glimmer just nods, sitting on the seat below Croptop and putting her phone away, wordlessly going back to watching the game. Catra, far too amused by Glimmer's obviousness, leaps up to the row behind Croptop and leans forward to whisper in his ear. 'Hey, Croptop. I think your girlfriend was checking me out, you wanna reel her in?'

Croptop chuckles, leaning forward to ruffle Glimmer's hair a bit. Glimmer just smooths it down again. 'Glimmer can be impulsive. My name's Bow, by the way.'

'No shit. Bow as in archery or Beau as in—'

'The first one, actually, yeah. My last name is also Archer, so...'

'Oh, wow, your parents had fun with that one, huh?'

'My dads like to think they're pretty funny, yeah.'

Catra nods, her focus shifting to watching the girl she's going on a date with hitting a ball back and forth across a net with a *really hot* level of determination. Distantly, Catra wonders if Adora's trying to show off, or if that's just as into it as she normally gets.

'How long do these things last, anyway?' Catra hears herself ask.

Bow ponders for a moment. 'This is a best of three, so it could take anywhere between twenty to ninety minutes. They don't usually go on longer than that. Best of five matches can go on for hours, though.'

Catra hums while she mulls over his answer, and knows that she'll never get tired of the view if it's Adora she's looking at. Especially if Adora's doing *this* , getting all worked up and sweaty down there on the court while Catra watches.

'That's so cute!' Catra blinks, caught out, and glances down to see Bow looking up at her with hearts in his eyes. Again. Glimmer's still recovering.

'What? I am not cute!' She growls for good measure.

'You were purring,' he coos as Catra huffs. She sits back as far as she can, crossing her arms over her chest and looking away while she grumbles about being caught purring while watching Adora.

Adora's friends, overall, are pretty annoying. But, Catra thinks she could put up with them. Maybe even get used to them. They seem nice, after all, and obviously care about Adora a lot, even if Adora apparently doesn't let them in as much as she probably should.

Catra watches as Bow leans forward again, scratching through Glimmer's *not bad at all* undercut, and marvels at the way she leans into his touch. She smiles at the trust Bow has in his girlfriend, and at how much they're obviously in love with each other, then looks back down at Adora and finds herself aching for that kind of comfort. She thinks she can have it with Adora, but the intensity of her feelings are still kind of scaring her, and she desperately doesn't want to screw this up no matter if all the signs point to Adora liking her back. Anything could happen to cause the pin to drop and Adora to distance herself from whatever it is they could have.

Catra closes her eyes and tries to silence the thoughts that tell her she doesn't deserve it and instead thinks of the way Adora's eyes light up whenever she looks at her. It helps, a little, but then her thoughts stray to Adora's black eye and how she could have gotten it, and then how Adora said she's going to tell her what happened, and she gets to worrying again.

It'll be fine.

It'll all be fine.

Chapter End Notes

I wrote this chapter because I have no internet to access the doc where MoE is stored so I hope you enjoyed :P

Next time: a conversation.

# Chapter 5

Chapter Summary

Catra helps Adora find who they are.

Chapter Notes

CW in this chapter for soft lesbians in love.
They're so in love.

Thank you to everyone who's read this already and given it a glowing review! You know who you are ;)

Also i set the chapter count to 10 but it's a working total and may change..

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora bursts into tears as soon as she leaves the building after her and Starla's meeting with Huntara. She hurries to the nearest secluded bench she knows of, one she'd visited all too often in the past, and immediately buries her face in her hands as she let herself cry. Her racket bag slides off her shoulder, and she lets it fall to the ground with a muffled thud.

*Isla*. The girl who seems to hate the very idea of Adora's existence is called Isla. The name quickly replaced *Girl A* in Adora's mind, and she's not sorry that she didn't even know her name at first.

But now she does. Isla is a full, living, breathing person with a name, a family, friends, who spends so much of her time just *hating.* It kind of makes Adora feel sick, literally and metaphorically. Adora definitely thinks she might throw up, so she instead focuses on trying to control her breathing. But she also wonders if she is *sick*, like, fundamentally. Surely there has to be something intrinsically wrong with her for someone to hate her so *fiercely.*

*Right?*

Starla was already there in Huntara's office when Adora finished her game. They were just finishing up talking about the event in the locker room when Adora knocked on the door, because apparently Coach had been writing a *detailed* report about Isla and her gang as Starla explained what happened.

After Coach told Adora to sit down, a chair already prepared for her next to Starla's, she opened up the next page of the report and set Starla with a firm glare as she asked the girl to tell her as much as she could about what Isla had said and done in the past.

There was... there was *a lot.*

Adora wasn't the only person who Isla hated with a passion, apparently.

Was something wrong with *all* of them? That didn't make any sense. It seemed like much *effort* on Isla's part for her to go out of her way just to bring people down and Adora just didn't understand *why.* Why hate so many people seemingly for no reason just because she can? Why can't she just live her own life instead of spending it making other's lives miserable?

Adora *knows* that all the things Isla has said to her, *about* her, aren't true. They *can't* be. But she can't help thinking about it. What if she really *is* a waste of space? A waste of life? Could someone else have done better in her place? Could a straight, girly Adora have done better with her life than the gay, *confused* Adora that currently lives in her body?

She doesn't know.

She doesn't *know.*

And it *hurts*.

So she cries. Adora cries on that bench until she can't cry anymore, and is left with a dry throat and sore eyes. She wonders if she looks like a mess, if Catra and Glimmer and Bow are looking for her. She should probably tell them where she is—

'Hey...'

Adora jolts, taken by surprise by the sudden appearance of Starla standing nearby, at a respectable distance, a look of worry and sorrow clouding her features. Adora opens her mouth to say something in return but Starla beats her to it.

'It's okay!' She blurts, holding out a hand in front of her as if to let Adora it's alright to stay sitting. Her other hand forms into a fist at her side as she shuffles a little, working up the courage to say what she wants to say. 'It's okay, you don't have to say anything. You don't owe me *anything*. But, I owe you an apology. A proper one. So... I'm sorry. I really am so sorry, Adora.'

Adora stands anyway, wiping her eyes on the bottom of her tennis shirt. Starla's eyes snap back up to meet Adora's once her shirt falls back into place, covering up her stomach again.

'You– uhm–' Starla stumbles over her words for a moment, 'you never– you didn't deserved any of that. I don't know why I hung around with her. Maybe I thought we were friends, I don't know. She was never very *friendly* with anyone, really. I won't hang around with her anymore though. I'm done with her. I just... I wanted you to know that.'

Adora nods, a small smile forcing its way onto her face. 'Okay.'

'None of it was true! You know that right? You're– you seem like a really cool person and you're not any of things she said you were.' The sincerity in Starla's eyes helps Adora to believe her, but Isla always had the same look in her eye. Like she meant it, every word, like it was *true.*

Adora just nods again, looking down at the ground. She decides to tell the truth. 'I know. I think. I'm... working on it.'

'Okay. Okay,' Starla smiles a little, then looks back toward the tennis courts. 'Listen, I've got– I have a match soon, but, could we exchange numbers? I'd really love to talk with you more, to perhaps– to maybe be friends. If you want that. I understand if not.'

'Yeah. Yeah, I'd like that,' Adora replies easily, offering Starla a kind smile, 'thank you for your help with everything, and for staying behind after Isla left. It– it means a lot, to know someone cares. Well, my other friends care too, probably, but someone else, y'know?'

Starla just laughs at Adora's awkward floundering, insisting that she gets it before offering Adora her phone. Adora inputs her number and hands it back, then waves as Starla makes her way back toward the courts.

Adora pulls out her own phone, half expecting to already have a message from Starla (there isn't one), and brings up Catra's contact instead.

It barely rings before Adora's greeted with the beautiful sound of Catra's voice.

*'Hey, Adora.'*

Adora just basks in it for a moment, humming to herself as she enjoys the way her name sounds when Catra says it.

*'Adora? You there?'*

*Shit.* 'Yes! Yeah, sorry, I– uh– I spaced out a little, I think,' Adora answers quickly, trying not to sound too croaky from all of her crying. She hopes it isn't noticeable through the phone.

*'Of course you were, Dummy. Oh, your roommates told me to tell you they went home, but I'm– I'm—'*

Adora isn't surprised that her roommates left already, they would see each other later, after all, no doubt to interrogate her about her black eye if Catra told them about it. But, part of her didn't expect Catra to stick around too, and her chest squeezes at the gesture. 'You're still here?'

*'I– Yeah, of course I am. I told Sparkles and Croptop I would hang around, and then after I said that they rushed off. All too eager to– um– to leave us alone, I guess. They're scarily supportive, by the way.'*

Adora sighs, enjoying for a moment how Catra's words make her feel incredibly warm inside; cared for. And how her friends obviously approve of Catra enough to leave them time alone together. 'Yeah, they are.'

*'So are you going to tell me where you are or am I supposed to guess? I'm outside the main entrance to the tennis... place.'*

'Oh! Right. Yes. I'll come find you. Just stay there,' Adora hurries, scrambling off the bench. She slings her racket bag over her shoulder and jogs back toward the tennis building with a smile on her face. 'See you soon!'

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If Catra notices that Adora's been crying, she doesn't mention it, and Adora is incredibly grateful. All of *that* is still pretty fresh, and she isn't ready to face it while they're still on campus.

But the hug is nice.

When Catra pulls away, she's smirking, and Adora feels her cheeks heat up *immediately*. Because apparently she just has no chill around Catra, whatsoever, and hoping to find some chill would undoubtedly be a fool's errand.

'The black eye *is* kind of badass, though,' Catra purrs, her smile mischievous where her eyes are soft. Adora feels *seen* in a way she doesn't usually. People don't often look at her the way Catra is, like she *knows* her, and it's kind of intimidating. Kind of scary.

Adora wants more.

In an attempt to hide her fluster that she hopes isn't too obvious, Adora clears her throat, and says, 'are you– uhh– are you free? Now? Do you have to go back to work, or...?'

Catra chuckles in a way that tells Adora she absolutely noticed her fluster, and even though she doesn't mention it verbally, the glint in her eye speaks volumes on its own. 'No. Scorpia let me off early, thanks to a certain someone, so I have the rest of the day off. I don't have any other plans, so I guess I'm all yours, Adora.'

If Adora replays those last few words in her head a few times, it's her business. But she can't hide the way her eyes fall shut, or the small hum of contentment she makes while she does it. When she opens her eyes again, Catra is looking off to the side, also blushing with her ears pinned back. Had she not meant to say that? Was Catra embarrassed?

'Well,' Adora starts, finding her voice again, 'I need to shower because, I mean, I *stink,* and I don't particularly want to be interrogated again... so...'

Catra turns back to Adora, looking her in the eye as if trying to find the hidden meaning behind the words. She finds it, because of course she does. 'You wanna come over, Adora? You want to shower at my place?' Adora thinks that's it, that's the extent of Catra's teasing on the subject, but then the magicat leans forward to whisper into Adora's ear, 'you want a hand?'

And Adora *dies.*

Catra cackles when Adora's breath hitches, her face flushing a deep red as her imagination takes *that* image and runs *wild* with it. Adora subconsciously wets her lips with her tongue, and finds her gaze falling to stare at Catra's lips. Her breathing feels heavy as she wonders how it would feel, what it would be like to close the short distance between them and—

'You're thinking about it, aren't you?' Are the words that Adora watches those lips form, and if she could blush any redder, she would have. But because she's her own worst enemy, Adora nods.

However, where Adora was thinking that would only give Catra more ammunition to taunt her with, what actually happens is the opposite. Catra blushes, and Adora watches as the fur on her arms bristles and Catra *shivers*, a barely audible squeak escaping her throat.

They're not even doing anything. They're just standing there, staring at each other, flustering one another with nothing but words, insinuations, and subtle movements. Both of them think, almost simultaneously, that no one has had this kind of effect on them before.

Catra is first to recover. She blinks a few times, looks around to get her bearings, then says, 'well, come on then,' and starts walking *away.*

Adora catches up quickly, trying to calm her *vivid* imagination. But then Adora feels Catra's hand brushing against hers. She turns her hand, *hoping,* and when Adora feels Catra's hand slide into hers, she thinks that nothing else has ever felt so right. That her hand was *made* to hold Catra's hand. She brushes her thumb against Catra's knuckle as they walk, marvelling at how soft the fine fur there feels, and has to restrain herself from just outright staring at the way Catra's hand fits so perfectly into hers.

They hold hands the rest of the way to Catra's Apartment, barely speaking a word to each other, and Adora doesn't think her heart has ever felt this full.

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Adora's in Catra's shower. Catra isn't sure whether or not she's actually going to fucking *survive* the evening. She wants Adora to stay over, and with the evening they've planned, which consists of eating together and then watching a film or two, not to mention the comfy clothes she's picked out for Adora, that's more than likely what's going to happen. Besides, if Adora *does* try to leave, Catra absolutely is not going to let her. It'll be too late to go out, so she may as well stay over anyway. *Right?* That's not weird, is it? To want Adora to stay? Catra knows that the urge to knead and to mark Adora is getting to breaking point by now. She can't hold back much longer, but she really needs to know if Adora would be okay with it before she gives in. They're *sort of* dating now though, the *promise* of a date has been made at least, so surely it wouldn't be too ridiculous of an ask. Catra takes a breath when she hears the shower shut off, steeling herself and working up the courage to ask something that Adora will probably not even think twice about.

But to Catra, it's *important*. She has to ask before she marks Adora, because then she'll smell like Catra and other hybrids will *know*. She doesn't want to put that on Adora without asking first.

The bathroom door clicks open not long after the shower shuts off, but Adora must see the small pile of clothes because Catra hears a small, thoughtful *"hmm"* and then the door clicks shut again.

Catra releases the breath she didn't realise she was holding. She'd put a change of clothes out for Adora because the blonde mentioned how she didn't have anything to change into and Catra said she'd figure something out. Catra also dreads to think about how her restraint would *crumble* if she saw Adora in nothing but a towel. That image nestles itself into Catra's head anyway, and she quickly flattens down the puffed up fur on her tail.

After an amount of time that was definitely *not long enough* for Catra to fully recover from her own thoughts, the bathroom door clicks open again, but this time the footsteps continue and get closer to where Catra is sitting, still fiddling with her tail.

'Hey...' comes Adora's small and shy sounding voice from behind her. Catra swallows, and turns to look at her guest.

Catra had assumed that she and Adora were around the same size, but she was *wrong.* Adora had been hiding *muscles* from her this entire time and the tightly gripping fabric of the tank top and sleep shorts left little to Catra's imagination. Which, when Catra thinks about it, does make sense. Adora plays a sport, after all. But that doesn't stop the way that Catra wants to trace the outlines of Adora's muscles with her teeth.

And– Catra needs a minute for her brain to restart after *that* thought.

'Catra? You alright?'

'Yes!' Catra bursts, she knows she's bright red but there's not really a lot she can do about it. All she can see is *arms* and *legs* and Adora standing in front of her just looking incredible and–

Catra never imagined she'd ever pine for someone standing right in front of her.

She may have realised that what she wants is a little more than marking and kneading, but it's definitely too soon for *that.*

'Are you sure?' Adora's frowning now, but Catra still thinks she looks cute.

'Yeah, I'm good. Just hungry. Food should be here soon.' With any luck, anyway. Catra ordered them pizza as soon as Adora got in the shower, after she got changed herself, but the waiting times are hit and miss depending on how busy the place is.

'Okay.' Adora sits next to Catra on the sofa. The TV isn't on, so they just kind of sit in silence for a moment. 'I was thinking,' Adora starts, her voice quiet, careful, 'in the shower. Is it okay if I just... you don't have to reply, but I want to talk. I want you to listen.'

Catra just nods, and when Adora smiles at her, she smiles back just as gently, reassuring.

Adora moves to sit back, bringing her knees up to her chest, wrapping her arms around them and hiding her face from view. Catra's heart clenches. She recognises that position, it's the one she defaults to as well whenever she needs a moment to process something without someone looking at her. No one's ever done it in front of her before, and now she knows why whenever she

does it whoever's with her feels the need to check in. It makes Adora look small, defenceless, like what she wants is the opposite of what she's doing. But Catra *knows*. Adora's thinking, and she just needs to hide her face for a bit while she does it.

When Adora finally speaks, her voice is so small that Catra wonders if Adora knows she can hear her. 'Who am I?'

'You're you,' is what Catra whispers back. It's true. She knows it, fundamentally. This must be what Adora's struggling with, her sense of self, stuck in some limbo where she has no idea how she fits into the world she lives in. Catra hopes this isn't related to the black eye.

Adora lifts her head just enough to meet Catra's careful gaze. Her eyes glistening with unshed tears. 'Am I sick?'

Catra's heart breaks at how small Adora sounds when she asks that question, it breaks for how Adora felt she needed to ask in the first place. 'No. No, of course you aren't.'

'I was punched,' is how Adora responds to that, ducking her head again like she's ashamed. 'I was punched because I wore the boy's kit, because I got a haircut. I was punched because I'm gay and dress like a boy and have short hair. I was punched because... because I don't know who I am.'

Catra can't help the way her fur bristles with anger at the thought of some homophobic *fuckface* punching Adora for dressing how she wants, for looking how she wants, for trying to feel some comfort in her own body.

'It's like– it all feels so sudden, you know?' Adora says, still talking into her knees. Catra kind of wishes that Adora would look at her. 'I know that it's not. I thought I knew who I was. That I was gay and that was it but it's not. Is there something wrong with me?'

Catra shakes her head. 'No. You're okay, Adora. You're perfect. Can you tell me how you feel? Maybe I can help.'

Adora lowers her legs, much to Catra's relief, and crosses her legs on the sofa while turning to face Catra. Catra mirrors her position so they're facing one another, and holds Adora's gaze.

Is this it? Will Adora trust her enough to let her in? To let Catra know of the storm that's relentlessly torturing her, taunting her?

Adora takes a deep breath, holding out her hands and smiling when Catra holds them. 'When I was in the locker room earlier,' she begins, brushing her thumbs against Catra's knuckles, 'the girl who punched me asked if I was trying to look like a boy on purpose. Which– all I could think was that, *no*, I wasn't. But I also knew I wasn't trying to look *girly* either. I guess I just... I don't know what I'm trying to do.'

'Adora,' Catra says, choosing her words very carefully, 'is it okay if I ask you something?' Adora nods, tightening her grip on Catra's hands. Catra squeezes back just as hard. 'Have you considered that, maybe, there's a third option to this?'

Adora just frowns, looking confused, and Catra swallows before speaking again, slowly, gently, 'I think, with what you're experiencing, what I've seen and what you've said—what you've told me—that you could be... non-binary?'

Catra immediately feels like she's overstepped. She gets this sudden wave of guilt washing over her like a tidal wave, like she's taken something away from Adora, ripped away Adora's ability to decide what she is for herself, but– but Adora's just staring at her. Adora's staring at Catra like she just told her some secret of the universe, like she's shared a wisdom from beyond the stars, some unfathomable thing that Adora never even thought of, never even considered. Catra watches as Adora's eyes widen, she watches the realisation set in, she watches as Adora *settles into herself.* Then Adora blinds her with a radiant smile, and starts *laughing.*

'Uh– Adora?' Catra asks, unable to hold back a dumbfounded smile. Adora just keeps laughing. She lets go of Catra's hands as she falls back onto the cushioned arm of the sofa, staring at the ceiling and just beaming from ear to ear.

'I'm neither,' Adora whispers, like it's a secret. 'I'm neither,' she says again, louder.

'So...' Catra ventures, 'are you okay?'

Adora sits up, beaming at Catra. If Catra didn't know any better, she'd think the look in Adora's eye was a few steps further along than pre-first date. 'I'm neither,' she says again.

'Alright, dummy, I get it,' and Catra can't help but match Adora's wide grin. 'Do you want me to use different pronouns for you? How does they/them feel? Or maybe she/they if you don't want to go all the way—'

'They/them sounds fantastic,' Adora rushes out, 'it sounds perfect. Yes, use those please.'

'Okay,' Catra whispers, her eyes shining with tears of happiness. Adora looks so happy, so free, like this huge weight has been lifted off their shoulders. 'Is this what's been bothering you?'

Adora just nods, 'I feel like such an idiot!' They laugh, loud and bright, and Catra basks in how genuine it is. 'I didn't even think. Thank you, Catra. Really. Thank you.'

'I was worried,' Catra says, gently taking Adora's hand again, 'that by pointing it out I'd be taking it away from you.'

Adora shakes their head, smiling, and squeezes Catra's hand between both of theirs. 'You didn't take anything away from me, Catra. You just said what I needed to hear, what I hadn't let myself consider. As soon as you said it, I *knew*. I knew that's what I am. *Who* I am. It just *clicked* and I *knew*.'

The pizza delivery person chose that moment to almost break down Catra's apartment's front door with the ferocity of the knocking, startling Catra enough to make the fur along her spine stand on end as she hissed toward the sound.

'I think you have to open the door, not hiss at it.'

Catra shoots Adora with an indignant glare, finding it hard to maintain under the warmth of Adora's smile. Adora had been really quiet on the walk to Catra's apartment (Catra could feel her hand tingling at the memory of holding Adora's hand for the entire way) and Catra was glad to see them finally opening up and being themself. But she couldn't exactly let a comment like that slide, could she? 'Alright then, smartass. You know what? No.'

'No?' Adora asked, sounding confused.

'Yeah, *no*. Just for that, *you* go open the door.'

'*Me?*' They asked, placing a hand against their chest as if Catra could be referring to someone else.

'Yes, you! What other blonde dumbasses do you see in my living room?'

'But I'm the guest?'

'Was that a question?'

Adora just rolled their eyes in such a way that Catra knew they weren't really annoyed with her. The bright smile was also a clue. When Adora was halfway to the door and another round of knocking threatened the hinges, Catra heard Adora yell, 'alright! I'm here, I'm here,' before opening the door.

Catra had just enough time with Adora being away from the sofa to remember that there was something she wanted to ask them. She tried, she really did, to not picture Adora's strong arms and legs, but that task became exceedingly difficult when Adora rounded the sofa again, holding the takeaway bag in both hands, biceps flexing. Catra's mouth watered, and her tongue darted out to wet her lips against her wishes; she knew her sudden hunger was *not* for the pizza, and she tried to quell it as much as possible.

After Adora sat back down, placing the bundle of food on the coffee table in front of them, they had a thoughtful expression on their face that intrigued Catra and commanded her full attention. Adora didn't need to know that Catra was thinking about them in a way that was too soon for their status of pre-first date. But in staring at Adora, Catra was struck again by the thought that Adora really was incredibly handsome, and those thoughts became a little harder to push down. Their hair had also mostly dried from the shower by now and looked like it was begging for Catra to run her hands through it. Or maybe that's just Catra projecting.

She decides to break Adora's trance, however, because as much as she enjoys eating left over cold pizza the day after ordering it, she likes to first have it while it's warm.

'Adora? You wanna choose a film?'

'Oh! Right. Yeah, okay,' Adora nods, officially trance-free, and leans forward to start taking their pizza boxes out of the bag. Catra grabs for the TV remote, turning it on and loading up Scorpia's Netflix that Catra has her own account on. Scorpia's renamed her profile to *"Wildcat"* again, because she's incorrigible.

When Adora and Catra wordlessly exchange remote for pizza box, Catra settling back into the sofa with pizza in hand and Adora leaning forward, subconsciously sticking her tongue out in concentration while she flicks through the endless lists of shows, Catra is struck by how domestic this feels. She wonders what it would be like if Adora lived with her, if this was how their evenings ended every day, just *being* with each other. Catra finds that she doesn't mind the thought.

She could get used to this.

***

Adora can't remember the exact moment Catra stretched out across the sofa, laying her head in their lap. They also can't remember when their hand started stroking through Catra's hair. But they're pretty certain that the purr Catra is making has been going on for a *while*.

Their pizza boxes are abandoned on the table. Neither of them finished, but Catra says she likes cold pizza, *any* pizza, even Adora's pineapple "monstrosity". The murder documentary that Adora chose to watch—yes they know it's not a film but Glimmer often watches them and maybe Adora pays attention too—is almost finished by now and Adora's fairly sure they know how it's going to end.

Because of this, their mind wanders back to what they were thinking about before Catra mentioned putting on something to watch.

They kind of hoped it wouldn't, but they're thinking about it now so *whoopie-doo*.

After the elation they felt at finally figuring out what's been bothering them about themself for so long, the realisation that they would have to *tell people* set in. Adora didn't get the opportunity to tell people for themself when they realised they were gay, so they don't think it's too far of a stretch to worry about it happening again.

They try to distract themself with the magicat that's laid on them, her cropped tank top exposing the stripes on her back that Adora's never seen before. They want to touch them. Well, they want to touch all of Catra's stripes, really, but now that they know that she has some on her back too...

It's an effective distraction.

That is, until—

'What's wrong?'

Adora had stopped stroking through Catra's hair, and now Catra's eyes were open and her purring had stopped. Adora mourns the peace they felt before their mind started worrying about things that don't matter enough to distract them from the most important task on the planet: making Catra purr. Adora knows that Catra likely won't let them get away with avoiding the subject, but they try anyway.

'Nothing, I was just, uh...' *looking at your back wanting to touch it?*

'You know that you can be honest with me, right? You can *always* be honest with me.'

'Well, I just,' Adora sighs, and gives in. They do trust Catra, more than they probably should after not knowing her for very long, but she's sweet and *hot* and Adora's got a crush on her that she knows about so... the lines are blurry. 'No.'

'No?'

'I think I'm okay, but I'm also... *not* okay.'

'Do you want to talk about it?' Adora appreciates that Catra's giving them a way out, but they also think that if they don't talk about it now, they never will, and they don't want to spiral while thinking about it obsessively for the next few days.

'I'm just worried. Maybe a little scared. Did I ever tell you that I was outed when I first realised I was gay? I never had a chance to come out as a lesbian at my own pace, it was taken from me. I guess I'm worried that will happen again.'

'Well, what's different about this time is that you didn't shout about it in a room full of drunk people. You can choose who you tell, and when.' Catra stills when she finishes talking, her ears perking up for Adora's reaction. Adora noticed the slip, and glances down at Catra quizzically.

'Drunk people... did Glimmer tell you about that?'

Catra's eyes go wide, she quickly turns her head to look up at Adora like a deer caught in headlights. 'Shit. I–'

'It's okay,' Adora reassures her quickly, 'I don't mind. I would've told you eventually.'

Adora feels a familiar calm wash over them. They voiced their worries and Catra helped so easily it's almost scary. It's scary how much Adora knows they like this girl, it feels like they're simultaneously moving too fast, and not fast enough. Adora knows that they want Catra to be their girlfriend. They know this. And even though they want nothing more than to ask, they also want to take Catra on a real date first. They decide, then and there, to stop fretting about it and just ask her roommates what she should do for the date.

They feel Catra's head bump into their hand, and they snap back from their thoughts to hear a thundering purr coming from the head in their lap. Adora realises their hand is gently stroking Catra's ear, but they don't stop. Catra isn't stopping them. They know how sensitive a magicat's ears are, how personal an area it is. If a magicat doesn't want someone to touch their ears, it won't remain a secret for long. Adora's read a few articles of people getting clawed up for doing it and then being imprisoned for assault.

Catra isn't stopping her. She's purring louder than Adora's ever heard her purr before. There's a blush dusting her cheeks, she's breathing heavily, and she keeps making the most adorable little sounds somewhere between a trill and a... and a moan.

*Oh.*

Adora stills their hand, briefly worried that Catra will chastise them for stopping, but she doesn't. Catra just gasps, like she's coming back to herself, and opens her eyes to look up at Adora and—

—and her pupils are so blown out Adora can barely see the colour for all the black.

'Adora...'

*Fuck.* Her voice sounds so needy that Adora almost dives down to kiss her there and then.

'Catra, I'm sorry, I—'

'Can I mark you?' Catra rushes the words out like they'll burn her if she says them.

Adora knows why. Of course they do. The same way they knew about the ears being an erogenous zone for magicats, but they zoned out and touched them anyway. Adora's been *reading*. Marking someone, for a magicat, is practically sacred. If Adora says yes, they'll *be* Catra's. They'll smell like Catra to every other hybrid who can pick up the scent. Adora's kind of stunned that, even though they're not even properly dating yet, Catra even *wants* to mark them.

It's not even a decision they have to think about.

'Yes.'

'You don't have to agree, obviously, I just–' Catra pauses, fixing Adora with a searching gaze, 'wait, *what?*'

'You can mark me,' Adora says, hoping Catra can hear the sincerity in their voice. 'In fact, I would– *I'm* asking you to.'

Catra, with pupils blown, ears stood to attention, and her tail weaving with interest behind her, readjusts herself so she's sat in Adora's lap, her legs either side of Adora's thighs, straddling them.

'Are you sure?'

Adora draws in a sharp breath when Catra's hands land on their shoulders. They can feel Catra's body heat, her warmth, and knows they've never wanted anything more.

They let their hands settle on the fur of Catra's thighs—because the cropped tank she changed into when Adora got in the shower wasn't enough, and Catra needed to also wear sleep shorts that were *far* shorter than the ones she gave Adora—and when Catra doesn't so much as flinch, Adora tilts her head to the side to give Catra as much access as she needs.

'I'm sure.'

Adora half expected Catra to dive in, what with the hungry look in her eye, but she doesn't. At first, she's slow, gentle, explorative, like she's getting used to the feeling of her cheek rubbing against Adora's neck, their jaw, their cheek. They feel Catra's claws extend, digging in a little at their shoulders, and they gasp. Their hands fly up to Catra's exposed waist, which only seems to make the magicat purr so hard Adora can *feel* it. Then Catra's kneading Adora's shoulders, marking up her neck and along her jaw, purring so *loud* Adora can't hear the documentary anymore and Adora can't help the pleased hum that escapes their mouth as they shut their eyes tight.

Adora's never felt this happy before. They kind of figured Catra would want to mark Adora as hers one day, *after* they'd started dating, but they never could have imagined that Catra would want to do it so *soon*. They can feel that feeling bubbling again,

the one they know is far more intense than simple attraction, and they don't fight it.

They don't fight it.

They *embrace* it.

When Catra finishes her marking, letting her head drop to nestle under Adora's chin, Adora begins to manoeuvre them so they're laying down instead. It's a little clumsy at first, but they adjust until they're comfortable and settled. Catra's legs are woven between Adora's, her arms folded between them, as she drifts off with Adora's arms around her, holding her close, keeping her safe.

Adora closes their eyes too. They don't mean to fall asleep—after all, there's still pizza to put away and the TV to turn off—but when all they can hear is the comforting rumble of Catra's purr, they find it's hard to stay awake.

Netflix must realise no one's paying attention to it eventually. It pauses, a question displaying on the screen for the rest of the night:

Are you still watching?

Chapter End Notes

Next time: Adora reintroduces themself to their friends.

Also, site note: I'm starting a new job soon! If you thought my updates were rare now, hoo boy do I have some news for you :D It'll be fine. I'll still be writing, I just won't have as much time to sit and ponder storylines all day ',:D

# Chapter 6

Chapter Summary

Adora returns to their flat while Catra freaks out at work.

Chapter Notes

Been a minute huh?

In case you didn't know, I am now with job, so writing time is less. I do also have a few more AUs in the pipeline so bare with me on those.

In other news, check out this amazing artwork for BMCC drawn by the wonderful EmileeDoodles as part of her 12 Catradora AUs art series!
You can find Emilee on Twitter and Instagram !




See the end of the chapter for more notes

By the time Adora gets back to the student flat they share with Glimmer and Bow, it's almost lunchtime. On a Thursday. Which means they've missed a lecture on Sport and Exercise Rehabilitation (which they'll have to catch up on, if it was recorded) and would normally be on their way to Catra's work to grab a coffee before heading home.

But this isn't one of Adora's regular Thursdays. For one, they forgot to tell Bow and Glimmer that they were staying over at Catra's; the whole evening kind of passed in a blur. So, as soon as they open the door, they're kind of expecting an onslaught of questions. That's okay though, they feel prepared for that.

Second, Adora actually woke up at Catra's place with Catra *gone* . After the initial worry of where she'd got to, Adora found a text on their phone, on top of a pile of other very worried sounding texts from the Best Friend Squad about where they were (that they still haven't replied to), that basically said she'd gone in to work because her shift started early. Catra had also locked her door, posting her key back through the door so Adora could lock the door when they left, and now Adora has Catra's apartment key and needs to drop it off to her at the cafe.

This was all without mentioning that Adora is also currently wearing some of Catra's baggiest, most comfortable clothes. Catra left them out in a small pile next to the sofa. Adora figures that's what they were for, anyway, to be worn. They kind of don't want to give them back. The racket bag is slung over their shoulder, and their tennis kit is in a plastic bag that she found in a pile of other plastic bags next to Catra's kitchen bin.

All Adora can think about is how Glimmer and Bow are about to watch them walk through their front door—wearing a black hoodie that says *"It ain't easy being purr-fect"* across the front with a little cartoon cat underneath, that definitely doesn't belong to them because otherwise Bow would have had something to do with it if it did—carrying their sweaty sports clothes from the day before in a plastic bag, all without telling them a thing.

It's practically a walk of shame, just without the sex.

Adora's face flushes bright red as their brain puts the word *sex* right next to *Catra* .

Which is exactly when Glimmer chooses to open the door.

Adora's blush promptly spreads down to their shoulders, not that Glimmer can see it, but they're still bright red, which Glimmer can definitely see. Adora's caught, and there's no way out of this now.

To their surprise, Glimmer just stands to one side, giving Adora space to walk past, which they do with a small, shy smile. Bow is in their living room sitting on one of the sofas, in front of which there's a– they've set up a chair from the dining room in the middle of the space, in front of the TV. Adora takes a deep breath before they step forward, putting their things down next to the chair and watching as Glimmer saunters back in and sits next to Bow.

'Hi, Adora,' she starts, and Adora winces at how much they can tell Glimmer is holding back right now, Bow's hand on her knee must be helping, 'please, take a seat.' Glimmer gestures to the chair, and Adora nods before sitting in it silently.

They were expecting an interrogation, but they weren't expecting *this* to be the method Glimmer would use. Adora feels very on the spot, but they know that's exactly the idea. This is how Angella and Micah told Bow and Adora to get information out of Glimmer whenever something weird happens around the flat, whenever anything goes missing, and whenever something new and sparkly appears without a word. Now Glimmer's finally able to use it on Adora, the only person out of the three who'd managed to evade it into second year.

Streak officially broken.

'Do you have anything you'd like to say in your defence?' Glimmer asks, as if she's a judge or a lawyer or something, because she's the picture of smugness right now and had no intention of letting Adora get away from this unscathed.

Adora just clears their throat; there's something they need to say before anything else.

It's time to re-introduce themself.

'Hi,' they say, smiling at their friends, 'I'm Adora. I'm– I'm a lesbian, I'm non-binary, and my pronouns are they/them. It's... uh– it's nice to meet you. *Again* .'

Bow and Glimmer are still for a moment, but nowhere near long enough for Adora's doubt to set in, and then all at once they have to hold each other down as they start bouncing in place on the sofa, unable to contain their excitement. Adora sucks in their lips, trying not to break out into a massive smile, and looks at the floor between them and their friends while they flounder on the sofa.

As soon as Bow manages to calm Glimmer down enough to stop her from *screaming* , he clears his throat, and speaks through a barely concealed grin, 'Hi, Adora. It's awesome to meet you again.' Glimmer looks like she's about to interrupt but Bow clamps a hand over her mouth, barely containing a laugh as Glimmer struggles to remove it. 'My name's Bow! I'm bisexual, trans, and my pronouns are he/him.'

Adora really struggles not to burst out laughing as they extend a hand for Bow to shake, which he does with the one that isn't occupied with silencing Glimmer. They shake once, firmly, and the sparkle in Bow's eye tells Adora that they never had anything to worry about.

Glimmer clears her throat next to Bow and Adora turns to face her next, giving Glimmer their full attention. 'Hi, Adora,' she starts, brushing her fringe out of her face, 'I'm Glimmer, also bisexual, and my pronouns are she/her.' Glimmer extends a hand, just as Bow did, and Adora takes it easily. Rather than shaking, Glimmer squeezes and pulls Adora forward and, trying not to laugh, rushes out, 'now tell us what the fuck we missed last night!'

'Glimmer!' Bow chastises his girlfriend through a wide smile, 'give them chance to explain! We *did* sort of put them on the spot.'

'I *know* Bow! But come on!' Glimmer whines, turning to face him on the sofa next to her. Adora just rolls their eyes, picking up their stuff from next to the chair. 'You've got to be dying to know what happened just as much as I am.'

'Okay. *Maybe* I am,' he holds up a finger just as Glimmer's about to burst again, *'buuut* we should still give Adora the space to tell the story in their own time. Right?'

Glimmer pouts dramatically at Bow, and Adora uses the distraction to carry the chair back over to the dining table. They sit in it, hiding their face behind their hands as they contemplate what to tell their friends.

A giddy kind of happiness courses through Adora every time their friends use the right pronouns for them, and they take a moment to just bask in how right it feels to be referred to in that way, as well as how accepting and awesome her friends are just in general. Maybe they'll grab them something from the coffee shop when they drop Catra's keys off to her after this.

The sound of two chairs being pulled away startle Adora enough for them to peek through their fingers. They watch as Bow and Glimmer take their usual seats, looking at them with patience. Well, *Bow's* looking at them with patience. Glimmer kind of looks like she's two seconds away from shrouding the room in darkness and pointing a lamp at Adora to demand the story out of them.

Adora closes their eyes, thinking back to the night before. It was just so... so *nice* to spend time with Catra like that; and Catra herself was amazing. Just, everything about her. Adora can't help but picture Catra again in her cropped tank and very short sleep shorts, making soft noises while Adora gently pets her ear...

They peek through their fingers again. Bow and Glimmer both have their phones out and are glancing between them, each other, and Adora.

Definitely not suspicious at all.

'Okay,' Adora starts, dropping their hands from their face and lightly tapping some random rhythm on the table, 'just to get this out the way... I'm definitely like, one-hundred-percent certain that I'm in love with Catra.'

Glimmer squeaks, slamming her phone down on the table while Bow gently places his face down, a wide, kind smile spreading over his face.

'I went home with her because I kind of just wanted to hang out with her and relax after I was, well...' Adora sighs, gesturing vaguely toward their face, 'I was punched before my game by the same person who outed me as a lesbian.' Bow's smile drops, and Glimmer's barely restrained patience gives way to boiling-over rage.

'It's okay!' Adora insists, waving their hands in front of them, 'my coach is handling it. Another girl, Starla, told Coach everything she's done and now I'm just waiting to hear what's happening.'

'I hope she gets fucking expelled!' Glimmer seethes under her breath. 'I swear if I ever find out her name...'

'Glimmer,' Bow says, levelling her with The Look, 'we talked about this. No more promising murder on people we don't know.'

Glimmer's eyes narrow, 'so it's fine on people we *do* know?'

'Within reason,' Bow grins back, and Adora marvels at the way he's able to diffuse his girlfriend by allowing her to imagine murdering people she *knows* as opposed to people she *doesn't* know.

After a prolonged moment of Bow and Glimmer just staring at each other, as they seem to do sometimes, Glimmer breaks from the trance and clears her throat to punctuate that the moment is over, levelling Adora with an apologetic expression. 'Sorry, Adora,' she winces, but Adora just shakes their head in understanding. They're in love, they're allowed moments to themselves. 'What happened after the game? We left when Catra said she was staying behind. I hope that was okay. We thought that you could use the time with her.'

Adora notes the meaningful way that Glimmer speaks, like there's some other, underlying reason for them to have left Catra there alone, but they shrug it off as the fond memories from the evening before flood through their mind again.

'After the game...' Adora starts, trying not to *swoon* , 'I met up with Catra and we... held hands... on the way to her apartment. Which was... y'know, *nice* . And I showered at her place because I stunk and— *wow* she has a lot of hair products—but after that I... I *talked* to her. About what's been bugging me recently. And... I'm sorry that I haven't really been open with you guys, *again* , but I just can't seem to hide anything from Catra. Being around her makes me want to just tell her everything and... she's so sweet and understanding and makes it so *easy* . I know you guys would be too but—'

'Adora,' Bow interrupts, his voice gentle and reassuring, 'we're not mad you haven't talked to us. We promise. We're just happy you have spoken to *somebody* . We're your friends, and we'll always support you, no matter what.'

' *Pluuuus* ,' Glimmer drawls, a smirk settling on her face, 'I kind of figured you'd open up to Catra. You being head over heels for her was *not* a secret. You're very much an all-or-nothing lesbian.'

'What's that supposed to mean?' Adora scoffs, sitting back in their chair and huffing at their friends. Distantly, Adora realises that's probably why they left Catra with them.

'It means,' Glimmer counters, leaning forward to chase after Adora, 'that you're either in love with them or want nothing to do with them. You were always chasing after that spark, you know? And now you've found it and,' she makes a clawing motion with her hands that Bow just nods along with, 'latched on.'

'I have not,' Adora tries to mimic Glimmer's motions with their hands, 'latched on.'

'You *have* , but that's not necessarily a bad thing,' Bow says, setting a hand on his girlfriend's shoulder to calm her down before she gets too into it. 'What did Catra say that helped? You don't have to tell us, remember. Only what you're comfortable with.'

Adora pauses at that, considering how to proceed. They want to tell their friends, they really do. Adora's kind of been buzzing about it ever since Catra's words just *clicked* . They decide to stop worrying, to just trust their friends with this part of themself, the same way they trusted Catra.

'Well, first of all she just listened. Like, *really* listened. It felt good to say it and be *heard* , y'know?' The bright smile that spreads over Bow's face reminds Adora that, *yeah* , he *does* know. They smile back, feeling warm and content with sharing the rest of what they've been worrying about. 'She listened to everything I said and then just said something like: "there's a third option". Which... I hadn't– it was always just *I'm a girl* , right? I should try to look like one. But at some point, I started to realise that I didn't want to wear only girl's clothes. I prefer shorts to skirts, suits to dresses. I *never* want to wear heels again. I don't really know how to explain it. Like, wearing the boy's tennis kit and getting my hair cut—those were impulse decisions—but I came out of them feeling *so much* and... So when Catra said I could be non-binary, it just summarised all of that. I'm *not* a girl. But I'm not trying to be a *boy* either.'

Adora had started to fiddle with their hands while they spoke, looking down at the table to make it easier to get the words out. But, when they look back up to meet their friends' wide smiles, they find themself unable to hold back a smile in return.

'So... yeah,' Adora continues, suddenly fighting down the urge to cry under the relentlessly supportive atmosphere that they suddenly feel engulf them, 'I figured that I owed you guys a re-introduction because I finally feel like *me* . I don't feel confused anymore. I know who I am, completely, and Catra helped me find that.'

Bow and Glimmer exchange a glance, nod, and slowly get up from the table, rounding it to surround Adora on either side with the very welcome, grounding squeeze of a Best Friend Squad group hug.

'Is it weird that she means so much to me so soon?' Adora whispers into the hug after a moment, holding their friends close and tight. Since mentioning Catra's name, Adora couldn't get the image of heterochromatic eyes, or the sound of her beautiful laugh, out of their head. They don't *want* it out of their head, but it's scary how much they feel. 'It's like– I'm thinking about her, all the time, and I've never felt this strongly towards someone before. Is it okay?'

'Of course it's okay, Adora,' Bow whispers back. They also hear a small hum of agreement from Glimmer. 'You've always been so full of love. You're always taking care of me and Glimmer, without even realising it, and now that you've found someone to *fall* in love with, it's not too far a leap to say that it might feel a bit overwhelming and intense.'

'You're literally the softest person we know, Adora,' Glimmer adds, and Adora chuckles at the sentiment, 'Catra doesn't know how lucky she is to be loved by someone like you.'

Adora *dissolves* .

Or, they feel like they do. They know that Glimmer and Bow are being supportive, and they're grateful, but they know they haven't done anything to deserve it; not *really* . The last time Adora tried to say as much, they were promptly shut down by their friend's kindness and reassuring words. But, as much as Adora wants to believe them, they *can't* , so they don't object to it, not out loud. They just smile through the few rogue tears that fall without their permission and hold on a little tighter, basking in the warmth of the moment for as long as they can.

Bow and Glimmer eventually pull away to sit in the chairs beside them, Adora takes the opportunity to quickly wipe those tears off their cheeks while their friends just offer them those soft smiles again. They don't deserve this kind of friendship, this level of support.

They don't deserve it, but they'll accept it. To push it away would be to lose it, and they *can't* lose it.

In an attempt to distract themself from any more of *those* thoughts, they look between their best friends in the whole world and ask, ‘so do you guys have any date ideas?’

They have to cover their ears when Glimmer shrieks.

***

Catra’s freaking the fuck out.

Just a *tiny* bit.

*Little bit.*

The customer she's serving doesn't know that though, even if they are eyeing her tail a bit more worried than one would normally. There's a chance it has to do with how much she definitely isn't freaking out at all right now. Which makes no sense, obviously, so instead of doing any *more* thinking about *nothing in particular*, Catra is just going to keep making this drink and ignore the way Lonnie is just barely dodging her tail as it betrays her. Again.

Frankly, Catra's mortified. She went way too far. She *marked* someone she hasn't even been speaking to for over a month. She keeps having to remind herself that the months she spent pining *don't count* as time getting to know Adora. They weren't speaking, she didn't even know Adora's name until a couple weeks ago. Not to mention that the whole of what happened last night was only the second time she's seen Adora outside of work, and even then being looked after while *ill-as-fuck* barely counts because she wasn't an especially gracious host—

Oh, fuck, now all Catra can think about is the way Adora's hand felt as they pet her ear. So gentle and soft, stroking from base to tip, tugging *just so* …

Catra has to bite her bottom lip to stop herself from making any strange noises in front of a customer and– oh fuck, now she can taste blood. A quick check with her hand confirms that, yes, she may have bitten her lip a *little* too hard.

*Fuck.*

'Um, Lonnie, can you take over? I have to, uh…' Catra gestures vaguely at her mouth when Lonnie glances up at her. The face Lonnie makes means she isn't impressed, obviously thinks it's a stunt to get out of working, and will be giving her shit for it later. However, because Lonnie is a fucking champ she doesn't complain, seamlessly taking over the drink Catra was making and apologising to the customer in that fake-ass voice that Catra knows Lonnie uses whenever her parents call to ask about her boyfriend. Because her boyfriend is actually *two* boyfriends. Who are also each other's boyfriend. Her parents don't know that yet though, and Catra can only imagine what her parents think Kyelio does for a living for him to get out so much and do so many vastly different things with his time. Almost like he's living a double life. Catra would be sus, that's all she's saying. She kind of wants to be there to film the reaction when Lonnie's parents do find out, but they don't really know each other outside of work so that feels like crossing a boundary. Whatever.

The first thing Catra does when she bursts through the staff room door is dab at her *wound* with some of their blue hand tissue. Not the most hygienic route, but she lacks the ability to give a shit. The blue hand tissue is "Only to be used for drying hands, thank you" as it says in a note taped to the dispenser, but Catra ignores it to grab some more, wet it under the tap, and then dab it on her lip and chin. She's seen humans cup water with their hands and splash it on their faces, and she's only a little bitter that the action, if she were to do it for herself, would leave her with a damp face for the rest of her shift. So she's dabbing at her face with damp tissue instead, as a compromise.

Which is when the last person she expected to knock (which in itself is weird because no one who works there knocks on the staff room door) does in fact knock, slowly opening the door to peer inside with wide eyes.

Blue irises lock with amber and cerulean, and Catra can't help but notice the scent seeping into the room. It's *her's* . Adora smells like her. Adora's *marked* as Catra's. They're also still wearing her clothes, which just amplifies the sensation tenfold.

It takes Catra's mind a second to catch up with her eyes, nose and ears, but when it does she—

‘Oh, shit, Adora!’

—forgets to say *hello* .

‘Hey, uh, is this not a good time?’ Adora’s eyes fill with worry as they take in the scene unfolding at the sink, a damp blue tissue dotted with red in Catra’s hand. ‘I can go…’

‘No!’ Catra panics, Adora leaving right now is the absolute last thing she wants. ‘I mean, yes! NO! I don’t– stay. Please. Stay.’

‘Okay…’ Adora steps tentatively into the room, the door closing on its own behind them with a quiet click. ‘Catra, what’s wrong? Are you okay? Is… I mean, are you…?’

‘What?’ She dabs at her lip with her finger again, even though she knows it didn’t even bleed that much and stopped a while ago. Cleaning up was just taking a minute, that’s all. She chucks the tissue into the bin and turns back to Adora, only to still be met with beautiful, worried, gorgeous eyes.

‘Well I’m just a little… confused? I guess? I thought you’d be happy to see me? I mean I saw you running back here but Scorpia said I should—’

‘Adora,’ Catra interrupts, because what are they even talking about? ‘Slow down. You’ve lost me. Start from the beginning.’

Adora swallows. Catra hears it, even from where she’s standing across the room. She’s really hoping Adora will come closer. As bad as Catra feels about last night, Adora being here has already filled her with some kind of giddy warmth that makes her want to just climb the blonde and be *held* . She wants Adora to pet her ears again.

No! No, she doesn’t. Adora didn’t even mean to do that last time, and then Catra just pressured Adora into letting her mark them in the heat of the moment and didn’t really give them a choice—

‘You ran,’ are the words Adora says, interrupting her spiralling inner thoughts. It still takes Catra a moment to process them because, *what?* ‘I got in and waved to you but you just ran as soon as I did and I wasn’t sure if you’d actually want to see me but Scorpia did see me and insisted that I come back here to find you and—’

‘Shut *up* , Adora,’ Catra sighs, a fond smile making its way onto her face. ‘I didn’t run from you, I just… cut my lip, that’s all. I came back here to clean it. I– I didn’t even realise you were here, but I’m happy you are.’

Adora’s eyes light up immediately, all the worry and concern previously clouding their face suddenly replaced with *hope* and… something else that Catra swears she’s seen in her own eyes when she stares at herself in the mirror, practising how to tell Adora she loves them. Not that she will. Yet. What?

‘Really?’ They ask, a small smile tugging at the corners of their mouth. Catra has to catch herself when she realises she’s staring at their lips.

‘Yes, really,’ Catra smiles back, marvelling at how handsome they are, even in Catra’s baggy sweats. ‘Adora, I’m so happy to see you, you don’t– you can’t– I am happy to see you.’

Adora pauses then, apparently taking in all of Catra. She feels very seen in a way she isn’t used to. Vaguely, she registers that her ears and tail are doing things that mean she *isn’t* totally okay, and Adora’s watching them closely. Their smile vanishes, their brow furrows, and Catra realises she’s been made. No hiding things from Adora, then. Not that she wanted to, but she was probably going to. It’s usually easier.

‘Then what’s happening?’ Adora asks, and Catra breaks a little under how well Adora can read her, over the concern and worry that has once again taken over their voice. ‘Is it something I did last night? If I went too far with– I didn’t mean to touch your ear like that, honestly I didn’t! And I’m sorry if I took it too far, I really didn’t mean to and I—’

‘It’s me!’ Catra bursts.

Adora blinks at Catra’s interruption. ‘What? What do you mean?’

She takes a deep breath, centering herself. Something Scorpia mentioned out of the blue recently as an exercise to calm herself down and collect her thoughts. It sort of works. ‘It’s me that went too far, Adora.’ Catra feels a squeeze on her leg as her tail winds around it, and she wraps herself in a hug as some kind of last defence against… she doesn’t really know against what, but it makes it feel better. She closes her eyes tight to make saying the next part easier. ‘I marked you. I– I’ve never done that with someone I…’ *love,* ‘…care about. I guess. So I just. I mean. We haven’t even been on a date yet and already I can’t control my inst… myself. Around you. I’m sorry.’

A pregnant silence falls over the staff room of Bright Moon Coffee Co., best coffee shop in Krytis, and Catra holds her breath.

Then she hears what she thinks is a sigh of relief from the other side of the room, and peaks through her closed eyes. Adora’s smiling, their eyes shining, hands flexing at their sides like they want to grab hold of something.

‘Did you forget?’ Adora asks, their soft tone of voice making Catra’s whole body relax. ‘What did I say to you before you marked me?’ They start walking forwards, toward Catra, and she drops her arms from around herself in, what she really hopes is, preparation for a hug.

‘You—’

‘What did I say?’ Adora interrupts, stopping just in front of Catra, close enough to barely whisper, ‘what were my exact words?’

Catra closes her eyes. It doesn’t take much for her to immerse herself in the moment she asked if she could mark Adora. The intimacy of marking, for a magicat, is profound. It’s almost sacred, and would probably be described as such if they were alive a thousand years ago. For now, in *this* time, it’s just *special* . It’s important. It’s so much more intimate than non-hybrids ever really seem to understand but here’s Adora, *understanding* .

The words Adora spoke come to her easily.

‘“I want you to”.’

Adora hums their agreement, finally stepping forward to wrap their arms around Catra. When Catra doesn’t protest, instead wrapping her own arms around Adora’s waist, Adora just tightens their hold for a moment, squeezing, and then gently kisses the top of Catra’s head, right between her ears.

Catra’s resulting purr banishes the silence in the room as she tries to hide her goofy smile in Adora’s neck.

‘That’s right,’ Adora whispers, and Catra melts into the sensation of being surrounded by Adora. She doesn’t even give a shit that she’s at work, not right now, even though any of her co-workers could walk in. Let them, Catra’s not letting go. ‘Catra, you… you know how you mentioned we haven’t been on a real date yet?’

‘What about it?’ She mumbles into Adora’s collarbone.

Adora squeezes her a little tighter before speaking again. ‘I’m free tonight, if you are. And only If you want to, obviously. Just the cinema, something simple, just so that we can, well… I want to spend more time with you. I really enjoyed last night, and I don’t have anything I have to do tomorrow so, I don’t know. We could maybe spend the day together again? If you wanted? Or, well, not the whole day cause you’re still at work and I’m still wearing your clothes… so… oh! Your keys!’

Adora doesn’t stop holding Catra, but shifts just enough to allow themself to reach into the pocket of their (Catra’s) sweatpants where Catra’s apartment key is. Then, instead of just handing it to Catra like a normal person, Adora slips the key into the back pocket of Catra’s black work jeans and *squeezes* her ass in the process.

Catra isn’t proud of the noise she makes.

‘ *Adora!* ’

‘Sorry!’ Adora giggles, squeezing Catra tighter when she tries to pull away. ‘Sorry, was that too much? I’m sorry, I just– I don’t know what came over me.’

Catra scoffs, her fight to leave Adora’s embrace forgotten. She could get used to being held like this. The thought of *getting used to this* makes her feel warm and fuzzy inside and she fights down a smile just enough to say, ‘I’m at work, dummy.’

Catra can feel Adora smile against the side of her head, their soft cheek providing a welcome weight and warmth that she leans into subconsciously.

‘So,’ Adora starts, and Catra can only imagine the shit-eating grin they’re wearing when they ask, ‘it’s okay when you’re not at work?’

‘You’re ridiculous.’

‘That’s not a *no* .’

‘Keep pushing your luck and it will be.’

Adora pulls back enough for Catra to see their face for the first time in a few minutes. They’re flushed, eyes sparkling, mouth stretched wide in a blinding smile and their hair…

‘Mmmm…’ Adora’s eyes fall closed and they duck their head when Catra’s fingers *somehow* find their way into their hair, carding through it and lightly scratching at their scalp. It feels so good, so soft, and Adora looks so amazing with their hair like this.

It takes a moment, but eventually Catra realises that she’s basically just holding Adora’s head right now. It would be so easy to just… to pull Adora closer, to lean in… their lips look so soft, and Catra wets her own lips while just imagining what it would be like to kiss them. She has to chew on her top lip a little to stop herself. No matter how much she wants to kiss them, she wants it to be special. Besides, she already knows that Adora wants to kiss her, she heard them say it themself, but that doesn’t mean she’s going to make their first kiss be in the staff room of her place of work just because she can.

For better or worse, Adora makes her feel valued, cared for, like no one else ever has before.

So Catra wants their first kiss to be special, not on a whim, or an impulse. She wants it to be the beginning of something amazing, the start line to the three-legged race their lives will become if they stay together. Gods… she actually *wants* this. She wants to be with Adora. For real. She feels so strongly for this lovable doofus already and they haven’t even been on a date yet. Deep down, she knows it’s dangerous to let herself get so attached, to latch on like this, but she doesn’t really care. Not when it feels this good to hold Adora, to be held by Adora, to *be* with Adora.

She wants this. More than anything.

‘So about that date…’ Adora chuckles, and Catra, mortified, realises that she didn’t actually give an answer because Adora squeezed her ass and distracted her like the thembo they are.

‘Oh! Right,’ Catra releases Adora’s face from her grip, settling her arms back around their waist and resting her ear against their chest, listening to their heart as it tries to beat out of their chest. Are they nervous of her reply? Is there any universe where she would actually say no to that question? If there is, it isn’t this one. ‘Yes. Okay, let’s do it. A date. With you. Tonight.’

‘Okay.’

And just because she has to make sure, Catra asks, ‘you really don’t mind?’

Adora just smiles into her hair, shaking their head gently. ‘About the marking?’ Catra hums an affirmative. ‘No, Cat, I really don’t.’

‘Okay.’

‘Honestly, Catra, you have blanket permission to mark me whenever you want. I’m not, you know, planning on seeing anyone else, so…’

Catra steps back at that, searching Adora’s face for any sign of mistruth or hesitancy, but all she finds is their sincere, sparkling blues staring back at her with such fondness that she almost trills under their gaze.

‘We haven't even been on one date yet and you already want to be exclusive?’ Catra asks, because *yeah* she wants that too but she’s still worried about them moving too fast and—

‘Yeah,’ Adora whispers, nodding and holding Catra’s eye contact. *Holy shit. This is real.* ‘I do… unless there’s someone else you’re—’

‘You’re a doof,’ Catra breathes, leaning up to rub her cheek against Adora’s jawline, purring when Adora angles their head to give her access. ‘Sweet, but a doof. No, Adora, there’s no one else. I want to see where this goes.’

‘Okay, alright, cool. And um, for the record I’ve, like, done research? So I know there’s certain things you can’t help, Cat, and I don’t mind. Marking, biting, kneading—whatever you need to do or can’t help—I just want you to know that I’m okay with it. I’m okay with all of you, alright?’

Catra almost fucking starts crying. She’s never felt so valued before, so seen, so understood. It’s a magical feeling, and she can’t quite believe it’s real. She tries anyway, and whispers into the crook of Adora's neck a small but heavy, ‘thank you.’

Adora just plants another kiss into her hair and this time Catra can’t stop herself from trilling from how good it makes her feel, her tail lashes as her emotions run wild and, as a treat, she just lets herself be enveloped by them.

‘Should I pick you up from here or your apartment?’ Adora asks, speaking into Catra’s hair and giggling when the feline’s ears twitch, thwacking them in the face.

‘From m’partment,’ Catra mumbles, sensing the beginning of the end of their conversation and leaning further into Adora in an attempt to prevent that as much as possible.

‘M’kay,’ Adora mumbles, squeezing Catra with a finality that only makes Catra want to hold on tighter.

‘Kay,’ Catra nods, relenting her iron, vice-like grip around Adora’s waist to allow them the ability to breathe properly once more.

‘I’ll see you later, then,’ Adora whispers, untangling themself from Catra and beaming down at her when their eyes meet. Gods, Catra is so, so *fucked* . How is she supposed to control herself around them? Maybe the night will end with them kissing. She wouldn’t mind that. Gods, she *really* wouldn’t mind that. She’s kind of hoping, but doesn’t want to heighten her expectations too much just in case they don’t.

She’s still hoping, though.

‘I’ll see you later, Adora.’

‘Bye, Catra.’ Adora steps backwards across the room as slowly as they possibly can, really dragging it out. Catra rolls her eyes fondly, still completely enamoured with the absolute dork she’s fallen in love with.

‘Bye, dummy.’

Catra spends the rest of her shift thinking about sparkling blues and a wide, happy smile. Lonnie even asks her if something’s wrong, something about “smiling like she’s plotting a murder”. Catra just scoffs and rolls her eyes, punching Lonnie on the shoulder when the teasing doesn’t let up.

Scorpia, however, just keeps glancing up at Catra now and then from where she’s wiping down tables, smiling in that way that tells Catra she knows exactly what she did, letting Adora through to the staff room, and she’s proud of it. Catra finds that she doesn’t mind. She can’t stop smiling either.

She’s just happy for a change. Truly, completely, *really* happy.

Chapter End Notes

please pay no attention to the chapter count. it's lying to you.

Thank you to Emilee, Liz, and Riley for beta-ing this chapter!

# Chapter 7

Chapter Summary

Adora thinks about what to wear on their date. Catra has a shower.

Chapter Notes

What better way to celebrate BMCC hitting 7k hits than with releasing the chapter I wrote immediately after the last one and have hoarded, all to myself, for just over a week.

Also worth noting, the tags have changed/been added to. Please read them. New Character Tags will be added as and when those characters appear, so keep an eye on that. There is now a rough plot for this fic which means the bubble of fluff you've all come to expect has an expiration date. I'm saying this as fair warning, but the fluff can only last so long. It's me, after all, what did you expect?

Hold that happy ending tag close to your heart. Squeeze it. Give it little kisses if you like. It'll all be okay.

I promise.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

‘Adora! Do you need any help?!’

‘No, Glimmer! I’m fine! You’ve helped plenty already!’

‘Are you sure?!’

‘Yes! Now stop shouting through my door, I need to think!’

Only after hearing Glimmer’s huff of frustration, followed by her stomping back through their flat to no doubt complain to Bow until he calms her down, does Adora open their eyes. They have a little over an hour until Catra said her shift finishes (Adora had to text after leaving BMCC to ask because they forgot to ask while they were there—a result of being too busy panicking about *almost kissing Catra* ) and they still have yet to pick out an outfit.

After initially getting home, reluctantly taking off Catra’s comfies and trying desperately to find something to wear, they realised that their clothes were all just kind of… *meh* . Over the years, after going on “girly” shopping trips with a number of groups, Glimmer included, Adora had amassed a collection of clothes that they didn’t really want anymore. Denim shorts that barely cover their ass, skirts that are way too short for the winds of post-winter months, skin-tight jeans that barely reach their ankles— tight and skimpy clothes that always seemed to hype up whoever they were shopping with at the time. Glimmer herself has an extensive collection of crop-tops, most she shares with Bow, and Adora has a good number now too after tagging along and being made to try things on. They don’t mind those though, really, they show off the muscle that appeared as a by-product of doing what they enjoy, and Glimmer has mentioned on many an occasion that if their abs work that well for *her* then they must be absolute *“lesbian-magnets”* .

Adora kind of wants to test that theory on someone in particular.

But the issue with the rest of their wardrobe did come up during a very efficiently ended argument during which Glimmer offered to pay for some new clothes for Adora, before sending them and Bow off with her debit card, locking the two of them out of the flat, and shouting from behind it: *"Time for some me-time!"*

Bow bet that they'd find the bath covered in glitter again when they came back. Adora didn't bet against him. He'd have won.

Adora was initially confused when Bow took them straight past the women's section of the clothing store, beelining towards the men's clothes. He didn't even glance at the women's clothes and, when Adora realised what was happening, they could barely hold down their excitement.

Wearing men's clothes always felt like it was something forbidden to them. Something they would always wonder about but never actually get to try. The tennis kit they started wearing was, for a while, the closest Adora thought they'd ever get to wearing men's clothes.

"So," Bow had asked, standing in the middle of the men's trousers section, "where do you want to start?"

Adora, grinning like an idiot, just speed-walked around the store, grabbing the baggiest clothes with the deepest pockets they could find. Cargo pants, straight-cut jeans, long sleeved plaid shirts, hoodies, shorts that go down to their *knees* that have *pockets on the sides* . Adora's never seen so many pockets before.

After they were done gathering their haul, trying some things on just to make sure they fit nicely (most of it did, Adora may have almost cried a few times looking at themself in the changing room mirror) Bow waved them away to wait by the entrance to the store while he went to the checkout to pay with Glimmer's card. Adora felt a little bad indulging in their friend's kindness like that, and the voice in the back of their mind that usually berates them for relying on people came back with a vengeance once they got home again.

So that's where they lay now, on the floor of their bedroom in their shared flat, staring up at the ceiling and trying not to think about how they don't deserve to be looked after like this. How they don't deserve these clothes because they didn't *earn* them, they didn't work for them.

But whenever they close their eyes, they hear their mother's voice reminding them of exactly how little they're worth.

*"You will earn your keep if you're to be a part of this family, Adora."*

*"You* deserve *nothing. You must* earn *the things you want in this world. Even friendships are just transactions of smiles and unfulfilled promises."*

*"Stupid girl! Do you listen to nothing I say? Do not expect anyone to go out of their way for you in this life. You have to be strong, to stand proud, and under no circumstances lower yourself to a position in which you are reliant on the whimsy of others! They will see you as weak! A burden! And will simply cast you aside when your usefulness is spent!"*

*“This party is for you to make* connections. *Find a boy with a strong future and make him fall for you, just like I showed you how. Do not let me down.”*

That last one stings the most. It was the most recent, after all, only about two years before they finally admitted to themselves that they’re a lesbian. The party was boring, full of boys and their rich parents, and Adora’s mother had been watching them like a hawk for the whole evening. Only after Adora started dancing with one of them (they can’t even remember his name) did their mother look satisfied. It wasn’t until they kissed him that she actually smiled.

Adora cried for hours in their room after that.

But they aren’t that girl anymore; too scared to stand up for herself, too scared to disobey, to act on what she wanted. They’re stronger now. *They* are. They don’t have to *earn* their friends, to act like someone they aren’t just to feel accepted. Glimmer and Bow have never asked anything of them, and yet they keep them around anyway. They have fun together, and Adora doesn’t feel like it’s a transaction.

Their mother was wrong. Lied about everything. They *know* this.

It’s just taking longer than they’d like to accept it.

They sigh, dragging their hands over their face. How long have they been just laying on the floor getting lost in their own thoughts? The answer: too long. They have a little under half an hour until Catra finishes her shift now, and are no closer to choosing an outfit. To be honest, they’re kind of hiding from it. All of the new clothes they picked are spread out on their bed, right where Glimmer arranged them while they were talking to Bow in the kitchen about the feeling of *belonging* with regards to wearing clothes labelled as the opposite to what you thought you were your whole life. From their current position on the floor, they can’t see the pile of men’s clothes on their bed where it waits for them to pick something.

When they first came into the room, they stripped down to their underwear—a sports bra and some boxers—then looked at the rest of the clothes on their bed and panicked, locking the bedroom door and hiding by practically planking on the floor.

It’s been less than 24 hours since the realisation that being non-binary *fit* . It fit with everything they’re feeling, solved the confusion, filled in so many gaps and yet… it’s *scary* , now that they’re faced with wearing different clothes. It feels much more real, very suddenly, and they’re not sure if they can do it. The idea of wearing any of their old clothes makes their gut twist uncomfortably, but thinking of wearing the new ones elicits feelings they really aren’t used to. They can’t decide if the feelings are good or bad, but they know they want this. They want to wear these clothes, look nice for Catra, and take Catra on a date.

Wait. *Catra.*

What would Catra like?

They sit up slowly, moving around to kneel in front of the bed and survey the clothes. Maybe if they could just decide what to wear based on what Catra might like, that would be easier? They want Catra to think they’re hot but they’re worried that Catra won’t like what they choose.

They stand, eyeing the drawer that Adora knows is filled to the brim with crop tops. They glance down at the plaid shirts, the jeans, and back to the crop top drawer.

*Fuck it.*

***

Catra practically runs home.

She knows this because she's sweating when she arrives back at her apartment, which she wouldn't normally be after walking at her usual leisurely pace, listening to whatever's on shuffle blaring through her earphones to drown out the cacophony of sounds that accompany the rush-hour frenzy. Taking the key out of her back pocket to open her front door briefly reminds her of where Adora squeezed her just a few hours before, and she flushes a deep scarlet at the memory. Honestly, if Adora pulls anything else like that tonight then Catra may not survive the evening.

She dumps her keys on the kitchen worktop along with her phone and then just sort of stands there like she's lost, and Catra realises she has no idea what to do.

A date. Adora's taking her on a date.

They said it would be something simple, like a movie, but it's still the first actual date Catra will have been on in… a while. She feels woefully out of practice, frozen in place while she desperately tries to work past the mental blank in her head.

Shower.

Clothes.

Then, wait.

Okay, when she narrows it down like that, it doesn't seem too bad. Adora will probably arrive within the next hour or so, unless they're already on their way, in which case Catra's screwed because her fur will never dry in time. Especially not her back, which she can never reach on her own. Usually she'd sit topless in her living room near the radiator and watch tv or something after using the hair dryer on the rest of herself, but she probably won't have time for that. Unless Adora would want to… No. That's stupid. Why would they?

Catra brushes her fingers back through her hair, grimacing when she's reminded of how sweaty she is, and just decides to shower now, drying be damned. If she were given more time, she could've prepared far in advance, but how could she say no to having a date with Adora sooner rather than later?

Her shower is fast, much quicker than it normally would be. Catra uses only the bare minimum of her usual arsenal of hair and fur products, and yet it still takes her almost half an hour, even while rushing. The door slams open once she finishes and she almost trips trying to get out. She's running out of time. She must be.

Catra fumbles, wrapping her towel around herself and just ignoring her hair for now, padding through to the kitchen where she'd left her phone to check it just in case—

**Adora (17:23)** On my way!

She checks the time: 17:39

Fuck!

Catra drops her phone back down onto the countertop, practically sprints back to her bedroom and hurriedly plugs in her hair dryer. She works on her hair first, drying it as much as she can before moving onto her legs and feet. Usually, she'd take much more care with this, but she's in a rush, dammit! She pulls on her stirrup socks and black ripped jeans as soon as her legs are dry enough, and then moves onto drying her face and hair again. Her heart is thundering in her chest, she can feel it, but at least she doesn't stink of coffee and sweat anymore.

*Fuck* , she hasn't been this excited for a date in, well, *ever* , probably. Not once has she rushed like this to be ready on time. She half-heartedly brushes her hair with one hand while hunting through her wardrobe with the other, grinning like an idiot when she manages to pull her leather jacket off its hangar without dislodging anything else, then makes an impulse decision in pulling out her favourite sleeveless maroon top to go underneath it. It's a solid outfit. One she's used before, and one of her favourites. It's *her* .

She chucks her hair brush onto the bed half-heartedly before reaching around to feel if her back is still damp. It is.

Which is when she hears the knock on her front door. She glances at herself in her wardrobe door's mirror, naked from the waist up, back wet as shit, and shrugs. If there was ever a way to test someone's character, this would be one of them. She grabs her towel again, folds it, and then wraps it around her boobs like some kind of improvised bra, and heads out towards the door.

Another knock.

Catra leans against her apartment door, trying to listen or smell for any hints as to who's on the other side. Obviously it has to be Adora, but she doesn't really want to open the door to anyone else when she's basically half-naked.

'Adora?' Catra asks for good measure, absentmindedly threading her tail through the hoop in the back of her jeans with one hand.

'Cat?' Is the response that comes back, definitely Adora's voice. Catra smiles, internally sighing in a mix of relief and fondness at the familiar sound. 'Is everything okay?'

She nods, even though Adora can't see her, and says, 'fine, just, not quite ready yet. If I let you in, don't freak out, okay?'

Adora starts to say, 'why would I freak out?' But stops halfway through when Catra suddenly opens the door.

Catra watches as Adora's eyes go wide, watches as their baby blues take her in—all of her—and feels a mix of emotions and feelings wash over her in their wake. She feels seen, vulnerable, yet almost *revered* . Adora's eyes are kind, soft, and the corner of Catra's mouth quirks up into a smirk when she recognises *want* briefly flash across their features. This all happens in about the span of a second, maybe two at a push, until Adora slaps their hand across their eyes while looking away, cheeks blazing.

' *Catra!* '

Their tone is accusatory, but not unappreciative. Catra lets out the breath she was holding and smiles, stepping back a little to give Adora room to enter her apartment.

But then she actually *looks* at Adora. Properly. Top to bottom. *Slowly.*

*Fucking hell.*

Abs.

Arms.

Gay. Catra is gay. Very. *Holy shit.*

Plaid shirt. Jeans. Rolled-up sleeves. Crop top. They've also *styled their hair.*

Catra's a goner. This is it. The last thing she ever sees and its her *hot as fuck* date.

Adora looks *comfortable* . The clothes fit well. Catra can see the bulge of their phone in their front pocket, almost halfway down their thigh; *deep pockets* . Everything except their trainers and crop top looks new, *smells* new, and Catra fights the urge to scent-mark all of it immediately. Is this where Adora went after they left the shop? To buy new clothes? Men's clothes?

Catra clears her throat in an attempt to chase away her fog of *gay thoughts* clouding her mind. It only sort of works.

'Are you coming in or waiting for someone else to walk past and see me?' She asks, knowing that her words will spur the blonde into functioning again.

As she expects, Adora quickly surges forwards across the threshold into her home, walking straight past without looking at her and beelining for the living room. Catra scoffs a little to herself at Adora's reluctance to even *peek* at her as they walk past, but she can't ignore the warmth that comes with feeling respected in this way. She isn't really sure what she was hoping for, taking Adora by surprise like this on a whim, but knowing that her date for the evening is a gentleman at heart isn't a bad thing to take away from it. Not bad at all.

She closes the front door, bolts it, then slowly stalks her way through her apartment to find Adora. The reality is, if they want to actually leave for the date *soon* then Catra will need help drying her back. Her fur is thicker along her spine, especially at the base of her tail, and it usually takes about an hour to fully dry if she just lounges around her apartment topless with the heating on as she normally does. Something tells her Adora might cease to function if she employs that method however so… she forms a plan. Of sorts. And just hopes that Adora isn't *too* gentlemanly to help her out.

Catra *really* wants to go on this date sometime *today* , after all.

'Hey… Adora…' Catra's nervous, she realises. Her voice is small and she can feel her heart trying to thump out of her chest. She swallows thickly, trying to think of words to say. How does she ask someone to help her dry her back because she's practically a fucking sponge? Which is when Catra realises… She's never asked this of anyone before. No one. Not a *godsdamn soul* . And now she's trying to ask Adora.

Why is that making her eyes well up? Making her throat feel tight? She closes her eyes, trying to stop herself from crying, and picks at her teeth with her claws just to give the hand not wrapped around her middle something to do. Surely she isn't this pathetic? Relying on someone, asking for help, shouldn't be this hard.

Should it?

'Hey, Cat, you okay?'

But then a warmth surrounds her, along with a familiar scent. It's Adora. Just Adora. They must have showered, because Catra can't smell any evidence of her marks anywhere on them, and her fur bristles as she fights down the urge to reapply them. Adora's arms are grounding, their pulse point a perfect hiding place, and the weight of when they rest their head on Catra's makes her feel safe, grounded, cared for.

Adora's hands stroke along her back, and Catra freezes. She can feel the way Adora's fingers are getting wet from where they're carding through damp, matted fur that would normally be light, soft and fuzzy. And then, as if it's the most obvious thing in the world, and not absolutely everything Catra needs to hear right now, Adora asks: 'Do you need help with drying your back?'

Catra sniffs, nods, and wraps her arms around Adora's waist, burying her face in their chest. 'Yes, please,' she whispers, as her tail wraps around one of Adora's forearms behind her.

Weaver instilled a lot of things in Catra as she grew up. One of them was to never let anyone see you vulnerable, because as soon as someone sees a crack, a weakness, they come for you and won't stop until you're beaten and *done* . Catra's lived by that, without meaning to, for *years* . Even after Weaver kicked her onto the streets for being a fucking *massive* disappointment, a waste of space, a misuse of all of Weaver's time, effort and money in raising her, Catra barely opened up to anyone. Scorpia

got the closest, but never *this* close. Never as close as Catra's letting Adora get, right now, in literally turning her back on them so they can help her dry it. *Vulnerability* , as Weaver would say, *is a weakness* . But Catra's *doing it* , opening up, letting Adora in, letting them see her with her guard down, letting herself be taken care of.

And Catra's never felt so fucking *strong* .

Catra leads Adora back to her bedroom where the hair dryer is still plugged in and just sits herself on the bed, facing the wall, silently telling herself on repeat that *this is fine* . Adora *offered* to do this for her, she didn't even have to ask. That, again, makes her insides do weird flappy, jumpy, rolly things that she isn't really used to. Her tail wraps itself around her waist as her ears droop and she holds her head in her hands in some kind of last attempt to hide. Adora's moving around behind her, probably fiddling with the hair dryer, but Catra can't bring herself to look. It's taking everything she has to just sit still.

There's a sudden, high pitched whirring like a tiny jet engine coming to life as Adora turns the hair dryer on. Catra immediately sits to attention, her ears alert and swivelling to try and give her clues as to what the blonde is doing. But then the sound dies along with the hair dryer and Adora chuckles to themself.

'Sorry,' they say, and they sound like they're smiling, 'just testing it. It's a little different from mine.'

'That's okay,' Catra mumbles, reaching up to her chest to undo the towel and swivel it round so it's no longer covering her back. She keeps holding it up though to cover herself, she isn't quite *that* comfortable yet.

Adora's breath catches in their throat, Catra hears it even from where they're standing across the room. She listens as Adora's steps get steadily closer, and straightens her back while keeping her head ducked to make Adora's job as easy as she can. She doesn't realise her tail is curling over her back until Adora's fingers brush against it, and she shudders at the touch because…

'Sorry! I know tails are sensitive, but it's in the way, Cat. You can wrap it around my arm, you know, if you want to…' Adora trails off toward the end, gently stroking closer toward the base of Catra's tail. She nods, allowing it to wrap itself around Adora's left forearm, and she feels the fur lining it stand on end when their hand gently holds onto it, too.

Then, after a moment, Adora says, 'I'm starting now, okay?'

Catra nods, and the hair dryer whirs back to life.

Firstly, it feels *amazing* . Catra relaxes immediately. Adora knows exactly what they're doing, moving it around so no one area gets too hot, keeping the heat spread evenly over her back. The pressure from the air feels fantastic and Catra sighs when it passes over the back of her neck. Her tail is occupied, her hands holding up the towel against her chest, her ears drooping from the warm comfort she's experiencing. She actually raises her head, eyes closed, and sighs more audibly than she means to, but Adora doesn't stop. They're really giving it their all, making sure Catra's back is dry all the way through.

No one has ever done anything like this for her before. She's never really let anyone close enough to try, this is true, but the fact that she's letting Adora in means *something* , right? Sure, people have cooked her meals, bought her presents, taken her places. She's been on plenty of *fine* dates with plenty of *fine* people. Slept with a good number of them. Not heard back from a few. Been broken up with by all those she herself didn't break up with. There's not a lot of self-worth under the definition of "Catra" in her own personal, theoretical dictionary, but Adora seems to see *something* in her. Maybe. Could it be that Adora

actually sees something of note, of worth, something of value in Catra? Something beyond some weird kink, some curiosity about hybrids, just some physical attraction?

Could that something be the same something that Catra feels whenever she looks at them? Whenever she's in the same room as them? Whenever they smile and it's all just for her?

Catra just wants to be taken care of by somebody who loves her for *her* .

So far, that's been too much to ask, but it feels like maybe it isn't with Adora.

Catra's tried drying her back herself. Of course she has. Who do you think she is? But she knows when she's beat. She almost burnt herself too many times trying to contort her body in the correct way to get a good angle for the hot air to dry her back and eventually just gave up, opting to lounge around her apartment topless for an hour or so instead. It was easier. Kind of freeing. Vaguely, Catra wonders if Adora would be okay with her lounging around topless even without a reason to. She really did quite enjoy it, actually.

Wait, why would it matter? It's not like Adora lives here.

Catra's mind starts doing calculations of dates, timing, rent, cupboard space, bathroom space, bed space, wardrobe space, fridge space… And she smiles, because, *yeah* , there would be plenty of room for someone to move in with her. Especially if they were in a relationship and they could share a bed. There isn't really room for another bed, and Catra doesn't necessarily want to sacrifice her queen for two singles to squeeze into the bedroom.

But that's just food for thought, Catra's getting *waaaaay* too ahead of herself again. It's just the heat on her back, making her mind sleepy and travelling to weird places it really shouldn't right now and… *Oh … That feels really nice.* Catra doesn't remember the hair dryer being able to work out knots in her shoulders but it's really… feels *real good* …

No, the hair dryer's *off* , Catra remembers hearing when the room was suddenly drowned in silence once again. She must have been too caught up in the warmth to realise. She feels safe, and Adora's… Adora's *hands* are so soft, methodical, gentle, yet firm. They really do know what they're doing with this, but Catra's too floaty to really say anything right now. She's just appreciating how good their hands feel on her body. Her shoulders, her back, her waist, her spine… Adora's hands seem to be everywhere, they're talking too, but Catra can't hear them. Her eyes are closed and she's so close to just falling asleep.

It's only when something brushes the side of her right boob that Catra realises she dropped the towel, her hands pooling in her lap as Adora worked their magic. Maybe it would be better if she laid down on her front. She turns to ask, but Adora's standing ramrod stiff, facing in the other direction. Are they speaking? Catra really should tune back into the real world and get down off of her cloud.

'—really didn't mean to and I understand if it was too far but you seemed to like it so I didn't really think and got carried away I'm so sorry I—'

Adora cuts off as soon as Catra plasters herself to their back, wrapping her arms around them and just *squeezing* . They breathe in deep, hold it for a moment, then let it out slowly. Their hands come up to rest on Catra's forearms as she nuzzles into their back, and Catra relishes the sound of their content sigh.

‘Thank you,’ Catra mumbles, kneading her claws a little into Adora’s exposed abs. *Gods* , their abs feel *good* under her hands. Adora just chuckles, stroking down Catra’s arms, their fingertips lingering over the outline of her stripes.

‘It was my pleasure, Cat. You looked like you enjoyed it. I hope the massage was okay, I think I’m realising you checked out at some point.’

‘Mmm,’ Catra hums, utterly content, ‘s’nice.’

Adora swallows, and whispers, ‘you’re so beautiful, Catra. So, *so* beautiful. I don’t mind doing this for you again, if you wanted me to. I *want* to be here for you. I *want* to. You’ve already done so much for me, I would love to be able to do this for you.’

*Love.*

Catra likes the sound of that.

***

It’s another few minutes until Adora manages to exit Catra’s bedroom without looking at her naked chest, and another few minutes after that when Catra manges to defog her mind enough to pull on her top and jacket and *confidently* saunter through to her bathroom to double check herself with some relative privacy because, *mainly* …

*What the fuck was that?!*

She almost fucking fell asleep half naked while Adora dried and then massaged her back like it was no big deal, and Catra was too out of it to even be able to fully appreciate the way their hands felt against her skin?! This is outrageous. It’s uncalled for. Obviously, they have to do it again. Just, y’know, so she can fully appreciate it. Not that she wants Adora’s nice, big, soft, firm, gentle, soothing—she’s getting off track—hands on her again. Not at all. Just for science, or something. Sure, that. Whatever.

When Catra finally looks at herself in her reflection above the sink and sees her cheeks blazing red, she just rolls her eyes. ‘Fucking simp,’ she mumbles, *to herself* , before almost splashing her face with water.

They still haven’t even been on a date yet, and Catra’s finding her ability to hold back from kissing Adora to really be getting far, far worse as time goes on. It won’t be long until she breaks, snaps, gives in; until she finally just caves and kisses them, *finally* tastes their lips, sees for herself if they truly are as soft as they look. Also, she wants to be held more, has she mentioned that? She had Adora’s hands on her but was too comfortable and sleepy to fully appreciate them at the time and so thinks a re-do is perfectly reasonable. Maybe she’ll bring it up during the next meeting.

What the fuck is she on about? What meeting?

Plus, Adora called her beautiful. *Twice* . What the fuck?!

Catra's certain she'll never love again. This is it. It's Adora or bust. She'll never accept anything less or anything more. Adora is who she wants to be with. She can't quite articulate why, *exactly* , but she knows it's true. No-one else will ever come close, *has* ever come close, and Catra finds that she really doesn't mind. Adora was worth the wait.

Taking a moment for one final check in the mirror, Catra runs her tongue over her teeth, her fangs, checks her claws, her ears, ruffles her hair. *Good* . She looks good.

She exits the bathroom slightly less flustered than she entered, but no less excited.

*Date time.*

Chapter End Notes

Next chapter is the date, I will make absolutely no promises for when that comes out. It could be a month. It could be longer. Who knows? Stick around though, I have *plans* for this story.

Thank you to Emilee, Riley and Liz for Beta reading!

# Chapter 8

Chapter Summary

Adora gets gayer for Catra by the second.

Catra steals a snuggy.

Chapter Notes

This chapter is soft as fuck.

You've been warned.

The rating has also gone up. It's maybe sort of in preparation for possible future shenanigans.

EDIT: I may have forgotten that Catra had in fact met Glimbow before, so if you read an earlier version of this chapter where it seemed like they hadn't met yet, no you didn't.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora’s gay.

A lesbian.

Attracted to girls.

But *holy shit* .

They aren’t exactly sure where all their confidence came from, back there in Catra’s bedroom. Sure, they were prepared to do something like that eventually—magicats have especially complicated grooming needs compared with, say, *humans* —but one thing Adora was *not* prepared for was the effect that seeing Catra’s (naked!) back for the first time would have on them. It took them a moment to gather themselves, to push down their desires, to help Catra in the way that she needed helping. Thinking about anything else in the moment was *wrong* , so Adora pushed through.

But then Catra started *purring* , and *sighing* , and dropped the towel from her chest.

It took everything Adora had to remain on task, to not get distracted, to be useful to Catra, to earn the title of being her girl–partner. Of being her *partner* .

But, as soon as they’d finished, Catra seemed to tense, her shoulders barely relaxed, and Adora’s education kicked in. They knew about tense muscles, where to press to release that tension, how to do it in a way that doesn’t hurt, so… That’s what they did. They helped more. The noises Catra made, ever-so-clear with the hair dryer turned off, combined with how *soft* her back

felt after being dried may have gotten to their head, though. Which was right around the time Adora felt a plump squish under one hand, heard a squeak of surprise from Catra, and promptly returned to reality.

That return to reality was punctuated by a loud shout in their mind of just the word *BOOB* and then *PANIC* in that order and looped until they were standing and facing away and apologising as much as they could as fast as possible so Catra would know they didn't mean to do that and then…

*Catra hugged them.*

Catra *thanked* them.

Catra said what they did for her was *nice* .

But she was also still half naked, and Adora's boob-siren didn't stop whirring until Catra was no longer pressed up against their back and Adora was safely hiding in her kitchen.

And now they're walking, hand-in-hand, through Krytis' shopping district toward the cinema, and Adora is desperately trying to focus on what Catra is talking about and not the fact that she's wearing a leather jacket and looks *hot as fuck* in it. She's wearing it like it was made specifically for her, which is the only explanation, really. The whole history of Etheria, the evolution of man, hybrids, the invention of the wheel— *everything* —happened just so that Catra could be united with that jacket and turn Adora into a puddle of gay.

Even just holding hands with Catra is distracting. Her hands are soft, warm, small, and fit into Adora's like they were made for exactly that purpose. However, Adora can also feel Catra's claws lightly digging into the back of their hand every time Catra squeezes it, and it's hard not to picture that pressure, those pin-pricks of deadly sharpness… elsewhere.

Walking down that street, holding hands with a beautiful woman, listening to the gravely timbre of her voice as she talks about her co-worker's boyfriend drama, makes Adora's heart feel full, and they almost audibly gasp as they realise the extent of their feelings for Catra all over again.

Adora's falling, faster and harder than they ever have before. It's scary, but this, *Catra* , whatever's happening between them… it feels so *right* .

'Is this the place?'

It takes Adora a moment to realise that they've stopped, that Catra asked a question, and is looking between them and the Moonlight Theatre.

'Oh!' Adora exclaims, 'Yeah! This is the place. Is there anything you want to watch?'

Catra laughs. She sounds so free, so relaxed. Adora squeezes her hand and smiles wistfully at the girl they're falling in love with.

'Let's just go inside first, Dork. They have a list of showings, right?'

'Yeah, should do.'

'Let's do it.'

Adora's feeling a little floaty, if they're honest, as they let Catra lead them by the hand through the doors and into the foyer of the cinema. They've never felt like this on a first date before. It's exciting, scary, and wonderful all at once.

Catra shoos them off to "grab a fuck-ton of snacks" while she wanders over to check out the film selection displayed on the screens above the checkout. Adora will not, in fact, grab a "fuck-ton" of snacks, but they will grab *a few* . They cringe at the thought of what Coach would put them through if they accidentally got addicted to sugary snacks *again* . Worry of what Catra's eating on a daily basis quickly flashes through Adora's mind but they stamp it out before it roots too deep. That's none of their business. Catra can eat what she wants. It's not Adora's place to project their dietary quarrels onto her.

As luck would have it, there are a few healthy options dotted around in the wall of Pick & Mix sweet dispensers that Adora finds themself standing in front of. There are three different sizes of bag to choose from, too. What size would Catra want? Maybe they could get a bigger bag for Catra and a smaller bag for themself. But then Catra would say that's unfair, right? Tell them to go back and make it even. But Adora doesn't really want that much, when Catra specifically requested a fuck-ton. Plus, all the healthy options kind of look like they haven't been changed in a while, their dispensers almost completely full, whereas the rest of the sugary sweets are clearly well-loved and restocked often. Would it really be so bad if Adora indulged a little? Just once wouldn't hurt, right? But they don't feel like they've *earned* it, not really. Their tennis game has been lacking a little since they became distracted by blue-green eyes, fuzzy ears, and a fluffy tail. What if Coach realises? Will they be taken off the team? Forced to back out from any tournament they may qualify for? Plus, what if they get Catra the wrong kind of sweets? Adora doesn't know if Catra has any allergies or if any of these candies do in fact contain allergens. They should have asked. They should be better than this. They're failing already and Catra's going to—

'Hey.'

Adora *inhales* for the first time in what feels like an hour as their body flinches in response to Catra's soft whisper. They shut their eyes tight, dig their nails into their palms, and try to calm their body down. It's been a while since they got this in their head about something, and now Catra's going to know how weak they can be. Maybe… Maybe this was a mistake.

But then Adora feels a soft, warm hand cupping their jaw, a thumb stroking over their cheek, and they relax, leaning into it just as Catra whispers again. 'Hey, come back to me.'

Adora blinks open their eyes to see Catra looking up at them with worry clouding her features. Catra smiles as their eyes meet, and Adora watches as her pupils dilate a little, just a fraction, just enough.

'Welcome back. I missed you.'

‘I’m sorry, I don’t—’

‘Nuh-uh,’ Catra interrupts, ‘None of that. Let’s just do the film, you can make it up to me with a nice meal somewhere afterwards.’

Catra seems nervous, like she’s worried she’s gone too far. Adora watches as she works her bottom lip between her teeth, a fang digging in a little more than the rest. Her ears look like they’re trying to decide whether to be up and alert, or cower back in fear of Adora’s response.

Adora sighs, rolling their eyes as fondly as they can, before bringing their hands up to scratch behind both of Catra’s ears, being extra careful not to accidentally touch her ears directly. The effect is instantaneous: Catra relaxes, her eyes fall closed as any hint of worry vanishes from her face. Her purr thunders into life from nowhere, her ears droop lazily, and Adora feels the faintest brush of a tail against their thigh.

‘That sounds perfect,’ Adora says, and they mean it.

***

Catra’s head is still a little foggy when Adora stops scratching behind her ears, but she doesn’t care. She just lets them lead her to the counter to buy their tickets from the scrawny-looking guy behind it. Adora asks which movie she chose, and she answers. She thinks. Some sci-fi space thing that they got literally all of the magicat actors available to take part in. Catra had read about it… *somewhere* . Something about how casting magicats as magicats instead of using CGI to make humans look like magicats is this huge ground-breaking thing. Catra just thinks it’s pretty cool, if she’s honest. There aren’t *many* magicats around so a film with five of them as the main cast *is* something that would catch Catra’s attention. Adora seems happy with her choice anyway, so Catra just goes back to pressing herself as close to the blonde as she physically can, wrapping herself around Adora’s arm.

They end up not buying any snacks. Adora promised to take Catra somewhere nice after the movie, even if Catra intends to drag them along to the nearest fast food place she can find. Eating fancy is nice and all, but sometimes starting simple is fine too. She fully intends on stealing some of Adora’s food, no matter what they order. That’s part of the fun of it, part of the experience of fast food: being less reserved, enjoying yourself, and almost entirely forgetting your table manners.

She kind of resents table manners at this point, if she’s honest. Weaver was always uppity about them, so after Catra was thrown onto the street she found that following them to a “T” made her physically uncomfortable. She’d start to shake if she thought about it too hard, it would become difficult to breathe for fear of doing something wrong, and her spine always stood to attention despite her not wanting it to lest she be found slouching.

Catra tries not to think about it these days. Doing what she wants works just fine. There are no expectations in a fast food joint beyond what’s considered common decency to your fellow patrons, but in a fancy restaurant… Catra doesn’t think she’d be able to sit still.

That’s a conversation for future Catra and Adora, though. For now, Catra just clings on to Adora a little tighter as she pushes any thought of Ms.Weaver’s screeching voice from her mind, instead focusing on how the lights dim as they enter Screen 5.

It’s not very full. The film’s been out a while, after all, so most people interested in it have seen it already and those that are here now are just the stragglers wondering what all the hype was about. For Catra, she just didn’t have a reason to go before now and was only really mildly interested anyway.

Adora follows the numbers on their tickets, leading them to their seats. It’s sort of toward the back, a little to the right of the screen. Catra doesn’t care. As soon as they sit down she lifts the armrest between them, shuffles closer, and practically drapes herself over Adora.

Catra smiles to herself when she feels her date’s heartbeat pick up, keeps her purr to just a low rumble when Adora’s arm reaches around her to hold her closer, and manages to keep her gaze fixed forwards despite Adora’s eyes burning into the side of her face.

Adora’s warm. That feeling of safety is washing over her again. That feeling of being cared for like never before. It’s intoxicating. Catra wants to hold onto it as tight as she can because, if she were to let it go now, she doesn’t think she could ever find it again.

The film finally starting doesn’t really register for Catra until she feels Adora’s head turning, the blonde’s eyes no longer studying her for whatever reason. Catra sits up a little higher too, still pressed against Adora but in a better position to actually watch the screen.

*Is this okay?* Catra thinks, suddenly worried that she’s taking up too much of Adora’s personal space. She glances between them, then up at Adora’s face. They’re just watching the film. They don’t look worried or uncomfortable, and that settles the churning in Catra’s stomach back down to a low simmer.

She’s nervous, she realises.

After work she’d been so excited, running all the way home to get ready, heart trying to beat itself out of her chest. But now? Now her stomach is home to a kaleidoscope of butterflies that don’t know how to land. All she wants to do is look at Adora, talk to them, get to know them more. But the main activity of the cinema portion of the date is *not* looking at each other. Who’s idea was this!?

Oh, yeah. Adora’s. Adora asked Catra on a date. They’re on a date right now. Just the two of them, together, bodies pressed as close as they’ll go on the seats. It’s not about looking at each other, is it? It’s about occupying the same space for a while, just existing together, experiencing a story unfold before their eyes that they can talk about for hours afterwards.

Catra relaxes.

This isn’t bad, actually.

The film is good too, it’s nice to see more of her kind on the screen for a change. She watches as they struggle through space, fighting to keep each other alive. There isn’t really a villain to the story, just circumstance and coincidence that push them into perilous situations against their will as they try to meet up with more of their people.

Catra's momentarily embarrassed when an obvious jumpscare works on her, but she finds that she doesn't mind when Adora just chuckles, kisses her ear, and whispers, *'It got me too.'*

Her tail, at some point, must have made its way into Adora's lap, because they're playing with it absentmindedly. Catra doesn't think they're fully aware of what they're doing as they thread it between their fingers and allow it to weave around their wrist, but she doesn't mind. As long as they aren't pulling on it.

Adora's warm. Catra's relaxed. Her defences are down and, as the film settles into a particularly slow part, she feels her eyelids drooping.

She's safe. Tired. Happy.

Catra decides to just rest her eyes for a moment. She can still *hear* the film, after all. Just five minutes…

***

Adora slumps down onto the sofa of their shared student flat, smiling to themself despite the looks Bow and Glimmer are giving them.

'Is she dead?'

The date was amazing. The whole experience of picking Catra up from her apartment, taking her to the cinema, watching *most* of the film with her… It doesn't really compare to any other date Adora's ever had.

Even if Catra did fall asleep three quarters of the way into the film, and refused to be woken despite Adora trying their damndest once it had finished.

'It's too late to hide a body, Adora, I've already taken my face off.'

'Well, where else was I supposed to take her, Glim? Our place was closer.'

So now Adora has a Catra in their bedroom. On their bed. Asleep. They're trying not to think too hard about what will happen when she wakes up.

'Well *I* think, under the circumstances, you did the best thing. *What,* Glimmer? We live right around the corner and Catra lives across town.'

‘Thank you, Bow,’ Adora says, grateful for the support. They take a deep breath in, then exhale all the air from their body and become one with the sofa for a moment, before finally breathing in again and reinflating. It’s nice to take a deep breath every so often. Adora finds it calms them, relaxes them, centres them for just a second so they can be more present in the moment.

Glimmer rolls her eyes, but Adora catches the little fond smile tugging at the corner of her mouth. ‘I just think a heads-up would have been nice.’

‘I kind of had my hands full, Glim,’ Adora replies, leaning back on the sofa with their hands behind their head. If they catch Glimmer’s gaze flicking between their abs and their forearms, they don’t mention it.

‘Well,’ Glimmer gulps, ‘I guess, it’s, I mean… I can’t believe you *carried her* here from the cinema.’

‘Can’t you?’ Adora asks, because they’re a shit, blatantly flexing now.

Bow, once again, levels Glimmer with The Look. Glimmer tries to match him with a glare of her own, but she concedes, flopping back onto her bean bag while Bow remains upright on his, victorious. They both know full-well that Adora easily could carry either of them. A particularly imaginative game of truth or dare put that to rest months ago.

‘So, how was it?’ Bow asks over the sound of his girlfriend groaning into her hands.

‘It was nice,’ Adora replies, nodding, thinking back over the events of the evening thus far. But Bow’s quirking his eyebrow at them and smirking a little, and Adora realises they misunderstood the question. ‘You weren’t talking about the date, were you?’

Bow shakes his head. ‘No, Adora. The date clearly went great and we’ll be sure to grill Catra on it when she wakes up, but you’re right that that’s not what I was asking about. It wasn’t too tight, was it?’

Adora sits up, takes a deep breath, closes their eyes, and runs a hand over their chest. It feels nice. Flatter. It *looked* nice in the mirror before they left. A last minute change of heart to wear the binder that they almost didn’t buy on their shopping trip with Bow. They don’t think Catra noticed it under their crop top, it does kind of just look like a sports bra, but the point is their chest was flat. Flatter. Somehow the word “Flatter” is morphing into “Better”, but that’s a little scary to admit out loud right now.

‘No, Bow, it’s fine I prom—‘ Adora sucks in a breath through gritted teeth as their fingers brush the band of elastic around the bottom of the binder. They’re suddenly aware of an *ache* all around their middle that they’re certain wasn’t there a moment beforehand.

Adora didn’t realise they’d closed their eyes, but when they open them again they see Bow moving closer, a concerned frown replacing the soft expression he had been wearing. They don’t have a chance to feel guilty about souring the mood before Bow gently helps them to their feet and leads them to the bathroom. He then slides the plaid shirt off their arms, helps them take off their crop top, and with a nod from Adora they both work together to pull the binder up and over their head.

Adora *breathes* .

Maybe their deep breath earlier had a reason, after all.

‘I don’t think it was too tight,’ Bow says, quieter than normal in their echoey bathroom. Adora can feel his fingers gently carefully brushing the ridges in their skin left behind by the binder’s compression. They trust Bow with this, maybe more than anyone. He’s been through it before, after all. ‘But I think maybe carrying Catra all that way was a little much for your first time wearing it. It’s dug in, any longer and it might have bruised. You’re going to be sore for a few days. *Don’t* wear it again until you’re ready, okay?’

Adora nods, trying not to let the word *failure* ring too loud in their head. ‘Okay.’

‘Did you tell Catra you were binding?’

‘No, I– uhm. I got distracted.’

‘That’s okay. You just might have to tell her before she hugs you or anything.’

‘I will. Thanks, Bow.’

A quiet knock on the door to the bathroom captures their attention.

‘I’m coming in, you better be decent,’ Glimmer sing-songs before stepping inside, eyes widening when she sees that Adora is *not* decent. She bites her lip. ‘Yep, still got it.’

Adora laughs. ‘Got what, boobs?’

‘ *Boobs,* ’ Glimmer scoffs, ‘Adora, *honey* , those… Are badonkers.’

‘Ba- *what* ?’ Adora blanks.

‘Badoobers?’ Bow supplies with a teasing tone, like he’s suggesting the answer to a quiz.

Glimmer throws the bundle of fabric in her hands at Adora, who manages to catch it just as she says, ‘Jinglies?’

‘By the stars…’ Adora sighs, unfolding the fabric to reveal a *huge* and very soft t-shirt. ‘Glimmer, what’s this—’

‘It’s to hide your mommy milkers!’ Glimmer squeaks, barely able to say the words before cackling and leaving the room lest she fall over from laughing too hard.

Adora shakes their head, ‘Bow—’

‘It’s my old dysphoria top,’ he says, his voice low and soft, no longer laced with the teasing lilt it had been a moment before. ‘I used to wear it when I couldn’t stand the way I looked in my reflection, but I’d already worn my binder too long. Glimmer bought it for me, it’s super oversized on me and we’re basically the same size these days, so… You can have it if you want, I don’t need it anymore.’

Adora glances down at Bow’s flat chest, then looks up at themself in the mirror. The ring around their middle looks a little red now, and their breasts are… *There* . They don’t really feel like they want them gone, *per se* , like Bow did with his, but it *could* be nice to wear the binder sometimes and, just for a moment, pretend they aren’t there.

But they don’t *deserve* this, do they? Not really. They only had the non-binary revelation last night, only came out to their friends this morning so it’s— It’s all too soon, right? There’s no way that Adora has earnt the right to any of this yet.

‘No it’s—’ Adora struggles to find the words, how to tell Bow what they’re thinking, even though they know it’s *stupid* to think this way. ‘It’s okay, Bow. I… I shouldn’t have worn it, I don’t– It’s too soon! I mean, I only came out to you this morning so I haven’t– I can’t—’

Bow holds up a hand, stopping Adora’s spiralling words from betraying what they really want. He steps forwards slowly, takes the top from Adora’s hands, and holds it up bottom first. Adora scoffs, but Bow just quirks an eyebrow, and they relent by lifting their arms and allowing him to put the top on them.

They look back at themself in the mirror. The top is *big* , baggy, and they can’t quite make out their breasts unless they stretch the top down or puff out their chest.

Something rises in the back of their throat, however, that wants to protest, to argue, to *insist* that they don’t deserve this; haven’t earned it yet—

Bow speaks before they get that chance.

'You may have only come out to us this morning, but that doesn't mean you wanting to try binding or new pronouns or anything like that is somehow invalid. Gender is malleable like that. Exploring it is scary, but it can also be exciting to try those things you might have thought "weren't for you", but were what you needed all along.'

Adora has to close their eyes to stop tears from just streaming down their face of their own volition. They don’t *want* to cry, but it’s all *so much* and feels *so good* and they aren’t used to feeling this good about themself. They haven’t been *allowed* to. It feels like they’re breaking some rule that simply states: Adora shall never know how to be happy.

‘But how do you know I need them?’ Adora asks, whispers, into what they imagine to be some inky, black void. Talking into a void feels easier than opening their eyes, after all. ‘I didn’t even know I need– *wanted* anything to change. I’m just– I’m afraid that I’m taking up too much space; space that other people might need. What if all of this is just wrong, a blip, something that I’ve made up and just isn’t *true* —’

They had more words lined up, but a loud sob breaks through their cascading feelings and cuts them off before they can hold it in, hide it, contain it. Adora nearly cries for real when Bow’s arms gently wrap around them from behind, being extra careful of their sore middle, and they can’t help but melt into his arms a little.

Bow gives the best hugs. It’s just a fact.

‘Adora…’ Bow whispers, ‘You just said, yourself, that you need them. You do so much for Glimmer and me, for Catra, for everyone else too. You’re allowed to have this. You’re *allowed* .’

‘Okay,’ they say, even if they know it will take some time to accept.

‘Thank you,’ they say, because they didn’t realise how much they needed to hear it.

‘We should probably head back out,’ they say, because they’ve been in the bathroom a while and their stomach just rumbled.

‘We were going to order pizza if that works for you?’ Bow suggests from behind them, smiling against their shoulder. ‘You can tell us all about your hot date, too.’

‘Yeah,’ Adora nods, smiles, and opens their eyes. ‘Okay, let’s do it.’

***

Catra’s been awake for somewhere between five and ten minutes, but she can’t move. *Won’t* move, is actually more accurate. It took her a second, upon waking, to deduce where she must be, and once she made her peace with that she decided that there’s nowhere else she *wants* to be.

*Adora.*

Everything smells like them. It’s overwhelming in the best way, a way that Catra hasn’t really been able to experience before, even when pressed right up against them. She’s already marked their pillows, the bedding, as well as a couple of clothes strewn haphazardly at the foot of the bed, probably from when they got ready for their date earlier in the day.

Catra just purrs to herself, surrounded by Adora’s scent, being unable to care at all that if any other hybrid were to walk into this room it would scream, “Adora’s mine, back the fuck off!” but as like, a scent instead of words. Maybe she could add the words too, if she’s there, just to push the message home.

But through her purring and gentle rusting of Adora's bedsheets Catra hears from outside the room; a knock, the sound of a door opening and closing, followed by the smell of pizza steadily permeating the entire apartment. The smell of food makes her stomach rumble louder than her purr, and Catra remembers that she hasn't eaten since lunch, and has no idea for how long she'd been passed out.

She groans, dragging herself off the bed. The room is dark, but she can see just fine, even if everything looks a little greyscale in the gloom.

The only light in the room comes from the steady glow of the city peeking around the curtains. Driven by a sudden curiosity, Catra peaks her head through them, but isn't prepared for the sudden, unexpected vertigo of realising she's a lot higher up off of the ground than she thought.

Judging from the view from the window, Catra's found herself on one of the upper floors of the Go-Lem Spires student dorm, which is about ten minute's walk from the Moonlight Theatre and even closer to Krytis U itself. She always thought the dorm had a stupid name, but since she was kicked out of college she never thought she'd ever see the inside of one of its rooms.

Weird, how things work out.

At the sound of a muffled laugh, the *tudummmmm* of Netflix being loaded, and the sound of drinks being poured, Catra steps back from the window and begins to carefully traverse Adora's room. It's a mess of clothing. No doubt it started out all neat and tidy, but it looks like Adora went through at least two or three outfit changes before they settled on what they were wearing when Catra answered the door to them in nothing but ripped jeans and a towel-bra. There's a laptop on the desk, plugged in and charging. Their tennis racket is propped up against the wall, beside the door, safe in its carry-bag. A plushie occupies the desk chair, some white bird-horse thing with rainbow wings and a spike sticking out of its face. Horrifying.

Catra doesn't see her comfies anywhere. She knows that if she was in possession of some of Adora's clothes, she would either be wearing them or they would be nearby. Her curiosity makes her linger, glancing around until she spots *it,* hanging on the back of Adora's bedroom door. It's not *her* oversized hoodie, no, it's way too big for that. Too *long* . But it has a hood, and is definitely soft. Catra can't help but purr a little as she steps closer, running her fingertips over the material. It looks like a hoodie, but also a blanket? She's never seen anything like it but— she *must* steal it.

Wearing something like that while wearing ripped jeans and a leather jacket would be incredibly uncomfortable, however, so Catra strips out of them until she's standing in Adora's room in nothing but her underwear and a sleeveless top, and grabs the pile of soft off the door hook.

*This will be fine,* Catra thinks as she hoists the bundle over her head, *I lent them some of my clothes, so it's only fair.*

'Glimmer!'

Adora's voice shouts from elsewhere in the flat, more clear now that Catra's standing right behind the door.

'You can't watch Friends again! You've already binged it seven times!'

‘In open defiance of your defiance I’m putting on The One with the Holiday Armadillo!’ Glimmer’s voice replies, cackling as the show starts in the background.

A groan from Adora, ‘No! Not the Holiday Armadillo!’

And another low, kind voice, chuckling at their antics.

Catra hesitates with her hand on the door handle as she remembers how she got here in the first place.

She ruined her date with Adora.

Who does she think she is, falling asleep like that and then just stealing Adora’s clothes as if she’s allowed to? No doubt Adora brought her back here so that her friends can help them let her down lightly, to tell her that it was fun, but it’s not going to work.

Her toes curl into the carpet, the claws digging in through the fibres until they touch the hard floor beneath.

Whatever. Either she’ll go out there, and Adora will dump her which, honestly, might be their best bet. *Or,* by some cosmic fluke, Adora and their friends will actually want her around.

Catra takes a deep breath, and opens the door.

***

At first, when Glimmer hears a door opening elsewhere in the apartment, she feels a wave of panic wash over her, thinking that someone had got in to burgle them. But then, she remembered. They have a guest.

Adora’s up immediately, rounding the sofa they were solely occupying to meet Catra at the threshold to the living area.

Bow tightens his arms around her, as if to stop her from also jumping up to interrogate the new arrival who, for a while, she knew nothing about. Then, only from a distance, the line between customer and barista seperating them at Bright Moon Coffee Co., Catra’s place of work. And sure, they saw Catra at Adora's Tennis match, but that wasn't enough to get to know the magicat, and it was barely a proper meeting. Glimmer's excited to get to know Catra more, but she holds herself back from jumping into interrogation mode. She ignores the fact that it's actually Bow who's—*literally*—holding her back.

But that doesn’t mean she can’t listen.

Glimmer *accidentally* overhears what they whisper to one another, steadfastly staring ahead as Ross makes his Armadillo entrance.

It's Adora who speaks first.

'Hey, you're wearing my snuggy.'

'Is that okay?'

'Yeah, of course. I got you some pizza. Well, *us.* It's a half meat-feast half pineapple. I wasn't going to subject you to eating pineapple *with me* because of—'

'Adora,' Catra interrupts, 'I'm *so sorry* .'

'Wh– what for?'

'For fucking… *falling asleep* on you. I feel terrible and I know we wanted to go eat somewhere…'

'It's okay, Catra. Really. Plus, isn't you falling asleep on me supposed to be a good thing?'

Catra snorts, and her voice is a little more muffled when she says: 'That's actual cats, dummy. Are you sure you researched magicats or did you get confused?'

Glimmer's nosey nature betrays her then, and she looks over to see Catra *buried* in a snuggy, pressed up against Adora with her arms wrapped around them. Adora's holding her too. *Enveloping,* would be more accurate. Their arms are wrapped around Catra's smaller frame, their head resting on hers. It's only then that Glimmer realises Adora is looking at her. Their eyes meet, and Glimmer feels a surge of… pride? Because Adora looks *so happy* , so very *in love* , and Glimmer is so, so happy for them. Proud. She and Bow have put up with Adora pining over the "cute magicat" for way too long, so seeing it work out like this?

It feels fucking fantastic, and Glimmer's just so happy for her friend.

Bow kisses the top of her head, and Glimmer gets the message. She turns back to face the TV, giving Adora and Catra another moment of privacy.

Adora whispers something then, something that Glimmer doesn't catch, but Catra replies by removing her arms from around them and whisper-shouting: 'You fucking dumbass! You should have told me!'

'I know! I just– It's all so new and I–'

‘It’s okay, Adora. I just wish you’d said something. Should we… sit down? I promise I’ll be careful with you.’

‘You don’t have to–’

‘By the stars, Adora,’ Catra chuckles, walking around the sofa and taking a good long sniff of the pizza.

Adora joins her after a moment, and they sit down on the other sofa together, Catra pressed as close as she can be while also being careful of Adora’s middle. They join Bow and Glimmer in shovelling pizza into their faces, and comment over each other at the antics happening on the screen. Glimmer can’t help but roll her eyes at the display, unable to think anything other than that they’re made for each other.

Once the episode is over, the pizza mostly eaten, and after Adora finally allows Catra to escape from their cuddle position, Catra clears her throat to get Bow and Glimmer’s attention.

Glimmer nudges Bow, prompting him to release his hold on her, and they scooch round to face the occupants of the other sofa. Catra looks nervous, her ears low and her tail weaving behind her. Adora places a soothing hand on her back, and Catra visibly relaxes.

‘Hi guys, it’s good to see you again and it's… *nice* to finally meet you properly. I didn't introduce myself before. I’m Catra, and I guess I’m Adora’s…’

They share a glance. Adora nods, beaming. Catra blushes.

‘I’m Adora’s girlfriend.’

Chapter End Notes

im really enjoying writing this. i think it shows. thank you to BabelFish, Emilee, and Liz for beta reading and screaming at me about this fic.

# Chapter 9

Chapter Summary

Catra gets added to a group chat.

Glimmer says too much.

Adora hides.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

**Best Friend Squad!!**

*<BossBitch added Catra to the chat>*

>Catra: oh what the fuck

>Catra: is it too late to un-know u people

>elBow: afraid so!

>BossBitch: Stuck with us now!! Perks of being Adora's GF

>Catra: istg

>BossBitch: do we get free coffee now ???

>Catra: u think bright moon is a charity, glitterbomb?

>BossBitch: no but i think i deserve free coffee

>Catra: what gives u that idea

>BossBitch: im just so likeable

>Catra: ur something alright

>BossBitch: yeah

>BossBitch: hot af

>elBow: ^^^ !!!

>Catra: hmmm

>Catra: debatable

>BossBitch: adora thinks so

>Catra: sure they do

>BossBitch: mhm they told me

>BossBitch: also ive seen their tits

>BossBitch: they dont show their tits to just anyone, uknow

>elBow: Glim, we've both seen them

>BossBitch: hush bow

>BossBitch: bet catra hasnt seen their tits yet

>elBow: They've only been officially together for just over a week

>BossBitch: and????? I saw adora's honkers 5 seconds after meeting them!!

>elBow: You walked in on them changing in the bathroom.

>elBow: They showed me to ask about a suspicious mole.

>elBow: We are not the same.

>BossBitch: lmao everyone in this chat has seen adora's boobs except catra

>Whorsegirlsummer: listen

>Whorsegirlsummer: WAIT CATRAS HERE?!?!?

>Whorsegirlsummer: YOU ADDED HER AND SHE DIDNT LEAVE?!?!

*<Catra left the chat>*

>Whorsegirlsummer: FUCK

>BossBitch: AHAHAHAA

*<Whorsegirlsummer added Catra to the chat>*

*<Catra left the chat>*

*<BossBitch added Catra to the chat>*

*<Catra left the chat>*

*<Whorsegirlsummer added Catra to the chat>*

*<Catra left the chat>*

*<elBow added Catra to the chat>*

*<Catra left the chat>*

*<Whorsegirlsummer added Catra to the chat>*

‘You guys are the worst!’ Catra growls, but it’s hard to hear the exclamation as anything remotely close to menacing through all the purring. When Adora’s friends just laugh in response, she turns over to bury her face in her partner’s stomach. It gurgles. Understandable. Food’s on the way, after all.

They’re laid down on the sofa together, Adora on their back and Catra on top of them, between their legs. They didn’t start like that, of course, but Catra just sort of kept leaning on Adora until they finally got the message and laid down so Catra could cuddle them.

She feels her phone buzz in her hand and checks it lazily.

**Adora ❤️**

Catra's heart skips a beat when she sees that little emoji next to Adora's name. It had taken a lot of willpower to add that there after being forced to download this messaging app and then add the three people who pressured her into it. Part of her wants to change it though, maybe to something a little more personalised. But, for now, she likes just seeing Adora's name. She's their girlfriend, and she wants to do it right.

> you okay?

She glances up at Adora, but they're facing the TV where *Friends* is still playing. She's pretty sure Glitter isn't even watching it in order or, if she is, she restarted it at some point since Catra was last in their dorm and no one protested. Cowards. Both of the Sparkle Twins are back to staring at it, now that they've stopped laughing and Catra's no longer engaging in their stupid group chat. Which she still has a lot of feelings about being added to. Annoyingly. She's working through them.

Catra takes a breath, wraps her tail around *one* of Adora's legs—she's not sure which—and types her reply.

why wouldn't i be? <

> you kept leaving

it wasn't serious <

i was just messing with your friends <

> so

> you're not annoyed that you haven't

seen my boobs yet?

Catra's tail tightens around Adora's leg at the mental picture that infiltrates her mind at reading those words.

no <

> you sure?

yeah <

> you promise?

i do <

Adora pauses typing for a moment. It's easy for Catra to tell, since she's laying on them and all. She then feels them take a deep breath, type something quickly, before hesitating and finally pressing send.

> would you want to?

Catra stares at the message for a long moment. She can hear Adora's heart, beating so fast it sounds like it could burst from their chest at any moment. The instinctual response is, of course, *yes,* but it doesn't *feel* right.

not like this <

A quick glance up at Adora's face reveals them looking down at Catra with a confused tilt to their eyebrows. It's cute. Catra realises she'll have to explain. She'll have to get used to this, after all, because she's definitely falling in love with (in the most affectionate way possible) an idiot.

if i do, i want it to feel right in the moment <

not like, pre-arranged or something <

This time when Catra looks up, Adora's staring at their phone, face completely red. Catra feels her face burn too as she realises the implications behind her words. That at some point, they would be in a situation where Adora's tits end up revealed to her and it wouldn't be forced or arranged or done to add another tally to the number of people to see Adora's breasts.

That it would be part of a moment.

That it would be *theirs.*

Catra has to bite her lip to stop her mind from getting *too* imaginative.

> okay

She smiles at the reply, her chest blooming with warmth and her nerves calmed at Adora's response. As fun as it sounds for her to just let Adora drag her off to their room for them to flash her their tits, that's not how she wants to handle this. *This* meaning *them.* Their relationship. Sure, it's only been about a week since she fell asleep on Adora in a cinema. And sure, they've barely seen each other since then because of Catra cramming extra shifts so she could pay her rent on time, and because of Adora playing tennis over the weekend to practise for their upcoming official matches *on top of* the mountain of studying they need to do for their degree. But Catra's messed up too many good things, scared away too many partners, and has been alone for too long to take this lightly. Maybe she's too attached, too stupidly in love already, but she's afraid.

Catra's afraid of stepping out of line, of losing Adora. She hates that she feels this way, but it's true. Weaver never let her get close to anybody when she was younger, so when she started feeling attraction toward people growing up, she never really knew how to handle it *or* herself.

And now here she is, falling faster than she ever has before.

It's scary, but she can't lose it.

Catra sits up when Adora taps her on the shoulder, whispering *'Bathroom'* as they heave themself up from the position they've been in for over an hour, stretching as they go. Catra watches them for a moment, before sitting against the back of the sofa and bringing her knees up to her chest. She wraps her arms and tail around them, just taking a moment to breathe and get the negative thoughts out of her head. She's happy. She is. So why does she feel so fucking awful all the time?

'You okay?' Comes a small, weary voice from across the room. Catra's ear flicks at the sound, and she looks up to see Bow and Glimmer looking at her like she's some kind of kicked puppy. 'They missed you, you know,' Bow adds, and Glimmer nods beside him.

'They've suggested going to get coffee for us like, everyday since you fell asleep on them,' Glimmer adds, her voice teasing, not mean-spirited. 'They've just been…'

'Busy,' Catra sighs. 'Yeah, I know. Same. I… I missed them too.'

Bow and Glimmer share a look, one that no doubt carries a whole conversation with it. Catra prepares herself for a questioning. To her surprise, it's Bow who speaks first.

'Adora said you've been at work the whole time. Is that true?'

Catra nods. 'Yeah.'

'Why?' Glimmer asks, and Catra can't help but bristle a little at the reasoning she's about to give.

'I need the money,' she says, because it's true. Plus, she doesn't really want to lie to Adora's friends. 'Scorpia lets me do more hours because I won't let her help me pay for things.'

'Scorpia?' Bow says, glancing to Glimmer as a hint of recognition passes between them. He looks back at Catra with a sparkle behind his eye. 'You don't happen to know Perfuma, do you?'

Catra sits up a little straighter, her ears standing to attention at the mention of Scorpia's *still* secret girlfriend. 'You *do* ?'

Bow chuckles whilst Glimmer grumbles something under her breath, crossing her arms over her chest and turning back to the TV.

‘Yeah,’ he says, ‘She’s actually a friend from school. We grew up together. She likes to joke that we swapped genders since we kind of figured it out together? We were also each other’s prom date in school and dated for a little while after but it… didn’t work out. And then I met Glimmer in college and now here we are, in university living together!’ He wraps an arm around Glimmer’s shoulder and squeezes. Catra doesn’t miss her fond eye roll and small smile peeking out behind her forced frown.

‘And I still haven’t met her yet,’ Catra muses, wondering how she’s let Scorpia get away with this for so long. She’s slacking, clearly, and needs to assess this Perfuma for herself as soon as possible.

‘If it helps, Perfuma talks very highly of Scorpia, but we still haven’t met her yet. Maybe we could all hang out and get to know each other?’ Bow’s positivity, infuriatingly, is seeping into Catra’s bones.

Which is probably why she says: ‘Sure, why not?’

But then Glimmer ruins it. ‘Bow, do you think I could ask mom about Catra’s branch?’

Catra immediately looks to her, confused, and her concern only grows when Bow’s eyes go wide like he wasn’t expecting Glimmer to say what she just said.

‘Glimmer…’ He starts, his tone weary, but she continues anyway.

‘Maybe they could get a pay increase? They *are* in the middle of the city.’

‘Glimmer wait, Catra doesn’t—’

‘I’m sure she wouldn’t mind? Bow? Why are you looking at me like that?’

Bow cringes, looking between Catra and Glimmer slowly. ‘Catra doesn’t know.’

‘Know what?’ Catra asks, slowly, her brow furrowing with Bow’s suspicious mood shift.

‘Oh!’ Glimmer squeaks, and turns to face Catra with a blinding grin. Bow hides behind his hands. ‘My mom is Angella Moon. The Mayor of Krytis. She owns the Bright Moon Group who own Bright Moon Coffee Co.! It was my dad’s idea really, he comes up with all the flavours and stuff, but he couldn’t run a business to save his life so my mom had to—’

Catra stands up, cutting Glimmer off from her rambling about she’s probably rich as fuck and could afford Catra’s rent fifty times over with what she has in her purse alone, and moves to walk out of the room. Adora’s been gone a while anyway. Yeah,

that's it, she's just going to find Adora. Maybe ask a quick *"Why the fuck didn't you tell me your friend was the Mayor's daughter who also owns the company I work for?!"*

Maybe.

***

'Wait…' Glimmer whispers, turning to Bow who's still hiding behind his hands. 'Did Adora not tell Catra about us? Have they even told Catra who *they* are?'

'You know they don't like to talk about it,' he replies, his words muffled through his fingers.

'Just because they don't use their bank account, which is *way* bigger than mine, for the record, doesn't mean they shouldn't tell their girlfriend about it!' Glimmer's bordering on her whispers becoming shouts by the time she finishes, but it just doesn't add up to her. She's worried for her friend. Not sharing details about your life is fine if you're like, from a regular family. But there's nothing regular about the Grayskull Corporation. They could buy out the Bright Moon Group at the drop of a hat. That kind of feels like something they should tell their girlfriend.

'Maybe they just get caught up in the anonymity of it all?' Bow says, finally lowering his hands. 'They said that they have nothing to do with the company itself, and never appear in the news. It's always just Randor and Adam. It was nice of them to let Adora do what they wanted instead of being tied to the family business.'

'Well, we're the same. Mom wants me to follow in her footsteps, and your dads want you to live and breathe The Library too. But they let you come do your engineering stuff and your archery and my parents let me come to learn about politics.'

Bow just gives her the Look again.

'Yes, Bow, I *know* I'm doing exactly what my mom wants me to do, but she still let me come to *this* university to do it! Plus, I actually *do* want to follow in her footsteps!'

Bow just rolls his eyes, looking down the corridor Catra left down a couple of minutes ago. He wonders where she got to, if she's found Adora, and if they're both okay.

Adora *has* been gone for a while, after all.

***

As Catra goes on the hunt for her partner, she tries (and fails) to not think about how her perception of reality seems to be shifting around her. Everything was fine, and then suddenly this bright, glittery girl Catra met like a week ago is the daughter of the woman who effectively runs the city and owns the company she works for.

That's a lot to process.

'Adora…?' Catra ventures, poking her head into the bathroom. It's dark inside, but she can see perfectly well that Adora isn't in there.

She growls under her breath, before closing her eyes so she can focus on her other senses. Magicats are, as they say, "blessed" with enhanced senses. Catra just thinks it's more of a curse than anything else, always overstimulating her at the worst of times. Except for times like this, when her partner apparently decides to go and hide from her. She tunes out the sound of the TV, the mumbling, hushed voices of Glimmer and Bow, cars blaring their horns outside, footsteps from the floor above, a saxophone being played elsewhere in the building. She tunes all of it out and focuses on the sound of irregular breathing, rustling, and the almost silent creaking of a wooden bed frame as someone sits down and makes themself comfortable.

Adora has a metal bed, for starters, so that means they aren't in *their* room.

Catra moves now, silently stalking down the hallway, past the bathroom, past Adora's room, following her ears and nose, her stride getting more confident as she picks up Adora's scent. She doesn't know who owns the room she stops outside of, a number "3" attached to it is the only differentiating feature.

But Adora's in there, so she knocks.

'Adora?'

Catra hears a sharp intake of breath from within the room, followed by a sniff and more fumbling around and creaking as the bed shifts underneath them. Catra feels a lump form in the back of her throat, and an uncomfortable weight settles into her stomach as she gently pushes down on the door handle before nudging it open as slowly as she can.

The room is dark, the curtains drawn. There's *stuff* around like books and shit, but Catra doesn't blink twice at any of the clutter. All she can focus on is the hunched over form of Adora on the bed, trying to make themself as small as possible. As slowly as she can, Catra steps into the room, closing the door behind her softer than she's ever closed a door before. Catra has to push the desk chair under the desk to clear her route to the bed. But now that she's standing closer she can more easily see the person she loves.

Adora's sitting against the headboard of the bed, knees pulled up as far as they'll go, their face buried in that hideous plushy (that Catra now knows has a name: Swift Wind). Catra chews her lip for a second, working out the best course of action here. She can feel her claws digging into her palms, her heart beating out of her chest, the fur along her spine standing on end. She's nervous. Afraid. Worried. There's so much she's feeling in this moment that it's almost overwhelming, but right now she has to be here for Adora the same way she wants them to be there for her. So, Catra picks up one of the pillows from the bed, gently moves Adora forward so they aren't leaning back against the hardwood of the headboard, and slips the pillow behind them.

*There* . At least they're comfortable now.

'Can I sit?' Catra asks ever-so-quietly, her tail weaving around her legs in anticipation of the reply.

Adora just nods.

Catra sits.

She looks down at the floor. It's the same carpet as in Adora's room. Or, the same pattern, anyway. She can't really make out colour all that well in the dark, even if she can see moderately well. Leagues above what Adora can make out in the dark, for sure.

Catra feels her eyes sting as her mind works to find its own solution to the way Adora's acting, and she has to fight her voice cracking as she asks: 'Is it me?'

Catra feels Adora move next to her, but she doesn't turn to look.

'Did I do something wrong?' She whispers.

Adora makes a strangled sound, like they're trying to come up with the words to say.

'I'm really sorry I haven't seen you since our date,' Catra says, gritting her teeth against the tears that are fighting to fall. 'I've just been so busy, and I need the money. I wanted to see you, *so bad* , I did. I'm here now. Please talk to me.'

Adora takes a deep breath, and when they release it, it's shaky and unsteady.

'It's not you, Cat,' Adora says, their voice soft yet heavy with… *something* . 'This is just… How I am. Sometimes I have to just crawl under a desk for a minute. Clear my head. It helps. I think. And back there I was just feeling so many things and I needed to get away. It's stupid that a conversation about *boobs* made me need to run but… I don't know. Sometimes I worry that we're going too fast, but other times I wonder if we aren't going fast enough. Finding the right middle-ground stresses me out because I *want this* so bad and I care about you *so much* and it's… It's…'

'Scary?' Catra asks, finally turning to look Adora in the eye.

Adora meets her gaze, their eyes melting a little once they can see her more clearly, and nods. No doubt the slight glow from her eyes is shining like a beacon in the low-light of the room, lit only by the warm light reaching around the curtains from the street lights outside. Adora themself *is* that glow for Catra. Their eyes may not actually shine, like hers, but whenever Catra looks at them it's like everything gets brighter. They're like her own personal star, shining brightly in a sky devoid of all else, and she loves them more than she's ever loved another person.

'Yeah, it is scary,' Catra whispers, the full weight of her feelings for this person washing over her yet again.

‘You don’t think we’re moving too slowly?’ Adora asks, looking a little less lost now they have something to latch onto. Catra doesn’t look away, lest she deprive them of that.

‘Well, it’s…’ She takes a breath, thinking through her next words. ‘We haven’t kissed yet, but that’s okay. That’s fine. ‘Cause, it should be special. You know?’ Adora just looks confused, so Catra continues, her voice breaking a little as the doubt starts to creep in. ‘Our first kiss should be part of a special moment, shouldn’t it? Like, I dunno, on a fancy date or something, maybe we’re dancing or looking at the stars or some shit. I don’t know…’

Catra watches as Adora’s frown deepens as they think through her words.

‘Special…? You don’t get it, do you?’

Catra feels her pulse skyrocket as her anxiety spikes.

Fuck fuck fuck shit shit shit!!

She’s ruined it. She knew she would. She always does, doesn’t she? Catra doesn’t deserve to be happy because she’s just a mangy stray off the street that no one should suffer the misfortune of knowing. Weaver was right. The whole time she was fucking right and Catra was stupid enough to think she could prove the old drow wrong. Stupid. Stupid stupid stupid!!

Adora’s still cuddling that fucking demon plushie, their eyes closed tight as they hug it to their chest. Catra dabs the wetness from her cheeks before Adora looks back at her and notices she’s been crying. Another sign of how fucking worthless and weak she is. She doesn’t deserve someone like Adora. Not really. It was too good to be true. A dream. A fabrication. A lie.

A lie she told herself because she wants nothing more in the world than to just be loved. That’s all. Catra just wants *someone* to care that she exists. She just wants someone to *stay.*

‘You want to wait for a special moment?’ Adora asks, speaking into the plushie and not to her. ‘Well, Catra, that’s the thing. *Every* moment I spend with you is special. Nothing compares. Nothing. I could have a shitty day and then seeing you could make it infinitely brighter. And I know, deep down, I’ve done nothing to deserve you. Not a *fucking* thing. But you’re here. And fuck, I never thought I’d feel this way about someone, not this *strongly.’*

Adora lifts their head, meeting Catra’s tearful eyes with a confident gaze. It softens as they take in the magicat, unaware of the war occurring in her head, and they say the one thing Catra needs to hear.

‘I know I never let myself want anything, but I know that I want *this.* You. I want you to be in my life. I want… I want to let myself love you and not feel like I’m burdening you with that.’

Adora’s eyes widen at Catra’s sharp intake of breath as they realise what they just said. Catra can feel her fur standing on end, her heart trying to beat out of her chest as Adora’s words thunder around her mind at a thousand miles an hour.

‘You love me?’

They’re frozen solid, unmoving as Catra stares at them. She watches as Adora’s eyes widen in shock, as their lips tremble, as they crumble before her. Adora looks like someone who’s just realised they’ve ruined something precious. But that’s *wrong* . Adora could never do such a thing. Catra has to show them. She has to let them know that it’s okay.

She can’t say it back, not yet, but she can *show them* .

One hand in front of the other, Catra crawls the short distance over to Adora. She raises up onto her knees so Adora’s forced to look up at her. She cradles Adora’s face in her hands, running her fingers over their cheeks to collect their tears. Adora’s eyes are still so fearful, so scared. Well, Catra can’t very well allow that now, can she?

‘You love me?’ She asks again, her voice barely a whisper.

There’s a small sound at the back of Adora’s throat, another round of tears falling from their eyes as they blink up at her.

And then they nod.

And Catra kisses them.

At first, nothing happens. Catra just kisses Adora’s closed mouth and pulls back when they don’t meet her. But Catra can see the shift happening behind their eyes. The look in their eyes morphing from fear into surprise and then…

*There* it is: understanding.

Catra hears more than sees Adora drop the plushie off the side of the bed. But she promptly forgets about it as she feels Adora’s hands on her, one on her hip, holding her in place, and the other cupping her face. Their thumb strokes across her cheek as their fingers curl behind her neck, and she lets Adora pull her back down to meet their lips.

The kiss is…

…It’s *everything* .

Catra’s kissing Adora the only way she knows how. It’s the way she’s kissed people in the past, those that left her behind and never came back. She’s trying to pour as much of herself, as much of her love for Adora, into the kiss as she can, but she doesn’t know if it’s doing anything differently. She loved those people she kissed before, after all, and they left anyway. She hopes it’s okay.

But…

They never kissed her the way Adora's kissing her.

Adora's kissing Catra like this is the last time, despite it being the first. They're meeting her perfectly, yet being so gentle and soft, savouring every moment of this, their first kiss. Their *First Kiss!* Catra can feel it. She can *feel* everything Adora's feeling, even with no words said. The care, the love, the *joy* . Adora's desperately trying not to smile while kissing her, she can tell with the way their lips keep pulling back before meeting hers again. Fuck. Catra's never felt any of this from *being* kissed before. It's new. It tells her that Adora feels the same way towards her that she does towards them. Maybe even more, if that's possible. She never wants it to end, but she can feel tears building at the corners of her eyes from the way she isn't *used to this* . It's everything she ever wanted, everything she could have ever hoped for. Adora *loves* her.

The kiss ends with Adora pulling back and giggling, which earns them a confused head tilt from the magicat, who's still somewhere up on cloud nine. Catra thinks she makes an affronted noise with the kiss being broken, but it only serves to make Adora laugh that little bit louder.

When their laughter dies down to gentle hums, they look up at Catra and just whisper, 'Tickles.'

'Wha—' Catra tries to ask what they mean, but she feels it in her voice as she speaks. She's purring. She didn't even realise.

'Your eyes…' Adora whispers, leaning closer. Catra feels her face flood with heat at being perceived, even though Adora can see a lot less in the gloom than she can. 'They're so black.'

Catra swallows.

'Can I—'

'Do you—'

'You go,' Catra concedes, smiling a little at the adorableness of the dork who just gave her the best kiss of her life.

Adora bites their lip, just a little, before they speak again. Catra feels the fur on her arms stand on end when she sees the way they're looking at her, like they want her.

'Do you… You can mark me. If you want to. I want you to.'

Catra's tail thumps the bed behind her.

'Now?'

'Yes, please.'

Catra feels the smirk spread across her face, is only a little disappointed that Adora can't quite see it, and says:

'You want to be mine that badly?'

Adora fucking *whimpers.*

Catra grins and leans forwards to rub her cheek against Adora's and, when her lips ghost Adora's ear, she whispers, 'Mine.'

Adora squeaks. Nods. Their grip on Catra's waist tightening ever so slightly and she continues purring and marking Adora everywhere she can.

Which is when the door to the bedroom opens, the light comes on, and someone sighs behind them.

'Guys, get a room.'

From somewhere, Adora manages to scrape up some bravado, even with a magicat sitting in their lap purring and marking them regardless of what's happening around her.

'We've got a room, *Bow* ,' they say, as if that somehow settles the situation.

'I meant *your* room, Adora. Not *mine.'*

Adora grumbles something about how he never uses the room anyway, and Catra cackles through her purring.

Bow sighs again, and says, 'Food's here.' Before leaving them alone again with the light on and the door open.

Adora's stomach *growls* .

'It's going to be *food* over *me* every time, isn't it?' Catra drawls, leaning back to look Adora in the eye. But they're just kind of staring at her, as if they forgot what she looked like somewhere in the last few minutes. 'What?'

'We kissed.'

It's just a whisper, but Catra feels her face flush bright red anyway.

‘Yeah. What, you just realised?’ Catra teases, speaking more confidently than she feels, basking in the nervous happiness that’s coursing through her entire body.

‘No, I just…’ Adora pauses, their hand coming up to cup Catra’s cheek, their thumb stroking her face like she’s a precious thing, made of glass, delicate. ‘Thank you.’

‘For what, dummy?’

‘I don’t know,’ they say, before planting their hands beside them like they mean to get up. ‘Food?’

Catra smiles, steals a peck from Adora’s lips, and leaps up from the bed, making it to the door in just a couple of strides. Adora, like she expected, is just staring at her, flummoxed and thoroughly caught off guard. Catra blows them a kiss, and walks off towards the smell of hot food, smiling like a lovesick fool.

She is one, though.

Guilty as charged.

Chapter End Notes

no notes at the beginning of this one, didn't want to give *too much* away!

(a whole chapter that spans twenty, maybe thirty minutes within the story? couldn't be me!)

and no, i didn't forget about catra wanting to interrogate adora about what glimmer said, and trust me, neither did catra!

a big thank you to my beta readers, sam, liz, and emilee! without you guys this story would suck just that little bit more <3

# Chapter 10

Chapter Summary

Finally *some* tennis.

Almost an interrogation.

Ungodly amounts of PDA.

Chapter Notes

Hi.

aha.

It's been a minute huh?

I got rid of the chapter count, who knows anymore.

If you've waited however long since the last part, for this part; I love you, you're amazing, and enjoy. <3

See the end of the chapter for more notes

‘Gray!’

Adora’s eyes refocus just in time for them to watch their second serve dump straight into the net before bouncing to the ground and rolling away. Mermista just rolls her eyes at *yet another* double-fault from Adora, looking like she’d love *something* to return before the match is over. Adora looks down at their racquet and checks the strings. There’s nothing wrong, but they make some tiny adjustments anyway.

‘Love-40!’ Coach calls from up atop the umpire chair where she’s been watching their match, no doubt making sure they’re both in shape for the qualifiers, which are *soon.* ‘Gray!’ she shouts again, and Adora cringes at the call-out, knowing that they’re in the wrong. ‘What the hell are you doing?! Get your head in the game, or go home! ’

It’s a baseless threat. Adora knows they’re one of Huntara’s best players, and she’d never send one of them home this close to the EUT nationals, but it still stings deep down. They’re mis-hitting, making unforced errors, *double-faulting* . Their second serve is usually perfect, even if they add a little more pace or place it closer to the corners . These incessant double-faults sting but…

But three days ago, Catra kissed them for the first time and they can’t get the feeling out of their head, or off of their lips. If they're being honest with themself, they kind of don't want to, not until they can do it again , at least. And they *really* want to do it again.

‘Sorry, Coach!’ they call back, returning to their backcourt to make yet another serve that Mermista will, no doubt, easily return. She’s a skilled player, having played for several years before joining the Krytis U team.They can’t afford to be distracted when they play against her. If Mermista converts any of the next three break points, she’ll serve for the set, so Adora will likely lose this practice match.

And all because of a girl.

Adora doesn't fight the smile that spreads across their face at the cliché of it all.

'Something funny?' Mermista calls from behind the net, opposite Adora on her side of the court.

Adora shakes their head. 'Just thinking about how I'm going to lay down five aces in a row to win this game.'

Mermista barks a laugh and readies herself to receive. 'Just you try it, Gray. We'll see who's laughing after I completely and utterly destroy you.'

'I'd like to see you—'

Adora throws the ball up into the air and leaps off the ground to smash it over the net in a serve fueled by their competitiveness, a spark of adrenaline, and the mental image of heterochromatic eyes shining in the gloom like beacons.

'—try!'

***

'So,' Mermista starts, leaning against the locker next to Adora's. They've been trying to find their shampoo among the mass of clothes thrown in there haphazardly for a couple of minutes already. 'What's on your mind?'

Adora just pauses and looks at Mermista in a way that they hope communicates: *"huh?"* .

She groans. *'Maybe* I like a little challenge. You crumbled out there faster than Hawk does when I threaten the safety of his moustache. It's no fun beating you if you make it easy. Spill.'

'I'd rather not talk about it,' Adora mumbles, only slightly aware of the frustration slowly building the longer they can't find their bottle of shampoo.

'Whatever,' Mermista huffs, 'I've got spare soaps if you need them.'

Adora's eyes light up, 'Really?'

‘Sure,’ she smiles, but Adora doesn’t trust it, ‘I trade only in things people would rather not talk about.’

This time, it’s Adora who groans.

‘Look,’ Mermista drops the smirk, turning to lean her back against the locker, staring off at the opposite wall. ‘If you don’t want to say, it’s whatever. I won’t ask. But if someone’s giving you shit, you better tell me. Especially is it’s that Isla chick—’

‘It’s not Isla.’

‘Good. If it was, I’d punch her.’

‘Oh yeah?’

‘Yeah. What else are friends for?’

Adora pauses. They turn to look at Mermista, only to find her completely ignoring them and not returning the stunned expression that no doubt paints their face as this entirely new piece of information is revealed to them. ‘We’re friends?’

‘Uh, duh? Why else would I be talking to you right now? You think I offer my soap to just anyone?’ Adora almost laughs at the indignant expression Mermista’s pulling, but they’re just too stunned to speak.

‘I… guess not,’ Adora says quietly, turning back to their locker when Mermista starts undressing, shimmying out of the purple and white pleated tennis skirt and letting it fall to the floor. Their eyes fix on the binder in their locker, neatly folded and ready for them to wear once they’ve showered. Catra made them promise not to wear it while they played. Adora’s thankful for it, really. They know that if they had worn it they would have had to work harder to breathe and all the movement could have caused it to rub against them again.

Mermista finishes changing while Adora steadfastly stares into their locker. Normally, they would also be changed by now, but something is rooting them to the spot until Mermista can’t see them anymore. They listen as the slaps of Mermista’s bare feet recede towards the showers, and they turn just in time to see her round the corner, her teal-green towel wrapped around her body.

There, left on the bench behind them, is a solitary, unopened bottle of shampoo.

***

Adora and Mermista leave the locker room together after showering and freshening themselves up, barely a word spoken between them at all. Adora doesn’t normally mind silences. After all, they’ve spent a good amount of time with Catra where they just… haven’t said anything. Haven’t needed to. Content with just existing around each other in the moment. But Mermista isn’t Catra, and her silences definitely don’t mean the same thing. This silence is the brooding kind, the plotting kind, the *“there’s something you avoided telling me before and I’m working out how to get it out of you”* kind.

Adora takes the plunge before Mermista comes up with a way to get them to say it anyway.

‘I have a girlfriend.’

They watch Mermista’s face which, unbelievably, remains neutral for about fifteen seconds until finally a small smirk appears. She doesn’t say anything. They just keep walking next to each other, opening doors and avoiding other students until they finally reach the exit and—

‘My sweet *Mermiiiiiiistaaaaaa* !’

—walk straight past Charles Hawk, who’s leaning against the wall beside the entrance to the tennis courts. He scrambles to catch up when Mermista doesn’t wait for him or even so much as spare a glance in his direction. Adora tries to slow down to wait for him but Mermista just places a hand on the small of their back and keeps them in step with her.

‘Don’t stop. Keep moving. Don’t even look at him,’ she mumbles under her breath, picking up their pace enough that he has to jog to catch up.

Eventually, he acquiesces, dutifully falling into step behind the tennis players. Their pace slows only once Mermista is content with Hawk’s distance and is sure he won’t try to gain any ground on them in an attempt to catch up.

‘Why can’t he walk with us?’ Adora asks, quitely, leaning into Mermista a little as they do.

Mermista just scoffs and yells, ‘Because he doesn’t know the meaning of personal space!’

Adora cringes, but they don’t look back.

‘Oh, but my sweet! How I long to hear you, once more, demand no space between us during the passionate fire of—!’

‘ENOUGH!’

Mermista’s thunderous bark makes Adora actually jump, completely taking them by surprise. Mermista snorts at them, and leads their little group toward one of the picnic benches on a nearby green. There’s seven benches in total, arranged in a wide circle around a towering, ancient oak.

Adora doesn’t really get a choice of where to sit, but they don’t mind as long as the sun isn’t in their eyes. Charlie, however, follows the line of Mermista’s finger to a spot two benches away from their own. He seems perfectly happy with this result, no doubt elated that Mermista is allowing him to stay around at all.

‘That’s Charlie Hawk, right?’ Adora asks after a moment, fiddling with the zipper on their Krytis University branded hoodie.

Mermista is more outspoken in her choice of post-tennis attire. Her outfit consists of denim booty-shorts over fishnet tights, and a blue mesh crop top over a deep purple sports bra.

Adora wonders if Mermista can predict the weather or something, because she isn’t carrying a bag or anything that would suggest she brought a change of clothes. What if it had rained?

But as Adora asks the question about the identity of Mermista’s thrall-apparent, they look over to see him clutching a raincoat and umbrella in his arms. *Oh,* they think, *he was the backup plan* .

‘Unfortunately,’ comes Mermista’s response, accompanied by an eye-roll. ‘He won’t leave me alone.’

Adora would think Mermista’s hostility was genuine, but the sparkle in her eye and the slight tug at the corner of her mouth gives her away. It reminds Adora of all the times Catra proves just how much of a little shit she can be, and all the ways Adora has learnt to read that on her.

‘He’s on the rowing team, right?’ Adora asks, because that’s the only place they know him from. They’ve seen his name and face around, on posters advertising the sport to freshers looking for a club to join. Though those tend to refer to him as “Sea Hawk” as part of some marketing gimmick.

‘Ugh! Don’t remind me! I have to go watch his stupid practice because he came to mine.’ Mermista looks away as she says it, away from Sea Hawk, but he must hear her because he perks up and almost breaks his face with the width of his grin. ‘But we’re not here to talk about me—’

‘We’re not?’

‘No– we’re *here* to talk about *you.* You said you’ve got a girlfriend and honestly? It’s the most interesting thing anyone has said to me in *days* . Tell me about her.’ Mermista leans forward slowly as she speaks, until she’s almost halfway across the picnic table, staring Adora down with a mischievous smile peeking through her otherwise uninterested facade.

‘Oh… Um. Uh—’ Adora doesn’t like being put on the spot, and under Mermista’s analytic eye they forget everything. No thoughts. That is, until their phone buzzes in their pocket, and they check it eagerly, desperate for an escape from this unexpected dive into their private life.

**1 new message**

*hey! where are you?*

Adora sighs in relief. They almost forgot that they’d agreed to this a few days ago, and it couldn’t have happened at a better time.

*Just finished practice, where are you? I'll come meet you!*

*okay!*
*i'm outside the library. i just grabbed some books.*
*we could go back in if you wanted..*
*but I kind of want a change of scenery?*

Adora sighs a little, looking up to see what Mermista is up to. Apparently, she's lost interest, already buried within whichever social media app she's trying to dominate this time. Adora's heard in passing about how Mermista has tried various apps, but is struggling to find the one that's *"right for her"* . She'll know it when she sees it. She said so herself.

Seeing that Mermista is occupying herself does fill Adora with a sense of relief, though. They know they would have felt guilty if she was just sitting waiting for them to finish on their phone before returning to the grilling about their girlfriend. So, knowing that they aren't wasting Mermista's time by texting someone else out of the blue, they return to the message they've now opened.

*adora?*
*hellllooooooo???*

*Hi! Sorry*
*We can go somewhere else!*
*Where did you have in mind?*
*Actually, nevermind, let me come meet you first*
*Then you can just show me lol*

*lmao*
*see you soon x*

They pocket their phone at that, and start to stand. Mermista glances up as they move, watching them extract themselves from the picnic bench. She has an expression on her face that could be read as something close to sadness at her friend leaving her, but Adora suspects it has more to do with her last line of defence between her and Hawk upping and leaving.

Adora hopes so, anyway, they'd hate it if Mermista actually *was* upset that they're leaving.

'I've got to go meet a friend,' Adora supplies by way of explanation.

Mermista just nods. 'I figured. You better be prepared to tell me about your girlfriend though, Gray. Or I'll be forced to resort to more *mysterious* methods of intel gathering.'

'You'll stalk me online?'

‘I’ll stalk you online.’

Adora laughs at that, turning to leave. ‘See you at the next practice, Merms!’

‘It’s not much of a practice if I wipe the floor with you!’ Mermista calls back.

That’s the kind of relationship they like to have with Mermista, the competitive type where they could literally say anything to each other and it would be seen as a challenge. Actually, Adora hopes they never come into contact with Mermista outside of tennis, because they don’t think they could stop themselves from rising to Mermista’s challenges.

Catra hasn’t really seen that side of them either, the Adora who will do anything to come out on top. Sure, they’ve been buried a little recently by the cloud of love that’s fogged up their mind, but once Adora’s back on their feet, they vow to not go easy on *anybody.* Unless there’s people trying out for the tennis club, in which case…

Adora waves to… Charlie? Sea? Hawk as they leave, which seems to cause him to perk up excitedly. He waves back before glancing over to Mermista and launching to his feet, cannon-balling himself toward her picnic bench. Adora keeps watching for long enough to see Mermista roll her eyes, facepalm, and then they catch the beginning of a death stare that, as they turn around and hasten their pace, they can feel steadily burning through the back of their head.

The Krytis University campus is fairly large, considering the city isn’t all that big. Eternia is a much larger city, but their Uni’s campus, by comparison, is maybe half the size. There’s a plaque attached to one of the walls just inside the campus library’s entrance that talks about this University in particular, Krytis U, being chosen by many a scholar in the past as their place of learning, where they chose to deepen their understanding of their respective subjects. All so they could write paper after paper that the students of today spend half of their free time referencing in papers of their own.

Because of this, a lot of the buildings are fairly old. They’ve been well-maintained though, and a few newer science blocks that look like something out of a sci-fi novel became recent additions just before Adora joined as a fresher almost two years ago. It’s a collage of classical and modern architecture. Adora supposes that the architecture students here will no doubt spend some of their time analysing the buildings around the campus. It’s almost like a map of Krytis’ architectural history, after all, and it seems like something they would have to do. The modernity of the newer Medical Science building versus the old, converted factory that now houses the extensive archive of the Krytis U Library. Metal and concrete, bricks and mortar… Better them than Adora, though, they wouldn’t know where to start with that kind of thing.

‘Adora! *Adora* !’

They’re broken from their wandering thoughts by a voice calling them. They’ve made it to outside the library, and a quick glance around reveals the source of the voice.

Starla runs toward them, a huge smile on her face and voluminous, chestnut hair billowing despite the lack of any wind.

Adora waves a little awkwardly as the girl approaches, not quite sure what else to do with their hands other than stick them in their pockets, which they do after the wave.

The sun is high and bright considering the time of day, and Starla is still wearing her tennis cap to keep it out of her eyes, the purple and white contrasting against her hair and skin. She comes to a jumping stop just before Adora, beaming at them, before grabbing their arm and whisking them away in the direction of somewhere off campus.

It started with Adora just messaging Starla to thank her for all the help with the whole Isla thing. Without her there to give direct accounts of everything Isla's said to Adora's face, and everything she's said behind their back, Adora isn't sure that anything would have actually been done about the hate they've been receiving just for existing. Coach said that it's being handled, and Adora hasn't seen Isla since, so they think she was temporarily suspended, at least. The problem is, Isla is as good a tennis player as she is a student, which is to say, *exceptional.* So, Adora doesn't believe the Uni would fully suspend her permanently.

Only when Adora hears the jangle of a bell, and the bustle of life in close proximity to them, do they realise that Starla has almost definitely been talking their ear off the whole way here and they didn't listen to a word of it. Apologising now would be even more awkward though, so they just smile and nod when Starla asks if this place will do. Starla's still talking as they sit down, something about her siblings taking up laser tag recently, which doesn't sound all that bad to Adora. They think they'd like to try it at some point, but they wouldn't want to play it with random people. On the other hand, they don't really know enough people to justify booking an entire space to themselves.

'—and I'm happy they're enjoying themselves and having fun but I do miss them when they're out and leave me at home.'

'Why not join them?' Adora asks, trying to ignore a new, nagging poke at the back of their mind.

'I'm not really sure it's for me. Tallstar gets way too into it, you know? She starts talking strategy and everything. I think I would just want to run around and not worry about *flanking* or *stealth.* ' Starla picks up a menu, looking at the front briefly before opening it up to browse inside. Unfortunately, this gives Adora a perfect view of the logo on the front of the menu.

They give into the tug pulling at them and look over to the counter, only to be met with the scariest fucking glare they've ever seen in their life.

Catra. This is her cafe. Starla brought Adora to Bright Moon Coffee Co. to study. How many times has Adora been in here now? This is what they get for getting lost in their thoughts and not paying attention to both Starla and where she was taking them.

Adora tears their gaze away from their girlfriend and looks back at the girl in front of them. They aren't completely oblivious, they know how this must look, but they hope Catra trusts them enough to not jump to any conclusions.

'What do you think, Adora? A sandwich or a slice of cake?' Starla asks, looking up at them with a quizzical smile.

Adora blinks and says, 'Sandwich.' Which, for some reason, makes Starla smile wider.

'Okay,' she says, holding out the menu for Adora to take, 'And what would you like, Adora?'

'Just a coffee,' they reply and, with another glance over at Catra who's busy on the coffee machine, 'Black coffee.'

Starla laughs a little incredulously, as if she must think Adora's joking. She must realise that Adora's being serious though, because she stands, puts the menu back on its holder, and walks toward the counter to order. Adora didn't even have a chance to protest, or to offer to place the order themself, so they just sort of sit and watch while fighting the urge to chew their nails.

They look for Catra, but they can't see her anywhere and that nagging pull is still at the back of their mind, like they're being watched but they don't know where from—

**1 New Message**

Their phone buzzes with a message notification. Adora can see the name on their lockscreen, but to view the message they have to unlock the phone. They lift it up so the facial recognition kicks in and…

*:)*

Catra's pissed. This is the only explanation.

'Hey, Adora.'

Adora actually jumps up off of their seat by about three whole centimetres, a small squeak sounding in the back of their throat by Catra's sudden appearance right behind them. They practically slam their phone back down on the table and freeze. Now that they know she's there, Adora can't help but focus on the warmth by their right ear, or how dangerous it feels to have Catra so close but unseen. The girl is intimidating when she wants to be, even though Adora knows what sounds she makes when her ears are stroked. They close their eyes, swallow, and whisper in return, 'Hey, Catra. How's your shift going?'

Catra hums, deep and low. It sort of turns into a purr towards the end, and Adora wants nothing more than to cuddle up with their girlfriend and let Catra nap on them.

'Stale,' she says, her hands coming up to rest on Adora's shoulders from behind, 'Until my partner walked in holding hands with some tennis chick.'

Adora actually giggles—Catra's jealous!—and drums their hands against their thighs. 'We were not holding hands, she practically dragged me here.'

'Well you may not realise it, you dork, but she definitely likes you. I can smell it.'

Adora scoffs. 'That's what you say about everything. There is no way you can smell that.'

They can *feel* Catra smirking behind them. 'Can too. How would you know what I can and can't smell?'

Claws dig into Adora's collar, and they have to hold their breath to stop any obvious reactions. Which, they realise, is kind of an obvious reaction. They relax when Catra leans forwards, pressing herself against them as much as she can from behind Adora's chair and wraps her arms around them. Adora almost coos when they hear the soft rumble vibrating from Catra's throat as she smushes their cheeks together.

‘You’re so *cute* ,’ Adora coos, giving in easily to the need to call Catra cute. It’s a fact of life, but it’s one that Adora’s decided their girlfriend needs reminding of as much as possible.

‘Shut *up* ,’ Catra protests, smushing their cheeks harder. It makes Adora giggle, and their hands come up to hold onto Catra’s arms as she hugs them tight.

It’s nice.

Adora feels Catra’s ear twitch against their head before they themself hear Starla stop at their table. They look up at the girl, standing like she’s just been bamboozled by a magician, and smile their best *“I’m sorry I have a girlfriend but also I’m not because she’s adorable”* smile. Starla just silently places Adora’s black coffee down in front of them, then takes her seat opposite. The plate she sets down in front of herself has a diagonally cut ham and cheese topped toastie occupying it. The sight reminds Adora how hungry they are, but they don’t mention it.

Beside them, Catra sniffs the air, her ears twitch. Then, she huffs.

‘You ordered black coffee and no food even though your stomach is growling?’ She asks. Ignoring Starla’s presence completely.

‘Um,’ Adora shifts nervously, feeling Catra’s arms constrict a little tighter. ‘Yes?’

‘Why are you the way that you are?’ Catra growls into Adora’s ear before nipping at it, making Adora squeak and Starla flush scarlet. She lets Adora go, the warmth of her arms vanishing and leaving Adora already missing her touch, before rounding the table. ‘Nope,’ Catra says as she picks up the mug of shadow coffee, then walks away back towards the counter without looking back.

Adora watches her go, their peripheral vision keeping them very aware that Starla’s staring a hole through their forehead.

Starla clears her throat. ‘So—’

‘She’s my girlfriend,’ Adora supplies before she can say another word.

Starla nods, eyes kind of glassy and unfocused. Adora cringes at how they must have accidentally led this girl on for however long. The downside of not publicly flaunting their relationship, probably.

The silence between them gets to Adora eventually, and they fumble out some words that they hope are coherent.

‘Y-you said you picked up some books from the library right?’ They ask. ‘Did you still want to go through them?’

It takes a moment, but eventually Starla blinks and looks down at her untouched toastie on the plate in front of her. ‘Actually,’ she says, ‘I think I’m gonna get this to go. I have to think about, um… Some things. And it might be easier to study in my

dorm, too.'

'Oh,' Adora nods, 'Okay.' And then, for some reason, says, 'Sorry.'

Starla just gets up and slings her backpack on, seemingly moving on autopilot as she picks up her plate again and wanders over to the counter to get her food bagged for takeout. Adora watches, feeling bad despite the voice in their head telling them that it isn't their fault, as Starla retrieves her bagged toastie and gives them a small wave (which they return with a smile) before stepping back out into the Krytis sunshine.

'Did I break your friend?' Catra asks, placing a new mug in front of Adora and sitting in Starla's vacated seat across from them.

Adora releases a long breath, sighing out their feelings before glancing up into those beautiful eyes they fell for a long time ago. They briefly glance at the lips they've kissed too, until they turn into a smirk and Adora has to pick up the mug and sip to pretend like they weren't staring.

'You can stare at my mouth if you want, handsome,' Catra drawls, resting her chin in the palm of her hand as she leans on the table. 'We are kinda going out, last I checked.'

'Just kind of?' Adora returns. They smile at the way Catra's eyes light up to the challenge.

'Well, you have only kissed me once.'

'First off, *you* kissed *me* , and second—'

'Nuh-uh,' Catra interrupts, 'You don't even understand how much you kissing me has rewired my brain.'

Adora frowns, 'What do you mean?'

Catra rolls her eyes. 'Please don't make me say it.'

Anyone that knows Adora at a surface level would probably say that they're pretty tame and easy to get along with. Glimmer would tell anyone curious enough to ask that Adora would *never* do anything not completely vanilla. After all, they never have before, so who can blame her? But the words that flash through Adora's mind would also have Glimmer shrieking from the rooftops that she was, in fact, secretly right all along.

Adora leans forward across the table, and in a voice far lower than they were expecting, croons, 'Are you going to use your words for me, Cat?'

Somehow, Adora manages to keep a straight face as they watch Catra completely crumble at their unexpected choice of words.. Her face flushes red, her ears stand to attention, her tail waves in the air behind her. And Adora will later swear that she heard a little *"mrrp!"* come from their magicat girlfriend. Looking down, Adora also watches as Catra's claws are starting to scratch into the table top. When they look back up, Catra's pupils are blown wide. As dark as they were when they kissed three days ago.

The sight makes Adora swallow, their bravado dissipating under the new feeling of much they just want to kiss Catra right now.

'Can I—'

'Come with me!' Catra jumps up suddenly, grabbing Adora's hand and whisking them away behind the counter toward the staff room, straight past a whooping Scopria and scoffing Lonnie. They've been trying their best just the two of them to manage the lunchtime rush and, by the look in Catra's eye, will have to last a little longer.

Adora just laughs the whole way, happy to be led into the break room and pushed against a wall, their giddiness only silenced when Catra meets them with a welcome intensity that they return as best they can.

Both of them forget about Adora's coffee going cold.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you to everyone who helped me with this chapter.

Especially you, tennis enjoyer <3

# Chapter 11: Chapter 11

Chapter Summary

Adora has a visitor.

Catra extends an invitation.

More PDA.

Chapter Notes

there may be plot inconsistencies, after all it has been over a year since this updated and i have not read the other ten chapters in that time aha

we're running on vibes gang

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"It's waaay too early for this. I need coffee."

Adora rolls their eyes as Glimmer slumps past them toward the kitchen in search of her daily kickstart. They're not sure what time it is, but they've spent most of the morning so far tidying up their shared apartment to make it seem, at the very least, *presentable*.

"Where the fuck is the coffee? Adoraaaaaaa—"

"In the cupboard!" Adora says over their shoulder as they ponder the arrangement on the dining table for perhaps the millionth time.

Behind them, Glimmer groans, and proceeds to open every single cupboard one by one until she finds what she's looking for.

"I'm too tired for you to hide coffee from me, Adora."

"I didn't hide it."

"It was hidden."

"It was *tidied*."

"It lives on the counter."

Adora scoffs. "It does not, you just never put it away."

"Not like you even use it anymore, anyway," Glimmer sing-songs as she flicks the kettle on. "You found another place to get your fix, didn't'ya? Or is it just a Catra addiction that you keep fuelling at my mom's store?"

Adora turns at that, their cheeks glowing just a little redder than a moment before.

"First, it's Scorpia's store, *she* runs the place, *not* Angella. And of course I go there to see Catra, she's my…" Adora doesn't mean to trail off, but there's so much about what Catra is to them now that it's hard to summarise it with a single word.

Glimmer smirks. "Sometimes I forget how gay you are and then you get all wistful about saying the word *girlfriend*."

Adora scoffs again. "I do not!" They protest, but when Glimmer just raises an eyebrow at them, they relent. "Okay, fine, whatever. Call me crazy for falling so hard. But I really think she's the one."

“I’m not calling you crazy,” Glimmer says, “Just very, very gay. I think it’s sweet how much you love her. Really.”

She sounds sincere enough, so Adora decides to drop the burning glare they were firing right at the back of Glimmer’s head.

As if sensing that the coast is clear, Glimmer asks, “What time is he getting here?”

“What time is it now?”

“Almost half past eight.”

Adora thinks for a moment, absently spinning the vase of flowers on the table as they do. “Maybe an hour?” They say, unsure. Adora’s been trying not to check their phone all morning in fear of the string of notifications that no doubt waits for them as their guest slowly zeros in on his destination.

"9:30, then," Glimmer says as she pours hot water into her mug of instant coffee. "You nervous?"

Adora nods, still spinning the vase. "Yeah, I am. I really want this to go well. I just hope he’s supportive. Like, as a minimum."

“I’m sure he will be,” Glimmer says, moving closer to place a comforting hand on Adora's shoulder. "He's your brother, and he loves you. From what I remember, he's a good guy. He'll understand."

Adora takes a deep breath and nods again. "I hope so. It's just hard, you know? It’s already hard telling people something so personal, but this is different. He’s family. We’re twins. I want– *need* him to accept me for who I am."

After sipping her coffee, Glimmer gives Adora's shoulder a reassuring squeeze. "I know it's hard, but I have a feeling it's going to go well. And if it doesn't, well, you've got me, Bow, Catra and the rest of our friends to support you. You're not alone."

Gratitude swells within Adora at the reminder that, yeah, they aren’t alone. They hit the jackpot on friends who make them feel comfortable as they are. "Thanks, Glimmer. That means a lot to me."

Glimmer grins back. "Of course, Adora. Now, come on! We've got an hour to make this place look like at least one respectable adult lives here, and if you spin that vase round again so help me…"

Adora scoffs and feigns offence, but Glimmer just rolls her eyes and wanders back over toward the kitchen to help tidy up. It takes another slight turn of the vase before Adora is actually happy with it. They know that the floral arrangement that Bow said Perfuma left for them is almost identical from all angles, but they need this kind of distraction to stop from overthinking what’s about to happen. Small things like this, just cleaning up the flat to make it presentable, helps to distract Adora and keep them busy. The idea of having everything ready and perfect for when Adam arrives also just makes them feel calm. It will give them one less thing to worry about while they work up the courage to come out to their twin. The person who they spent their entire childhood practically glued to. They want him to see how well they’re doing away from home, away from the family, and that they’re happy.

The most important thing though, is coming out to him. If that goes well, maybe even tell him about their relationship with Catra. Ever since they figured themself out, they’ve wanted to tell him. To hear what he thinks, if he knew or had any idea about this before Adora did. Adam’s a goofball most of the time, but Adora knows that there’s more to him than that. He’s perceptive, clever, and quick. Adora spent a lot of time trying to be like their brother, but now…

Now they just want to be themself.

But there’s always that possibility that it won't go well. Despite everything Adora knows about their twin, there’s always the faintest chance that he’ll react poorly, that he’ll reject their identity and sexuality. Logically, Adora knows that Adam isn’t that kind of person. But Adora’s anxious thoughts don’t often agree with logic or sound reasoning.

Determination swells within them despite all the nerves and anxious thoughts. They can do this. They have to. It’s the right thing to do, the best thing, both for themself and for Adam—for the rest of their family too, really, but Adam feels like the best and safest starting point—and they’re ready to face whatever consequences may come from it, good or bad.

Time, however, likes to chip away at any mental armour Adora builds up. As the minutes tick by, their anxious brain keeps letting in thoughts that they really would rather not have right now. Adam is already on his way, probably almost here, there’s no turning back now. They take deep breaths, trying to calm their racing heart, it kind of works but not as well as they want it to. After all, Adora trying hard not to think about something just makes them think it harder.

Finally, there's a knock at the door. Despite waiting for it all morning, it still makes Adora jump and flail their arms around as if defending themself from an unseen attacker. Relief washes over them as they realise it was just the door, but then the dread builds and Adora can feel their anxiety start to build back up again. After one final deep breath, just for good measure, they steel themself and turn the handle.

"Adora!" Adam greets them exactly how they thought he would, with a beaming smile and a crushing bear-hug. They try to match his exuberance as best they can, but he always was the more violent hugger. It's nice, familiar, and that sets them at ease, their anxiety already beginning to dissipate at the pure safety he makes Adora feel.

After closing the door behind him, however, they remember everything that they have to say, to get out into the open, adding fuel to the fire that was ever so close to being smouldered.

Adora leads the way back through their accommodation to the living area and plants themself down in one of the chairs. They're running on autopilot and can see from Adam's face that he's picking up on their nerves. It's not as if they're doing much to hide their anxiousness, not that they could do that with Adam anyway. He's always been able to read them just as much as they have him. Probably a twin thing.

After a moment, Adam sits nearby on the sofa, and smiles. It's kind, and Adora can already tell that he wants to help as best he can.

"So, how's everything going?" Adam asks, not mentioning Adora's internal panic in an attempt to ease their tension.

They appreciate it, their shoulders already feel less tense. Not that they had even realised their shoulders were tense.

"Things are good," Adora replies, fidgeting with their hands in their lap just to stop themself from tapping their leg or something. "I've been busy with uni work and trying to train for the EUT nationals."

Adora watches the proud smile spread across his face and feels their face heat up in turn. They forgot how much he was interested in and supportive of her progress through tennis.

"That's great, Dorbz," he says, nodding, his proud smile turning shit-eating at the mention of Adora's least favourite nickname of all time. "How's your second serve coming along?"

With how back that nickname flings them, how many memories they have attached to it, and how much they loathe yet apparently missed hearing it, Adora almost forgets to reply. It takes another second to remember what the question was, but as they do, they sigh, their shoulders sagging in apparent defeat. "Honestly, it's been inconsistent lately. There's been… I've been having some trouble focusing on the court."

Adam's cocky smirk is replaced as concern etches itself across his face. "Oh. Is everything okay? You do seem a bit—" Adora's eyes narrow, "—distracted."

When Adora next meets Adam's eyes, there's a determination in them, fighting down their nerves so they can just do this and get it over with. "Yeah," they begin, "There's something I've been wanting to talk to you about. To tell you."

"Okay," Adam says, leaning forward, an encouraging expression on his face. "What's up? What is it?"

"Okay, so…" Adora frowns, their words escaping them. "Well, it's… There's… I've been thinking, like… Ugh." And they spent so long trying to perfect this too. They hide their face behind their hands for a moment before squeezing and dragging their hands back. It grounds them. Adam just looks confused and mildly amused at Adora's fumbling. They roll their eyes. Of course he'd enjoy watching them struggle. "I'm non-binary!"

There. Done. Said it. Whatever. That wasn't hard.

Adam looks blank. "Okay."

There's an awkward moment of silence. Adora squirms. "'Okay?'"

"Yeah," Adam nods, "What, did you want me to disown you? Is that what you wanted to tell me?"

Adora nods.

"Then, okay." Adam smiles, it's bright and annoyingly calming. "Thank you."

His reaction is both expected yet winding.

“What for?”

It’s taking a moment for Adora to catch up.

“For telling me. Glad to know you still trust me this much.”

That all their worrying was for nothing.

“Shut up.”

That Adam is still who they remember him to be.

“Have you told dad yet?”

Ah.

“No.”

“Hmmm.” Adam leans back against the cushions and stares at the ceiling for a moment. Adora has an idea of what he’s contemplating. It’s likely the same thing they’ve been contemplating on and off for months. “I have no idea.”

Adora nods. “Same. I’ve thought about it so much and I just, I have no idea.”

“I mean, he does seem nice.” Adam says with a laugh. Adora rolls their eyes.

Yeah, their dad is nice. He raised both of them pretty much on his own, juggling them and work. Not that their mother wasn’t around. She was just, less Parent and more Manager. All in all, Adora knows that he did the best he could. They trust him. They want to believe that he would accept them with the same casual nonchalance that Adam is capable of, but Randor is unpredictable at the best of times.

Once, when Adora was younger, their poem was picked as the best in the class. They didn’t win a contest or anything, and the poem wasn’t even that good, but Randor’s eyes shone with pride regardless. He bought them a car in celebration. Adora was 7, but still able to reprimand him for buying something they couldn’t even use for about ten years. Randor had just laughed, saying that they’ll grow into it.

Briefly, Adora wonders what happened to that car…

“Is he in town?” Adora asks, without really thinking. Their mouth is doing that thing again where it goes off on its own.

Adam sits forward again and nods. “Yeah, there’s a company thing, that’s why I’m here too.”

To cover their discomfort at the mention of the company, Adora asks, “Have you been to the house?”

“Urh,” Adam puffs air in and out of his cheeks in lieu of answering. Adora deadpans him. “Alright, no, I haven’t. You know how it feels there with no one around but the kooky gardener.”

Yeah, they do, and it’s Adam’s fault for making them believe it. “It’s not actually haunted though.”

“Who told you that?” Adam asks, barely hiding his cheeky smirk.

Adora’s about to retort when a chime dings on their phone. They check it, because that specific chime always draws their attention, no matter what they’re doing.

***Catra*** *9:51*
*how goes the broment*

And they smile.

“Who’s that?”

Adora’s eyes snap up to meet Adam’s.

“No-one.”

Bad idea. Big mistake. Adam’s eyes practically blaze with intent.

So, Adora may have never mentioned having a girlfriend to their twin brother. They are now realising this could have been a lapse in judgement and maybe they should have clued him in earlier.

“Let me see,” he teases.

Adora snorts, “Yeah, like that’s gonna happen.”

Adam stands. Adora mirrors him.

He glances down at their phone. Adora locks it and hides it behind their back.

“It’s been a long time,” he says, “But I will chase you if I have to.”

“I’m still faster,” Adora challenges.

“Enclosed space,” Adam counters.

Adora takes the bait, glances around as if to plan a route, but Adam takes that moment to step forward and reach around them. Adora yelps, manoeuvring their phone out of his reach while stepping the only way they can: up onto the chair. They hold their phone above their head so it’s out of reach and stick out their tongue at their trouble-maker brother.

“You didn’t get very far,” he teases.

Adora shrugs, “Enclosed space. You’d have cornered me eventually.”

“Ahh,” Adam laughs, “Sh-they’re learning.”

He corrects himself instantly and Adora’s heart grows two sizes. It takes considerable effort not to burst into tears on the spot.

“We… Well…” They stammer, trying to find their words. “We’re twins. I know how you think.”

“You still fell for it though, didn’t you?”

“Why do you want my phone?”

“Why won’t you tell me who’s texting you?”

“Because.”

“Uh-huh.”

***Adora*** *9:54*
*yeah, call after he’s gone?*

Adam steps back over to his previous seat and re-acquaints himself with it, holding his hands up in surrender as he goes. “All right then, keep your secrets.”

Adora squints down at him, suspicious of his retreat.

“Whoever it is, they’re obviously important to you,” he explains, “And I’ve met most of your friends. So, ergo, if you’re not telling me who it is, it means I don’t know them yet, and you’re nervous about me knowing who they are and/or meeting them. You want me to like them.”

Adora’s face heats up. Their twin brother just read them like a book. Again. “Whaaat? Nooo…” They slink back down into their seat, keeping their knees up to partially hide their face. “Maybe.”

Annoyingly, Adam’s just smiling in that knowing way, resigned to wait Adora out. “It’s okay if you don’t want to tell me. I do respect your boundaries. But, you know, if this person is important to you then I’ll find out sometime between now and—”

“Catra.”

“—the wedding.”

His head snaps to Adora as soon as they speak. They know he caught what they said.

He leans forward. “Catra?”

Adora nods.

“A girl—?”

Adora nods.

“—friend?”

… Adora nods.

They watch as a shit-eating grin spreads across his face. “Is this the part where I’m supposed to be all, ‘Wow! I didn’t know you’re gay!’, just because you never officially came out to me?”

Adora instantly hides their burning face behind their knees and groans, curling up as much as they physically can.

“Oh, please. You were fawning over girls growing up just as much as I was.”

They hate this. They feel seen. Known.

“And! *And*!” Adam says, already laughing, “You stole my fucking haircut! We’re now *identical* twins!”

While Adam laughs it up, Adora prepares for at least another hour of questioning and being made fun of. Adam can be a lot when he’s giddy, but they still love him, and are so incredibly thankful to have this accepting, open-minded person as their brother.

***

Adora flops down onto their bed about 30 seconds after Adam leaves, their phone already pressed to their ear and ringing. Though the dial tone only rings once before the call is answered.

*“Sup, dork.”*

Catra’s voice immediately calms Adora. They find themself sinking just a little bit further into their bed, their social battery well and truly fried. Well, except for Catra, they always have energy for Catra.

“Hey, you.”

*“How’d it go?”*

“It went okay, I think,” Adora replies, relieved. “You have no idea how nervous I was.”

Catra barks a laugh. *“Um, yes I do. I’ve been dealing with your nervous ass for the past week, remember?”*

She’s right of course. Ever since Adam reached out wanting to visit his ‘sister’ Adora’s felt as if they were in overdrive. Every little thing freaking them more than it probably should. They love Catra just for being able to deal with them like that.

“I literally thought my heart was going to jump out my throat!” Adora retorts.

*“Now you’re just being dramatic,”* Catra says. Adora can hear the smirk. *“But you said it went okay? Does that mean he’s chill? Like, with you?”*

Adora nods to themself. “Yeah. I don’t know. He took it well? I think? He didn’t seem surprised. I kind of blurted it out and he

just said ‘okay’ like it was obvious.”

*“This is the guy who’s known you since birth, Adora. Plus, don’t twins have, like, a psychic connection or some shit?”*

“Oh my stars, so you’re saying he already knew?”

Catra chuckles. *“No, I’m saying he has enough life experience of Adora Gray to have that kind of intuition. Hell, it’s worthy of a CV.”*

“Shut up!” Adora laughs, “That goes for you, too.”

*“Not sure I’m quite on par with your literal womb-buddy.”*

“Eugh,” Adora cringes, “Please don’t call us that.”

*“What? Womb-buddies?”*

“Just never say it again, how’s that?”

*“Make me.”*

Adora has to actually move the phone away from them to process Catra saying those words. It’s bratty, and hot, and Catra’s voice just makes it so much *more*.

Stumped at how to reply, Adora changes the subject in a feat of mental agility that only appears in desperate times such as these.

“I told him about you?”

A pause. *“Was that a question?”*

“No,” Adora says, shaking their head, “I mean, I told him your name. And, you know, that we’re dating.”

*“That we’re what?”*

“Dating.”

*“What are we?”*

“Dating?”

*“Adora.”*

Adora takes a deep breath. “Girlfriend.”

Catra hums, *“What about them?”*

“That you’re mine.”

Another pause. *“I like the sound of that.”*

“Catra!”

The laugh that follows calms Adora’s racing heart. They don’t know why admitting that Catra’s their girlfriend out loud has such an effect on them, but they love how much Catra likes to tease them about it.

*“So Adam knows my name and that you’re my partner?”*

“… Yeah.”

*“Anything else?”*

“No.”

*“Really?”*

“Yeah, he moved on to teasing me pretty quickly about how my taste in women is not a surprise either.”

*“I have to meet this guy.”*

Adora laughs, “You absolutely do not!”

*“I do! Think of all the Adora lore he has in his brain, just going to waste not being put to good use.”*

“Oh, he makes good use of it alright.”

*“Yeah but think of what* I *could do with it.”*

Adora narrows their eyes. “I’m instantly suspicious.”

*“You should be.”*

Adora struggles for a reply. Not in a bad way, just sort of speechless at how they managed to be so lucky to end up with someone like Catra on the other end of this phone call. But, before they have a chance to get too existential about butterflies, dominos and cause and effect, Catra speaks again.

*“I knew he’d be okay with it,”* she says, her voice carrying a little more weight than just a moment before. *“You always think the worst with these things. You should have more faith in your brother.”*

“Yeah, I know,” Adora admits, taking a breath. “It’s just hard. Admitting I’m different—that I’m non-binary—it’s not easy. I just got in my head about how he’d react and what he’d think of me after he knew.”

There’s a beat or two before Catra says anything, and Adora winces. They know what they’ve said but they can’t lie to Catra about anything. The truth just spills from their mouth before they can cover it with something easier.

*“Adora.”*

That’s all it takes. Adora breaks. A couple of tears spill before Adora can catch them. “I know! I know. I’m not different; I’m me. I always have been. I’m just embracing myself. It just feels… I was so scared that he’d hate me but– When I think about who I was before I cut my hair a few months ago, it’s weird. It’s like I was acting at being a girl without even realising it. Like I knew something was wrong but had no frame of reference for how else to be and now I’m just—”

*“Hey.”*

Catra’s voice breaks them out of the spiral.

“Hi.”

*“I love you.”*

Adora laughs, it’s a little wet with all the tears, but in moments like these it doesn’t feel real.

“I love you too.”

Like a dream.

*“Oh!”* Catra yells out all of a sudden, startling Adora. *“I just remembered I have to, uhh…”*

Adora waits as Catra trails off. “Cat? What is it?”

*“It’s fine. I don’t want to interrupt your inner turmoil gender spiral.”*

“Like you haven’t already,” Adora laughs. “Also, bold of you to assume my inner turmoil gender spiral ever ends.”

Adora smiles and sinks a little further into their bed, playing with their hair while they wait for Catra to tell them what she just remembered. They wonder if it might be due a cut soon and, maybe, instead of just a trim, they could even try something else?

After all, they wouldn't want to undercut Catra's expectations.

***

On the other side of town, on the other end of the line, Catra balks. If Adora really is hurting near constantly, then it's something she'll need to bring up again when they're alone together. Preferably when she's laid on top of them so they can't escape when she brings up a difficult topic they don't want to talk about. Like when Catra had to remind Adora that they are, in fact, really hot, and need to careful not to accidentally lead on unsuspecting gays.

*"So what was it?"* Comes Adora's voice through the phone, dragging Catra back to the present and focusing her mind back to the text Scorpia had just sent her a moment before.

She re-reads the text one more time for good measure before moving the phone back to her ear. "So it's this…" Catra begins, trailing off for a moment before sighing and pushing through. "Scorpia planned this team-building exercise for everyone at the shop and she– I was wondering, well, if you'd maybe want to come? *Youdon'thaveto!* I just thought it might be the kind of dumb activity you and your friends would enjoy."

There's a moment of silence on the other end of the line. Catra's gut, despite her best efforts, sinks. Until…

*"What kind of dumb event?"*

Adora sounds interested. Catra can tell that much, it's easy when you know what to listen for. Without thinking, she rolls over onto her belly and burrows a little into the bed, her tail weaving in the air above.

"Laser tag," she says into the sheets. She doesn't know why this feels so embarrassing to ask.

*"Laser tag?"* Adora repeats. Catra's cheeks burn as she hears the grin spreading across her partner's face. *"I'm in. When?"*

"Saturday," Catra replies, emerging from the duvet burrow. "If we're on opposite teams I will destroy you. Scorpia has dragged me to this place hundreds of times. Tennis is your thing, and this is mine."

*"Laser tag is your thing?"*

Catra growls at the teasing tone. "Against my best efforts, yes. Yes it is. I will destroy you."

It's almost infuriating that Catra can just tell Adora's grin gets even wider when they speak next. *"It's a date. Though since I'm walking into a trap, I'm bringing backup."*

"Good, more blood for the blood gods."

Adora laughs, *"I don't think it's an especially bloody spor—"*

Catra hangs up. Annoyingly, she's purring. As much as sharing this part of her life with Adora, the dorky-secretly-likes-her-coworkers part, she's excited to bring Adora into it. Plus, they'll all finally meet each other properly, outside the walls of Bright Moon Coffee Co.

She spreads out on the bed and breathes deep, her phone face down on her chest.

In just a few moments, she'll win. Adora has never outlasted her yet.

*bzzz*

There it is. She grabs her phone and checks the message.

***Adora*** *11:43*
*See you saturday - love you!*

Catra's heart does a summersault.

***Catra*** *11:44*

*love you too*

And then,

***Catra*** *11:44*
*loser*

***

*"Laser Quest",* these are the only words, printed blue in a simple sans-serif on an otherwise empty sign, that give away what this building actually is. It's small. The sign, that is. It's fixed to the wall next to an equally bland white door that looks like it was painted in a hurry. The rest of the warehouse's exterior matches this. It's unassuming, eerie, the kind of place that would be the killer's lair in a horror movie. There are a few windows at ground level but all are painted over or boarded up, letting no light through nor revealing anything from within. The parking lot doesn't help to soothe any doubts that this establishment is actually open to the public either. Obviously in disrepair, with only Glimmer's car and a van populating it. Judging by the level of plant-life overtaking it, this must be the most traffic it's seen in a long time.

"Okay, I'll say it. This is where we die."

Glimmer's face is awash with disdain for the building in front of them. Adora can't blame her, really, if this was any other situation they would never even look twice at a building like this.

"This is definitely the place," Adora nods confidently before trying to subtly double-check the address Catra sent her. They even google 'Laser Quest Krytis' to be absolutely sure. Most of the images that pop up are of the building in front of them, but it looks so much newer, cleaner.

"Just so you guys know," Bow says, slinging his arms around both Glimmer and Adora's shoulders, "It's been an honour to know you, even if it ends with you bringing me to a murder warehouse."

Adora snorts.

"I guess I was just expecting something a bit more… laser-y?" Glimmer says, "Maybe more futuristic, high-tec, awful graphics, you know?"

Adora stands tall. "Catra wouldn't have invited us here if it was a murder house—

"You sure?" Glimmer says, side-eyeing her friend.

—so I say we give it a chance and go in. I bet it looks much nicer on the inside."

"That's the spirit!" Bow says, clapping them both on the back and making Adora jump, "Best Friend Squad, advance!"

Excitement builds in Adora's chest as they approach the entrance. They've played various sports for as long as they can remember, but never anything like this. The thought of playing a game not to win some trophy or advance whichever school's placement in league tables or whatever, but just for fun with friends and Catra, somehow makes them giddy to get started.

After a light shove to the slightly stuck door, Adora pushes it open to reveal exactly what they had been expecting. Neon lights and signs hung along the black walls are the brightest things in the reception area, the ugliest yet best laser-themed carpet Adora has ever walked on lays underfoot, hypno music interspersed with random laser sounds plays from hidden speakers. It's exactly the exuberance that came to mind when they imagined what laser tag would be like and they're delighted, a huge smile immediately spreading across their face. A series of monitors on one wall cycle through various bits of information and high scores, opposite the info wall is the (currently empty) reception desk. And, in the middle of everything, two piercing eyes and a cocky smile shine at Adora through the neon illuminated gloom.

Adora freezes, immediately under Catra's spell. They can't see every detail in the low light of the room, but it certainly seems as though Catra is wearing a tight-fitting black jumpsuit that makes her even hotter. Adora swallows and Catra's ear flicks just as her head tilts with interest.

They're paying too much attention to the way Catra's tongue wets her lips to notice anything else going on around them. Such as the behemoth charging towards them to wrap all three members of the BFS in a crushing hug. It turns out that suddenly having your oxygen cut off will break you out of the spell of a beautiful woman. A yell from somewhere behind the mass of

muscle and chitin currently squeezing the life out of them seems to snap their captor out of it. Scorpia lets them go, retreating to a safe distance while simultaneously apologising for being a hugger and thanking them for coming.

Finally able to take in the rest of the room, Adora also sees Lonnie and Kyle from the coffee shop grimacing at their misfortune as they lean against the farthest wall. It's the kind of grimace that comes from experience, from knowing exactly what that feels like.

"Holy fucking shit," Glimmer wheezes.

"Hey, Adora." Catra is suddenly in front of them, looking slightly concerned, annoyed, and apologetic all in one. "Was starting to think you were gonna stand me up," she smirks, "And did I hear Archer yell 'Advance!' from out there? Do you guys always hype yourselves up before entering a building?"

Glimmer straightens, suddenly completely composed and entirely fine and definitely not still breathing funny. "Only ones that…look like murder…dungeons."

Catra's eyes fall on Glimmer, her smile widening. "It'll only be a murder dungeon when I wipe the floor with you."

Glimmer scoffs and pouts angrily at Catra, which only makes her cackle.

It's adorable.

"And anyway," Catra continues, "I know the owner, she's a little eccentric which tends to drive customers away, especially since she doesn't charge us for playing. All she wants is to watch us shoot each other with lasers for some science-y research or some shit, I don't ask. Who can argue with free lasers?"

Adora nods, that seems reasonable. They've participated in all kinds of things for other student's dissertation research.

A light pops on above the door that Lonnie and Kyle are perched next to, catching everyone's attention.

"Oh my gosh it's ready!" Scorpia squeals, immediately heading through and almost topping Kyle in the process.

Catra turns back to the three of them, but her eyes settle on Adora as she speaks. "I already signed us all up. There's a quick safety talk before the game. You ready, Dor'?"

The last question was said softer, like it was only for them.

Adora smiles and squeezes Catra's hand, linking their fingers together. "Let's kick some butt."

***

The briefing room is much smaller than Adora was expecting. They have clearly spent too much time acclimatising to cavernous lecture theatres within the University and nowhere near enough time frequenting small, local activities who care less for the before or after and instead are all about the during.

What really makes the space cramped though is the rows of open lockers and tables stacked with gear that surround the room. The walls are almost identical to those in the reception, painted black with neon highlights, but the floor seems to be made of a black vinyl instead of continuing the carpet.

Catra and her friends make themselves at home immediately, putting any personal belongings into lockers before helping themselves to the gear set out on the tables.

"Welcome! New subjects! How exciting!"

The shrill voice welcomes Adora & Co. as they stand awkwardly in the middle of the room, catching all three of them off guard. Bow actually yelps and Catra cackles with glee.

It takes a moment, but Adora's eyes eventually land on the figure at the other end of the room who addressed them. Her voice sounded like it came from everywhere at once and, when Adora notices the microphone snaking around the woman's cheek, they realise it did. A wild mane of violet hair punctuates and frames her face. Some of it falls in odd directions at random lengths, giving her the general appearance of someone who cuts their own hair while accidentally touching live wires at the

same time. Her black overalls are emblazoned with *Laser Quest* over the left breast in the same style as the sign next to the door.

Almost as if she's oblivious to the three people standing stock-still in front of her with no idea what's going on, she waits until the others have stopped whatever it is they're doing before saying anything else, bouncing on her toes the entire time. The absolute picture of overwhelming excitement paired with the refined patience of someone familiar with waiting for others.

"Okay!" She yells when all activity dies down, happy that everyone's attention is now on her. "Welcome to Laser Tes– Laser Quest! Since we have some new volunteers I will now efficiently explain some safety information!" Her eyes sparkle with joy, she's clearly in her element. "You can call me Entrapta! I will be monitoring and recording today's experimen– game! The most important thing to remember is to keep your goggles on at all times and do not aim your laser at anyone's face! These steps should provide an eighty percent chance that no one loses sight in one or both of their eyes while participating today!"

Adora takes a quick glance around the room when Entrapta pauses. Bow and Glimmer have never looked more serious, taking in every word. Lonnie yawns.

"Now for some basic conditions that are essential for taking part," Entrapta continues, "No running or climbing on the obstructions! No throwing physical objects! No physical attacks! Lasers should be the only point of contact between yourself and other participants while the experiment is live! Do not enter areas that are marked 'Do Not Enter'!"

Adora wonders if they should be taking note of the way Entrapta is clearly trying to mask some kind of social experiment as a game, but everyone else seems perfectly calm so they brush it off.

"Okay!" Entrapta says, now on the move. "The door will open in three hundred seconds!" She heads out the door they entered and closes it behind her.

"Adora?"

Catra is suddenly next to them. They can't quite make out her expression.

"Everything okay? You need any help?"

They realise the expression is care, mixed with some light concern.

"Maybe?" They reply, "Where do I put my things? What's all this stuff on the tables for?"

Catra chuckles, "Yeah, she always forgets to explain how the actual gear works or how to put it on. It's okay, handsome, I'll show you."

Adora's face burns as Catra leads them by the hand to one of the lockers, opening it for them as if it were a car door, bowing and everything. Behind them, Lonnie and Glimmer fake gag in unison, then grin at each other.

"Oh no," Bow whispers under his breath, "What terrifying alliance did I just see form?"

Glimmer turns to him and backs away, flipping him dual birds. "The winning one."

***

Adrenaline pumps through Adora's veins as they dart through the maze of neon-lit corridors, laser blaster at the ready, searching for their opponents. Catra and Bow are with them making sure no angles are left unchecked, the last thing they need is a pincer attack that takes them all out at once.

Adora was initially quite intimidated at the scale of the actual arena; it was daunting trying to take it all in at once, especially since they didn't know their way around. Despite this, Adora is surprised at how quickly they managed to get their bearings. As it stands, they're about 20 minutes into the game and have only managed to take Kyle out—not that that was difficult, Catra shot him within the first minute—the rest of his team, Lonnie, Scorpia, and Glimmer (traitor), have yet to make an appearance. Even so, Adora feels like they're being watched, like as soon as one of them lets their guard down they're done for. Catra's suggestion that they keep moving so the enemy can't surround them is the only thing that's kept them safe so far, not to mention giving Adora and Bow a speedrun course on memorising the layout of the space.

"Wait," Catra says, tapping Adora on the shoulder. They stop. "I think I hear something."

There's a moment where nothing happens as they wait for Catra to listen. Adora wants to look back at her, but then they always want to look at Catra. They can imagine the face she's making as she concentrates, the furrow of her brow, the way she bites her tongue without knowing she's doing it, the way her ears swivel to pick up even the most minute of sounds—

"There! It's Lonnie!" Catra yells, suddenly darting off to Adora's left and vaulting over a waist-high obstacle like it's nothing.

Adora decides the worst part about being on Catra's team is how distracting and hot she is.

Similarly, Adora decides the best part about being on a team with Catra is how hot and distracting she is.

The remaining humans on team 'Glimmer: Lost But Not Forgotten' who don't have their dexterity ability score maxed out—unlike a certain naturally acrobatic magicat—take a moment longer to actually react to Catra's sudden yell and movement. So much so, that by the time they actually catch up to Catra, they find her standing victoriously next to a fuming Lonnie, who's LED vest is lit up like a christmas tree to show she's been hit.

"Fucking game is rigged," She sneers, pointing at Catra. "How is this fair?"

Catra grins, fangs on show. "You're just too slow, Cadet."

Lonnie actually growls. "Just because Entrapta agreed to give you an arbitrary title doesn't mean—!" She stops and takes a deep breath. "Whatever, I'll get you next time."

She turns and stomps away just as Adora reaches Catra's side. It's quiet, but Adora realises that Catra is, despite grinning like a maniac, purring.

"So what's the title?" Adora asks, a soft smile on their lips.

"Force Captain," Catra says, her voice prideful as she turns her grin on Adora, who melts under the attention way too easily.

"And what does that mean?" Bow asks, appearing next to them.

Catra tuts at him, "Only that I'm the best, arrow boy."

Any further celebration is cut short however, as Scorpia and Glimmer appear behind them out of nowhere, charging with blasters raised; It's the remnants of their opponents, team 'Win Or Die Trying'.

"Traitor!" Glimmer yells, and Bow laughs before ducking behind cover.

"You traitor-ed me first!" Bow yells back, smiling. He returns fire on the enemy, forcing Scorpia and Glimmer to hide behind nearby walls.

Catra grabs Adora's hand and drags them down behind the cover she had vaulted over just moments before, narrowly avoiding a volley of beams from scorpia's larger blaster. It's chaos all around them, Bow yelling and shooting at his girlfriend, Glimmer yelling and shooting at her boyfriend, Scorpia just yelling and firing indiscriminately around the whole area, forcing Catra and Adora to stay hidden behind their only defence. Yet everything fades away when Adora looks at Catra. The determination on her face, laser blaster at the ready, as she waits for a moment to go on the counter-attack.

"Cat," Adora says, "Cat!"

They smile when Catra's eyes meet theirs.

"What's the plan?" They ask, "They've got us pinned down pretty good."

Catra stares at them for a moment, eyes boring into eyes. Then her gaze wanders around their face, taking her time, taking them in, before finally landing on their lips. She grins, a mischievous glint in her eye.

"I've got an idea," She breathes, "Follow my lead."

Without another word, Catra leans in and presses her lips against Adora's, pulling them into a kiss. Adora squeaks in shock, too surprised to react at first, but as Catra's tongue nips out to tangle with their own they find themselves sighing into it, responding eagerly.

Adora doesn't know how long the kiss lasts, but it's bliss, definitely one of their best. Maybe they need to kiss in the heat of battle more often. When they do finally break apart, both of them are panting and breathless. Catra just grins her fanged smile, her pupils dilated and unfocused. Adora's basically just a puddle on the floor at this point, their lips feel swollen and their body hot. They realise they want more. A lot more.

"That was… You're…" Adora pants, their voice barely a whisper.

Catra smiles. "I know, you're not too bad yourself, Cadet."

Adora blushes, but frowns when Catra's gaze shifts to something behind them.

It's Bow, standing there awkwardly with an apologetic smile on his face. The vest he's wearing lit up like fireworks at New Year.

"Avenge me?" He says, meekly.

Adora snorts, "Sorry, Bow, Catra's distraction tactics work a little too well."

"Says you!" Catra says, lightly shoving Adora's shoulder, "You've been distracting me all day."

That makes Adora feel warm inside, their chest swirling with emotion.

"Don't look at me like that," Catra says, "I'll just end up kissing you again and we have a fight to win. Charge on three?"

"A charge?" Adora questions, "Instead of more kissing? Are you crazy?"

"Crazy about you," Catra says, then immediately frowns and cringes. "Oh gross, no, forget I said that, that was awful."

But Adora's smile just shines brighter, their eyes never looking away from the woman in front of her. Everyone's always telling Adora that they wear their emotions on their sleeve, that their face betrays everything they're thinking. They hope that's true right now, because they want more than anything for Catra to know how utterly, completely, hopelessly in love they are.

"It was sweet," They whisper, when they're done fawning over their girlfriend. "Now let's kick some ass."

Catra nods, her face morphing back into that of the Force Captain: fearless laser tag killer. She readies herself to spring over their cover as Adora gets ready to go around it.

"On three," Catra starts.

"One,

two,

three!"

Chapter End Notes

I have marked this story as complete only because I truly see no end in sight. I think in one of my other chapter notes I said there's plot now? Nah, I scrapped that idea. It got too dark and went against what I think this story is about. I don't know if I will revisit this so I won't promise anything, but I also wanted to say thank you for reading. Writing this story helped me figure myself out too. After all, most of Adora's thoughts echoed my own at the time of writing them.

Thank you all for visiting Bright Moon Coffee Co.

End Notes

This was supposed to be a one-shot.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!